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JOURNALISM of COURAGE

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NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 18 PAGES

DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

Happening today

● **ANJIA COURT** will pronounce its judgment in the 2013 Maoist attack in Chhattisgarh's Jhiram Valley, in which several Congress leaders, including former Union Minister V C Shukla, were killed.

● **THE SC WILL HEAR** a plea challenging the validity of a provision of the Income Tax Act that allows political parties to receive cash donations below Rs 2,000.

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY

Some books are free than their authors, some authors are freer than their books.



NATION PAGE 8
KIN OF DALITS KILLED IN 2012 GUJARAT FIRING LINK SUICIDE TO A FATHER'S GRIEF

NEET-PG: POWER CUT HITS TWO JAIPUR CENTRES, RETEST ON SEPT 5; PANEL FORMED



Vasudev and Arjun Pyakurial perform their mother's last rites after failing to find her, in Nepal's Umerkot. TASHI TOBGYAL MORE REPORTS, P.8, 12

'Can't stop looking... not so soon': In Nepal, hope against hope as families search for the missing

Await sign of their relatives, dead or alive



DEVANSH MITTAL TASHI TOBGYAL
EXPRESS IN NEPAL
Betravati, August 30

OVER THE last four days, Lekhnath Adhikari, 43, has travelled hundreds of kilometres

on his uncle's bike. He has been going to almost every search and relief camp, hospital and locality near his native village Betravati, and areas downstream.

Betravati is located in Nuwakot district, north of Kathmandu. It is on the border of Rasuwa district — which was the epicentre of the flash floods. While it usually takes two hours to reach the village, after the floods, it takes roughly four hours. On Wednesday, when

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Govt prepares for mass cremations; toll now 788

Yubaraj Ghimire
Kathmandu, August 30

THE GOVERNMENT of Nepal has decided to go for mass cremations amid a dearth of mortuary facilities in hospitals on one hand and recovery of bodies of flood victims in hundreds, on the other.

A day after 70 bodies were cremated en masse in Chitwan district, the Federal Home Min-

THE EDITORIAL PAGE
AS GLACIERS MELT, PREPARE FOR HIMALAYAN CHALLENGE PAGE 10

istry has decided to do the same in Kathmandu, the hub where bodies of victims of the devastating floods are being brought

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

AMID SHIFTING GEOPOLITICS, WAR IN WEST ASIA

Modi at SCO today, will hold talks with Putin, may meet Xi

Look forward to advancing India's vision for region, says PM ahead of Bishkek gathering

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 30

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi is expected to meet Russian President Vladimir Putin and Chinese President Xi Jinping in the Kyrgyz capital Bishkek Monday where leaders of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation are gathering for a two-day summit amid shifting geopolitics and the conflicts in Ukraine and West Asia.

Modi reached Bishkek from Tashkent Sunday night. This year marks 25 years of the SCO. For India, the Bishkek gathering is a lead-up to the BRICS summit in New Delhi on September 12-13. Both Putin and Xi are expected to attend the summit.

Officials said that while a bilateral meeting with Putin has been slotted, Modi and Xi are expected to meet each other during the summit.

Calling the SCO an "important organisation", Modi said,

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



PM Narendra Modi receives the 'Order of Highest Friendship' from Uzbekistan President Shavkat Mirziyoyev, in Tashkent, Sunday. PTI

Delhi & Tashkent discuss long-term uranium supply to India, upgrade relations

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 30

ELEVATING THEIR ties to a comprehensive strategic partnership, India and Uzbekistan Sunday discussed establishing a framework for long-term supply of uranium to India and set a bilateral trade target of USD \$5 billion by 2030.

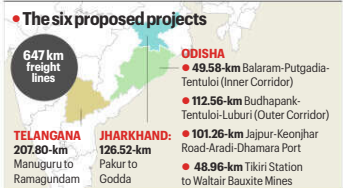
These were the key takeaways after Prime Minister Narendra Modi met Uzbekistan President Shavkat Mirziyoyev

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Expanding footprint
India's engagement with Central Asia has been on the rise. Security cooperation has deepened in the wake of Taliban rule in Afghanistan. India has to deal with China's influence in the strategically vital region, establish connectivity projects and meet its growing energy needs.

In a first, Rlys to build 6 freight lines with pvt firms using highways' hybrid funding model



Dheeraj Mishra & Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, August 30

GIVING A push to private investment in Indian Railways, the Public Private Partnership Appraisal Committee (PPPAC) under the Ministry of Finance, earlier in August, approved six railway lines spanning 647 km along freight corridors. These are to be developed under the Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM) — similar to the model used in the highways sector wherein the government and the private builder split the project costs and risks.

Of the six proposed railway projects, four are in Odisha: 49.58-km Balaram-Putgadla-Tentul (Inner Corridor), 112.56-km Budhapank-Tentul-Luburi (Outer Corridor), 101.26-km Jaipur-Koonjar Road-Araddi-Dhamara Port and 48.96-km Tikri Station to Waltair Bauxite Mines. The other two projects are the 207.80-km Manuguru-Ramagundam line in Telangana and the 126.52-km Pakur-Nagarnabi to Godda line in Jharkhand.

The project will now be sent to the Union Cabinet for final approval, before the bids are invited. This will be the first time

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

FIR AGAINST LoP BASED ON COMPLAINT BY VALMIKI RESIDENT

Kharge 'purification' row: Day after he calls for FIR, Rahul booked in Haldwani

Lalmani Verma
Lucknow, August 30

AN FIR was lodged against Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi in Uttarakhand's Haldwani town on Sunday under sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the SC/ST Act.

The FIR was lodged a day after Gandhi, in a press confer-



Rahul Gandhi called it an act related to untouchability without verification: Complaint

ence in New Delhi, urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to order an FIR over a "shuddhikaran havan" (purification ritual) held at Ramilla Maidan in Haldwani, days after a rally there by Congress president and Dalit leader Mallikarjun Kharge. Calling the act a "crime," Gandhi said that it illustrated the "untouchability" Dalits face

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

For India polymer notes, bidders certify no animal tallow, firewalls against China, Pak

Among bidders is Indian firm in partnership with global banknote major De La Rue

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, August 30

MOVING A step closer to the introduction of low-denomination plastic banknotes in the country, Indian and foreign firms have bid for the supply of polymer substrate sheets with inbuilt security features.

Responding to the global Expression of Interest (EOI) is-

sued by Reserve Bank of India subsidiary Bharatiya Reserve Bank Note Mudran (P) Ltd (BRBNMPL), which set an August 18 deadline, at least two foreign polymer currency manufacturers and an Indian substrate manufacturer in partnership with UK banknote manufacturer De La Rue have placed their bids, The Indian Express has learnt.

Given the sensitivity of future supplies of polymer banknotes, the companies have been made to fill an integrity pact; a confidentiality contract; a no-agent pact and an undertaking that they will firewall their operations in India from those they may have in China and Pakistan.

The bidders have also had to certify that their polymer sub-

strate will not contain any animal tallow content or its DNA for supplies to the BRBNMPL. Controversies over the presence of animal tallow in banknotes in countries like the UK is said to be one of the reasons for the RBI's hesitation over the introduction of polymer currency in India.

In its EOI documents, the

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

NLU DELHI CONVOCATION ADDRESS

Threatening students for asking questions is misuse of power, says Justice Bhuyan

Amal Sheikh
New Delhi, August 30

SUPREME COURT judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan said Sunday that students cannot be threatened with punitive action for expressing a different point of view or asking questions, and called such action "unconstitutional" and a "misuse of power".

Speaking at the 13th Convocation of the LL.M. programmes at National Law University Delhi, Justice Bhuyan said, "In a democracy, the right to question is not an act of defiance. It is an essential expression of citizenship, liberty and constitutional responsibility... When students express a different point of view, when students ask questions, they cannot be threatened. They cannot be threatened with punitive action. That is unconstitutional. That is misuse of power and office."

Earlier this month, the Bar Council of India withdrew a directive issued by its chairman,



Constitutional democracy requires the State to listen to the citizens, the citizens to listen to one another, to have institutions that are accountable and a society that does not treat every dissent as a threat.

JUSTICE UJJAL BHUYAN,
SUPREME COURT JUDGE

Manan Kumar Mishra, asking state bar councils not to enrol graduates of the 2026 batch of NALSAR University of Law.

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● COUNTRY HAS REMOVED LEGAL OBSTACLE TO VOLUNTARY RETURN OF REFUGEES WHO FLED CIVIL WAR WITHOUT VALID PASSPORTS OR THROUGH UNAUTHORISED DEPARTURE POINTS

Lanka beckons, but for refugees in TN, too much time and distance lie in between

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, August 30

FIVE DAYS before his family fled Sri Lanka, men from the Eelam People's Revolutionary Liberation Front arrived looking for boys above the age of 12. Mahendran was 11. His parents hid him, his brother and cousins in the narrow space between the roof and a false ceiling of their home. The children stayed there from morning until 9 at night.

Soon afterwards, the family left home, escaping 15 km to Pelsalai in the Mannar island. Two of Mahendran's cousins travelling in another vehicle were

captured by the LTTE, put into battle with the Sri Lankan army, and died fighting. Mahendran's family waited 15 days on the Mannar island for a boat, surviving on limited food, and dodging the LTTE and the Sri Lankan military.

On the night of July 22, 1990, they finally crossed the Palk Strait, getting off near Dhanushkodi on the Indian shore. The water, Mahendran still remembers, reached above his father's waist as he carried the children to land.

Thirty-six years later, Mahendran lives in Pudukkottai. His father, who was 42 when the family fled, died just seven

years later. Mahendran went to school in Tamil Nadu, studied at Loyola College in Chennai, and now sells furniture on instalments. Ask the 47-year-old where he comes from and his answer is still "Ceylon".

His son and daughter, he says, would answer differently: Tamil Nadu.

That gap between two generations is what Sri Lanka is seeking to bridge, removing this month a longstanding legal obstacle to the voluntary return of refugees who fled the civil war without valid passports or through unauthorised departure points.

As per a Cabinet decision by the Lankan government, re-



A house in one of the refugee camps in Tamil Nadu. EXPRESS

turnees whose Lankan nationality is established can enter through an authorised port after clearance by the State in-

telligence Service. Those cleared will not face prosecution under immigration law merely for having left the

country without authorisation during the war. It applies to all those who left before May 19, 2009, when the civil war ended.

This is a major leap for many refugees. As late as August 2025, four returnees were detained on arrival in Sri Lanka because they had originally left the country illegally.

The Lankan government's new decision has been welcomed by the UN as an important step towards "safe and dignified return" of its people.

But, for the nearly 90,000 Sri Lankan refugees in India, moving back is not an easy decision. More than 58,000 of them live in 103 camps spread across 29 districts of Tamil

Nadu, and another 30,000 outside the camps, with one special camp within the Tiruchirappalli Prison complex.

The long road home

Sri Lanka is a difficult choice even though, more than three decades after many of them arrived in India, they continue to be registered with police and subject to periodic renewals, sometimes weekly. Those living in camps are allowed to leave the premises at 6 am but generally required to be back at 6 pm. There are curbs on travel outside Tamil Nadu.

Says Mahendran: "The important thing is not a warm welcome, but how the government

expects us to live. How do they expect us to survive, how do we buy food there? A friend who returned eight years ago managed to find his feet in Lanka, he says, and the dream of "Ceylon" is always there. But Mahendran can't set aside questions about land, shelter, employment and his children's education.

"Should we go back and start a life from scratch, worse than a refugee life here?... Am I asking for too much? I don't know," he says.

While successive Lankan governments have offered returning refugees resettlement assistance, including with housing and livelihood, the

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• Skywatch



Forecast: August 31, 2026

Partly cloudy sky

MAX: 35-37

2.5°C above normal

MIN: 25-27

1.5°C below normal

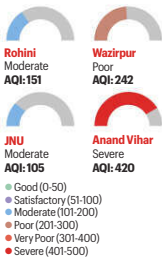
• Sunrise: 5:59 AM (September 1)

• Sunset: 6:45 PM (August 31)

• Moonrise: 7:54 PM (August 31)

• Moonset: 8:47 AM (September 1)

• AQI Tracker



TEACHER SERVED NOTICE, PCO CASE REGISTERED

School attendant held after 'assault' on child

Pragnesh

New Delhi, August 30

AN ATTENDANT at a play school in north-east Delhi was arrested and a teacher was served a notice by the police, after a three-year-old boy was allegedly "assaulted" at the centre, the police said on Sunday.

Police said that a case under relevant sections of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act and the Juvenile Justice Act had been registered against the attendant and the teacher. According to the police, the child has undergone a medico-legal test and a probe is underway.

The police added that the incident came to light on August 16 when the child's parents noticed "bruises" on his arms and face. "On August 16, I saw bruises on his face and arms. Two days later, when he came home, he started vomiting. We took him to an ENT (Ear, Nose, and Throat)

specialist. The doctor said his eyes were swollen. Some tests were run and it was found that his eardrums were damaged," the boy's father told *The Indian Express*.

The father also claimed that once he and his wife approached the school authorities, they allegedly refuted their claims, but "reluctantly agreed to share the CCTV footage".

On August 26, we saw the footage. About 9.45 AM on August 18, he was tied to a chair. He was tied for three hours. He managed to open it... then was beaten up by the attendant. On August 17, he was slapped by the teacher," the child's father said.

The family claimed that even on August 16, when the child was taken for a routine height measurement exercise, he allegedly "punched and slapped unnecessarily." "They were rude to my wife when she confronted them," said the father.

The FIR in the case names

four persons, including the owner of the school and the principal, as the accused.

On August 27, the family got a medico-legal certificate for the child and then got an FIR filed.

"He is so scared that he is not even going to the washroom. He hasn't bathed since we took him out of the school. He refuses to leave his room. When we asked them why they roughed up my child, they said he was 'hyperactive'. Seriously?" said the father.

Delhi police sources, meanwhile, said that they are questioning the attendant, adding that the teacher will be questioned soon. Other school administrators, including the principal, will also be asked to cooperate in the probe.

"What if he had died? I have been shown CCTV recordings for just three days. Have no clue what they did to him before that," the father also said.

The school authorities were unavailable for a comment.

POLICE SAY SEARCH FOR A RELATIVE OF THE VICTIM IS ON

Accused gestured to her, she went as she knew him: Father of six-year-old who was raped and killed in Greater Noida

Pragnesh

New Delhi, August 30

IN A narrow lane in a Greater Noida village, 20-odd men sat on Sunday afternoon.

Among them was the father of a six-year-old girl who was allegedly kidnapped, raped and murdered on Friday by a man the family had known for years. Police had killed the accused in an encounter on Saturday night.

The father, who runs a family-owned business, said he had seen the girl last on Friday afternoon.

"She was playing outside. But when I came out to check on her, she was not there. We searched for her everywhere, but in vain," he said.

Family members and neighbours of the child approached the police on Friday evening.

Officers scanned footage

The accused, a friend of victim's relative, was killed in a police encounter on Saturday

from a CCTV camera near the entrance to the lane in which the child was playing.

Police said they spotted a man, who was later identified as a friend of a relative of the child.

"We saw him in the CCTV footage. *Usne bachchi ko ishara kiya kuchh gali ke baahar se.* (He gestured to the girl from a distance.) He was a familiar face, so she went with him," the girl's father said.

On Saturday morning, police reached the house of the child's relative where the man in the footage lived on rent, an

officer said.

They apprehended him, but they did not know then what had happened to the little girl.

After questioning the suspect, police found the girl's body near a pond in the village in the afternoon.

"They took him to the pond next to farmland. He would still not tell them where he had dumped my daughter's body. Later, he broke down and revealed the exact spot, after which her body was retrieved," the father said, crying.

Police said the accused was questioned after the body was recovered. He allegedly confessed to killing the girl using a knife after raping her, police said.

He hid the body in some shrubs about 6-7 km away, they said.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Central Noida) Shaile

endra Kumar Singh said: "On Saturday night, he was taken to the area [where he had dumped the body] for the second time. The knife he used to kill the girl was recovered from the shrubs at his instance."

"While coming back, he pushed an officer, took out a pistol he had hidden in the bushes there and fired at the police team. One of the officers sustained a gunshot injury. Police fired in retaliation, and the accused was hit by a bullet. He was rushed to a nearby hospital where he was declared dead," DCP Singh said.

A police officer said that the accused sustained the injury in his chest, which proved fatal. The injured police officer is under treatment, police said.

Talking about the victim's relative, a police officer said, "We are still looking for him... His role is yet to be ascertained."

IIT-D students pause protest, cite progress on their demands

Sophiya Mathew

New Delhi, August 30

STUDENTS at IIT Delhi, who have been protesting for a week over the alleged suicide of 31-year-old MSc Physics student Rishikesh Kumar on August 22, announced a pause in their on-ground mobilisation on Sunday, citing progress on their key demands, including the constitution of an external inquiry committee to probe the circumstances leading to his death.

The decision comes amid Kumar's mother, Asha Poddar, declining any financial compensation, which had been one of the primary demands of the protesters. Instead, she has asked the institute to look into creating residential facilities for students navigating mental health issues. This follows concerns raised by the family over Kumar's access to hostel accommodation, including allegations that he was told there was no provision for "such children" to stay there.

Compensation had been a point of contention during the protests, with students demanding that Rs 1 crore be provided to Poddar. The administration had proposed a formula comprising Rs 6 lakh from its Benevolent Fund, reimbursement of medical expenses, and additional funds to be raised through voluntary contributions from the institute's alumni and employee network.

Poddar, however, declined monetary compensation and instead asked the administration to consider assigning living quarters, or a section of living quarters, for students navigating mental health issues, so that no student in need would be removed from campus.

IIT Delhi Director Rangan Banerjee said he would look into Poddar's proposal, sources said. He also said the institute would explore how Kumar's memory could be commemorated on campus, according to the students' statement.



The protest was being held over the alleged suicide of an MSc Physics student. FILE

The proposal assumes significance as hostel accommodation at IIT Delhi is available to less than 50 per cent of the student population, with preference given to undergraduate students. While the institute has provided ground-floor rooms for students with disabilities, it lacks dedicated residential facilities for students requiring sustained mental health or psychiatric support.

In her police complaint on August 22, Poddar said the IIT Delhi administration did not allow her son a hostel room and that he was humiliated by the institute's Dean. She said Kumar was told there was no provision for "such children" to stay in the hostel, and that the incident left him deeply distressed. She urged the police to investigate whether these circumstances were linked to his death.

The students said they would leave the matter of compensation between Kumar's family and the IIT Delhi administration, and would support whatever decision the family reached.

Earlier this week, IIT Delhi Director Rangan Banerjee had also warned protesting students of disciplinary action, saying the situation had "escalated significantly" on the night of August 27.

In his August 28 communication to students, Banerjee alleged that between 10.30 pm and 12.30 am, protesters had extended their agitation into campus residential zones and

used "unsavoury, humiliating and threatening language" in slogans outside faculty housing.

In a statement on Sunday, students said the demonstrations were confined to main transit roads and that they did not enter residential hostel premises. The students added that they had also consciously decided against marching near Kailash and Himadri hostels, citing concerns over the privacy and safety of women students.

Further, they said their slogans were limited to appeals for institutional accountability and community support. According to the students, protesters did not attempt to enter residential blocks or hostels.

The students also alleged that they faced "disproportionate surveillance and police presence" during the protests. They alleged that Delhi Police personnel entered the campus in civilian clothes without authorisation from the IIT Delhi administration.

On the demand for resignations of senior officials, the administration said new appointments had already been made following the previous appointments' tenures, while the inquiry committee would examine their roles in the alleged lapses.

100 acres of land reclaimed as city removes 2.16 metric tonnes of landfill waste, says CM

Express News Service

New Delhi, August 30

THE DELHI government on Sunday said that over 100 acres of land has been reclaimed at the Okhla, Bhalasa and Ghazipur landfills after 2.16 crore metric tonnes of waste has been removed.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said that so far, around 70 lakh metric tonnes of waste has been processed at Okhla, leading to the reclamation of 35 acres of land. She said that at Bhalasa, the quantity of waste processed is around 102 lakh metric tonnes and 45 acres of land has been reclaimed. The numbers at Ghazipur stand at around 44 lakh metric tonnes of waste and 20 acres of land reclaimed.

This comes in the backdrop of civic authorities in Delhi setting up a timeline to clear legacy waste piled up over decades at landfills in the Capital. The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has set a goal of clearing the Okhla and Bhalasa landfills by December this year, and the Ghazipur landfill - the largest in the city - by December next year.

Speaking at a press conference on Sunday, Gupta said that the inert material being recovered after processing the waste is being put to use.



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday. X/@GUPTA, REKHA

"It has been used for filling low-lying areas and preparing the base beneath roads. This has ensured not only the scientific processing of waste but also the utilisation of material recovered

through the process. The government's working model is not limited to addressing the problem at hand but also involves planning in advance for future requirements," she said.

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NOTICE TO THE SHAREHOLDERS OF 54th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING
NOTICE is hereby given that the 54th Annual General Meeting (54th AGM) of the members of General Insurance Corporation of India will be held on **Monday, 21st September 2026 at 3.00 p.m. (IST)** through Video Conferencing (VC)/Other Audio Visual Means (OAVM) to transact business, as set out in the Notice of the 54th AGM being sent through email.

In compliance with applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and the rules notified thereunder and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirement) Regulations, 2015, read with all applicable circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) and the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI"), the Corporation has decided to convene its 54th AGM through VC/OAVM and members can participate through VC/OAVM.

The Notice of the 54th AGM alongwith the Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26 is being sent only by electronic mode to those members whose email addresses are registered with the Depositories/Corporation Registrar & Transfer Agent (RTA) in accordance with the Circulars issued by MCA and SEBI. Members may note that the notice of the AGM and the Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 will also be available on the Corporation's website www.gic.co.in and websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com respectively. A letter providing the web-link for accessing the Annual Report will be sent to the Members whose email-id is not registered with the Depositories/Corporation Registrar & Transfer Agent (RTA). The Physical copy of the Annual Report shall be sent to the Members on specific request. Members can attend and participate in the AGM through Video Conferencing/Other Audio Visual means (VC/OAVM) facility only. The instructions for joining the AGM are provided in the Notice of the AGM. Members attending the AGM through VC/OAVM shall be counted for the purpose of reckoning the quorum under Section 103 of the Companies Act, 2013.

The Corporation is providing remote e-voting facility ('remote e-voting') to all its members to cast their votes on all the resolutions set out in the Notice of the AGM. Additionally, the Corporation is providing the facility of voting through e-voting system during the AGM (e-voting). The Corporation has engaged the services of National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL) for facilitating participation by the Members at the AGM through VC/OAVM including remote e-voting-e-voting. Detailed procedure for 'remote e-voting-e-voting' is provided in the Notice of the AGM.

Members who have not yet registered their email addresses are requested to register the same with their DPs in case the shares are held by them in electronic form and with M/s KFin Technologies Limited in case the shares are held by them in physical form.

In view of the SEBI mandate for payment of Dividend only in electronic mode, Members are requested to update their KYC including bank details with their DPs in case the shares are held by them in electronic form and with M/s KFin Technologies Limited in case the shares are held by them in physical form for timely receipt of dividend.

For General Insurance Corporation of India
Sd/-
(Satish Kumar)
Company Secretary

Place: Mumbai
Dated: 30.08.2026



Pinak Ranjan Chakravarty
Former Indian High Commissioner to Bangladesh

In conversation with



Shubhajit Roy
Diplomatic Editor, The Indian Express

How much does Sheikh Hasina's shadow impact ties?

How does PM Tarique Rahman look at the current situation?

How can India and Bangladesh reset and repair ties?

Should India be worried about the security situation in Bangladesh?

Can Delhi and Dhaka work on economic and development projects?

How do China and Pakistan view and influence the current situation in Bangladesh?

02 Sept 2026, 6:00 PM

Join us on **Zoom**

The Indian EXPRESS
JOURNALISM OF COURAGE



Scan to Register



A section on the second floor of Delhi State Cancer Institute lying in ruins. TABSHIR SHAMS

THE STACK of medical files Sabra carried in her worn maroon *jhola* was thick enough to tell the story of the past five years of her life: four surgeries, chemotherapy, scans, prescriptions and bills.

Sabra, 48, from Jaffrabad, came to Delhi State Cancer Institute (DSCI) expecting free treatment. Her husband drives an e-rickshaw and earns about Rs 20,000 a month, making the Delhi government's largest cancer facility, the family's only realistic option. Instead, she says, she has spent over Rs 12 lakh over the past two years on trastuzumab, a cancer drug she now buys from outside for Rs 4,000 to Rs 5,000 a month.

Then there are the tests. In July, a PET-CT scan cost her Rs 12,000 at a private diagnostic centre. "The testing was also done here before; now, for most tests, they refer us outside," she said.

Before her diagnosis, Sabra worked as a tailor in Jaffrabad. She first noticed a lump in her breast five years ago and has since undergone four surgeries, the latest in January 2025, and continues to receive chemotherapy. For her, the treatment has become a question of how long her family can afford to pay. "Till my husband supports me," she said, sitting in the hospital's waiting area on the first floor, if he refuses to spend money on a dying woman, I'll have nowhere to go."

A floor above, a 42-year-old corporate-sector employee moved between the hospital's private wards and an unfinished section that had been intended to house more of them. Construction had stopped, leaving part of the floor abandoned.

His father had been in the intensive care unit for 12 days. The family had already spent more than Rs 4 lakh, he said. His father was

DELHI'S CANCER CARE CRISIS

At Delhi State Cancer Institute, expensive equipment lies unused amid staff shortages. **TABSHIR SHAMS** and **SOHINI GHOSH** report on how this is pushing patients into mounting out-of-pocket expenses and delays in care

• CANCER-CARE EQUIPMENT: CRORES SPENT, MACHINES UNUSED

Equipment	Cost	Current status	What it is used for	Cost in private sector
Dual-head Gamma Camera + SPECT	₹11 crore	Unused; under evaluation	Advanced imaging, treatment monitoring, radiation therapy simulation	₹8,000-25,000 per test
PET-CT Scanner	₹21 crore	Unused; under evaluation	Cancer detection, staging, treatment monitoring and response assessment	₹8,000-24,000 per scan
PET Cyclotron	₹15.42 crore+	Unused; manpower shortage	Produces short-lived radioactive isotopes for PET diagnosis/treatment	—
DNA/RNA Extractor	₹30.90 lakh	Non-functional; awaiting repair directions	Extracts genetic material for PCR, sequencing and cancer mutation testing	₹20,000 per cancer panel
Dual Photon Energy Linear Accelerator	₹9.2 crore	Non-functional since 2020	Delivers high-power X-rays to target cancer cells while sparing healthy tissue	₹2-3 lakh per treatment course

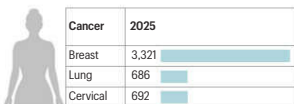
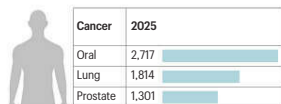
₹56.93 cr+ Approximate cost of the five equipment

COST TO PATIENTS

Services that could have been provided through these machines instead have to be sought at private centres, where individual tests or treatment courses can cost thousands to lakhs.



CANCER IN DELHI: WHAT THE DATA SHOW



KEY TAKEAWAYS

Most common cancer among men	Oral — 2,717 cases (2025)
Most common cancer among women	Breast — 3,321 cases (2025)
Second most common cancer in Delhi	Oral cancer
Fastest rise among women, 2023-25	Lung cancer — +13.6%
India's estimated cancer burden, 2022	14.6 lakh cases

SOURCES: DELHI CANCER FIGURES (2023-25); MINISTRY OF HEALTH & FAMILY WELFARE, GOVERNMENT OF INDIA. PARLIAMENTARY REPLY, 2025. NATIONAL CANCER ESTIMATE: NATIONAL CANCER REGISTRY PROGRAMME (NCRP), CANCER REPORTING RATE DURING NATIONAL LIBRARY OF MEDICINE (NLM), 2025. DELHI CANCER REGISTRY NETWORK-DELHI

CANCER REGISTRY, AIMS DELHI. IMPORTANT: THE 775 GOVERNMENT CENTRES AND 250 PRIVATE HOSPITALS/NURSING HOMES DESCRIBE THEMSELVES

AS CENTRES/HOSPITALS CONTRIBUTING CANCER-RELATED DATA TO THE DELHI CANCER REGISTRY, RATHER THAN SAYING ALL OF THEM HAVE DEDICATED CANCER DEPARTMENTS.

A recent audit of 26 govt hospitals, ordered by the Delhi High Court, found medical equipment lying unused across the Capital's public health system

diagnosed with multiple myeloma six years ago, and the expenses had included a PET-CT scan, dialysis and several blood tests.

"The PET-CT and dialysis alone cost us about Rs 60,000," he said.

What troubled him almost as much as the expense was having to pay for tests at private centres after coming to a government hospital expecting them to be covered. "I wasn't aware that DSCI-referred patients get some discount at private testing centres," he said.

Sabra and the 42-year-old are not alone. Patients say they are increasingly sent outside DSCI for medicines, scans and tests, leaving them to pay costs they expected the government hospital to cover.

The hospital describes itself as having "ultra-modern diagnostic facilities." Yet some of the equipment needed to provide those services lie unused on its premises.

The problem extends beyond DSCI. A recent audit of 26 city government hospitals, ordered by the Delhi High Court, found medical equipment lying unused across the Capital's public health system.

Nothing illustrates the findings more starkly than DSCI, where the consequences are being felt in patient care — and in the bills patients are left to pay.

Machines gather dust, patients suffer

The waiting area at DSCI sits at the centre of the hospital — a large hall with transparent plastic roof. Patients and attendants crowd the hall, with some lying on the floor, while open pipes from a nearby bathroom fills the area with foul smell.

In the waiting area, Sarita, 62, from Murshidabad, moves slowly behind her son. Her body has grown visibly frail; a feeding tube tucks from her nose. Sarita has lymphoma, a cancer of the immune system. For the past two months, she has been coming to DSCI for treatment. Now doctors have asked her to undergo a PET-CT scan to assess her response to treatment. But the scan is not available at the hospital.

"When I went to the radiology depart-

ment, I was told the test was not available," said her son, Mohan. A PET-CT at a private centre can cost between Rs 8,000 and Rs 30,000. Mohan is a daily-wage labourer. At Rs 12,000 scan, he said, would eat up nearly three-quarters of his monthly income.

"They are asking me to get the test done at a private centre," he said. "The security guard said he could get it done at a discounted price of Rs 12,000. But how can I afford it?"

Across the road from DSCI, in the DDA market at Pocket E, those private centres have become part of the hospital's ecosystem. A cluster of diagnostic centres has sprung up around the hospital, catering in part to patients sent there for tests.

At one of the diagnostic centres, a staff member described the routine. "We get two to three patients from DSCI a day. For a PET-CT, we offer a special discounted price of Rs 8,000. They deposit Rs 1,000 at the counter, and the next day, we arrange an ambulance. The patient comes to DDA market, and we take them to the testing centre," he said.

Some patients, however, specifically ask to have the scan done at another centre, considered one of the best. "The price then rises to Rs 22,000," he said.



Pocket E, DDA market where a cluster of medical shops and diagnostic centres have come up around DSCI. SOHINI GHOSH

For patients like Sarita, the cost is harder to bear because DSCI has the machines to do the scan. They are simply lying idle.

According to records submitted to the High Court, DSCI's Department of Nuclear Medicine has three high-end machines installed in 2017 at a cost of \$6.3 million, plus Rs 4.06 crore in local and turnkey costs. One, a medical cyclotron used to produce isotopes for PET scans, has been sitting unused since 2018.

"The radioactive sugar molecule has a short life. It decays quickly and requires specialised handling," the official said. "The machine was operational until 2018 but has been unused since then because of a lack of

qualified manpower. We are filling these positions now."

Two other sophisticated imaging machines, used to guide cancer treatment and track how patients respond to radiotherapy, are also sitting idle and under evaluation: a dual-head gamma camera with SPECT capabilities and a PET scanner integrated with a multidetector, multislice CT scanner.

It is not only expensive equipment that lies unused. Parts of the hospital itself have been left to deteriorate.

On the second floor, across from the private rooms, a section of the hospital lies in ruins. It was more than 150 patients were treated each day. Now, it stands abandoned. A warning on the door reads: "Don't enter without permission." Inside, steel vents hang loose from the ceiling. Beds sit unused. Wires and pipes dangle from the ceiling to the floor. Plastic waste is scattered across the room, while dust has accumulated on the floor.

"Due to a lack of medical supplies and manpower, this facility is shut," a source said.

The staff shortage

At DSCI in Dilshad Garden, there are 236 beds; 169 inpatient beds, 29 for observation

Patients run to pvt centres

● Patients say they are increasingly sent outside DSCI for medicines, scans and tests.

● They say they are left to pay charges they expect the government hospital to cover.

● Across the road from DSCI, the private centres have become part of the hospital's ecosystem.

● A cluster of diagnostic centres has sprung up around the hospital, catering in part to patients sent there for tests.

At DSCI, the consequences of medical equipment lying unused are being felt in patient care — and in the bills patients are left to pay

chair arrangement that resulted in the present unfortunate situation." The doctor alleged that there was a perception the changes were being made "deliberately to benefit private centres".

Fight against time

For patients, the consequences are increasingly visible. Many are being referred to other hospitals altogether — some of which provide treatment free of cost.

Take Sunita Ghai's case. In 2025, when the 70-year-old was diagnosed with uterine cancer, her son, Nikhil Ghai, a photographer from East Delhi, took her to DSCI. The hospital could not provide the radiation therapy she needed and referred her to a private hospital run by a public charitable trust because of the "non-availability of the facility."

"She was treated for free," Nikhil said. The reason: Eight items in the hospital's radiotherapy department reached the end of their usable life and were lying idle on the premises for years. Among them is a dual-photon energy linear accelerator, which uses high-powered X-rays at two energy levels to destroy cancer cells. A course of treatment using such a machine can cost Rs 2-3 lakh at a private centre. DSCI bought the machine for Rs 9.2 crore in 2007. It has been non-functional since 2020, officials said.

Now, Ghai and his mother are back at DSCI. Fluid has built up in Sunita's lungs, and she has been advised to undergo a minor surgery. After spending six days in a private hospital's ICU, the family has exhausted its savings, leaving Ghai with little choice but to return to the government hospital.

The family has been waiting outside a room marked "Minor OT" for hours. "I could not find a wheelchair for my mother... Why should the facility open at 2 pm instead of its regular hours? Cancer patients are fighting against time. It took two weeks to get the biopsy results here."

At DSCI, patients are fighting that clock in more ways than one — waiting for tests, waiting for treatment and, increasingly, waiting for the hospital itself to function.

Will fix gaps with clear timelines, says Delhi Health Minister

Tabshir Shams
New Delhi, August 30

DELHI HEALTH Minister Pankaj Singh said the BJP-led government had taken cognisance of the functioning of DSCI and was taking steps to "address the gaps".

"Our priority is to ensure that no cancer patient in Delhi is forced to choose costly private treatment, and we are committed to restoring DSCI to full

functional capacity at the earliest," Singh said.

"Most of this equipment was brought in by the previous AAP government, and unfortunately, several of these machines have been lying underutilised or non-functional for a while now," Singh told The Indian Express.

"We have taken serious cognisance of the matter and have asked for a detailed report from the hospital administration on the exact status of every machine,

along with a clear timeline for repair and recommissioning," he said.

Singh said the government would fast-track recruitment.

"Recruitment of specialists across departments has already begun, and we are prioritising nuclear medicine and radiotherapy, given how critical these departments are for cancer care," he said. "The machines have also started functioning gradually as vacancies are being filled and supply issues are being addressed."

Devbhoomi Uttarakhand Hub of Growth and Investment



Policy
Reforms



Financial
Incentives



Institutional
Support

Under the visionary leadership of PM Narendra Modi and the impeccable governance of CM Pushkar Singh Dhami, policy reforms, financial incentives, and institutional support have made Uttarakhand a robust ecosystem for MSMEs and startups



I congratulate the Uttarakhand government on the remarkable progress achieved in the last few years through sustained policy push and focus on key sectors such as tourism and renewable energy. The state has made significant strides in infrastructure, setting new benchmarks for sustainable growth. Utkand's commitment to harnessing its natural resources and promoting tourism will bolster its economy and showcase its potential on the global stage.

Narendra Modi,
Prime Minister



The investment-related agreements made with the industry groups during the investor conference are now rapidly coming to the ground. This is also creating new employment opportunities in Uttarakhand. We are providing all possible assistance to set up industries. With strong infrastructure and peaceful environment, Uttarakhand has emerged as the choice of investors.

Pushkar Singh Dhami,
chief minister

The Uttarakhand government has unveiled a comprehensive action plan to bolster the Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSME) sector, with a focus on positioning the state as a global hub for startups, green industries, and high-quality local products. The new MSME policy emphasises sustainable, inclusive, and employment-generating enterprises, while ensuring ease of doing business for investors.

MSMES AT THE CORE OF STATE ECONOMY

Micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) are the backbone of Uttarakhand's economy, driving employment, local enterprise and value creation. The government's renewed focus on the sector is encouraging startups that harness local resources, alongside investments in renewable energy, green industries and clean manufacturing. By strengthening infrastructure, easing business processes and promoting local enterprise, these initiatives are attracting fresh investment, expanding manufacturing and creating new employment opportunities. Together, they are enabling MSMEs to contribute more strongly to economic growth, livelihoods and inclusive development across the state.

POLICY PUSH AND ACTION PLAN

To accelerate economic growth, Uttarakhand is strengthening both new and existing enterprises through technology

upgradation, easier access to finance and markets, streamlined procedures and investment incentives. The One District One Product (ODOP) and One District Two Products (ODTP) initiatives, supported by GI-tagging, are helping showcase the state's distinctive products, strengthen local value chains and expand market opportunities. Aligned with national programmes such as Startup India, Stand-Up India, Make in India and MUDRA, these efforts are attracting investment, encouraging entrepreneurship and strengthening the "Make in Uttarakhand" identity in wider markets.

INCLUSIVE AND SUSTAINABLE GROWTH

The government is committed to ensuring that growth in the MSME sector is inclusive, providing special support to women entrepreneurs, the Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe communities, and entrepreneurs with disabilities (Divyang). To assist these groups in scaling their businesses and accessing new opportunities, additional financial incentives, subsidies, and dedicated helplines are being introduced.

STRENGTHENING INSTITUTIONAL SUPPORT

District Industry Centres (DICs) are being modernised to provide technical facilities, project preparation, and advisory support to

Financial incentives and subsidies

The new MSME policy provides a range of financial benefits to enterprises:

- ▶ Stamp duty reimbursement of upto 100% based on the category
- ▶ Capital subsidy of up to 50% on plant and machinery
- ▶ Extra capital investment subsidy of upto 5% under 'Priority' categories and upto 10% under 'Most Priority' categories
- ▶ An additional 5% subsidy for SC, ST, women, and divyang entrepreneurs
- ▶ Interest subsidy reimbursement of up to ₹21 lakh, depending upon the category
- ▶ Reimbursement of electricity duty for five years for new enterprises with a sanctioned load of up to 500 KW
- ▶ Recognition through ZED certification
- ▶ To encourage quality manufacturing, MSMEs are being offered certification under the Zero Defect Zero Effect (ZED) scheme. Units certified under gold, silver, and bronze categories receive recognition along with a monetary award of upto ₹75,000 per unit

entrepreneurs. A single-window clearance system is being streamlined to ensure faster approvals.

Additionally, an Investment Promotion and Facilitation Centre has been established at the Directorate of Industries to serve as a one-stop solution for investors and businesspersons. Special helpline services for women and differently-abled entrepreneurs are also being introduced.

FOCUS ON SKILL DEVELOPMENT AND MODERN TECHNIQUES

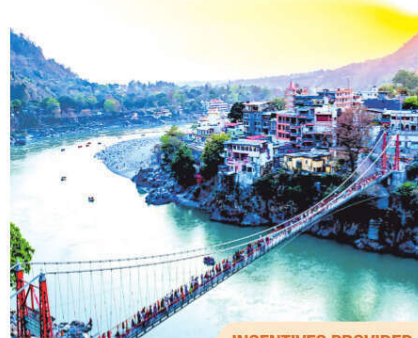
The policy also emphasises the need to equip young entrepreneurs with modern skills. To this end, the state is collaborating with reputed government and non-government organisations to provide training in:

- Manufacturing techniques
- Product design and packaging
- Marketing and branding strategies

MARKETING AND GLOBAL OUTREACH

The Uttarakhand Handloom and Handicraft Development Council is being engaged to promote state products in both national and international markets. Increased use of e-commerce platforms and commercial online portals will ensure that local enterprises gain greater visibility and a global reach. By encouraging innovation while preserving local traditions, the state aims to establish itself as a hub for sustainable and inclusive industries.

STATE'S NEW TOURISM SECTOR POLICY



The geographical, cultural, and environmental diversity of Uttarakhand has positioned it as one of the most visited states in North India. The number of tourists visiting Uttarakhand has consistently increased from ~22 million in 2014 to ~39 million in 2022 and registered a CAGR of 11.97%. A recent World Tourism and Travel Council (WTTTC) report has pegged India as the 7th largest tourism economy globally in terms of absolute size and further forecasts the sector to grow at 7% between 2017 and 2027. The state of Uttarakhand is expected to match this trend in terms of tourist arrivals.

The state's new Tourism Policy envisages to chalk out a sustainable development strategy for tourism sector in the state. The role of the State Government and its Departments is envisaged to revolve around policy, regulation and promotion of tourism; while provision of services like accommodation, tourist facilitation, transportation, organisation of tours, activities, events, etc. will be the purview of the private sector, with State playing an enabling role.

LEVERAGING PRIVATE SECTOR INVESTMENTS

The policy underscores the fact that future tourism development in Uttarakhand would also benefit from private sector capital and expertise. In this regard, the government places immense faith in private-public sector relationships to further the cause of tourism development. For this to take effect expeditiously, the State would:

i) reduce their role in areas where private

INCENTIVES PROVIDED UNDER THE POLICY

The policy provides the following incentives to eligible tourism units:

- ▶ Capital subsidy for hospitality (accommodation-related projects)
- ▶ Capital Subsidy
- ▶ Incentives for marketing and promotion
- ▶ Incentives for training and skilling
- ▶ Interest subvention
- ▶ Incentive for waste treatment
- ▶ Incentive for generating bookings through State Online Travel Agency
- ▶ Capital subsidy for investments in tourism products and services
- ▶ Subsidies for projects and units not eligible for capital subsidy
- ▶ Incentive for high-value premium hospitality
- ▶ Incentives for foreign tourists
- ▶ Organisation of MICE, art, social and cultural events, fairs and festivals
- ▶ Incentives for promotion of Heli transport
- ▶ Exemption on electricity duty
- ▶ Exemption on stamp duty

sector participation is encouraged (such as development and provision of accommodation), and
ii) enhance ease of doing business (investor facilitation) by strengthening single window clearance process for faster approvals of tourism entities.

ELIGIBILITY TOURISM UNITS

This policy supports and incentivises both existing and proposed tourism projects. For the purpose of eligibility for capital subsidy under this policy, those projects / enterprises which are new as well as those going for expansion / diversification as of the date of application for subsidy shall be considered.

For eligibility for turnover-linked incentives under this policy, those projects / enterprises which are operational as of the date of application for subsidy shall be considered.

The state intends to concentrate its efforts on the following 'Focus Tourism':

- ▶ Nature and Adventure Tourism
- ▶ Health and Wellness Tourism
- ▶ Religious and Cultural Tourism
- ▶ Heritage Tourism
- ▶ MICE Tourism



AYUSH Policy



AYUSH has remained a core part of Uttarakhand's culture and tradition over the years. The state has multiple natural and cultural endowments which make it an ideal destination for AYUSH.

Some key endowments include the presence of rare medicinal herbs, a well-established AYUSH manufacturing sector, a strong ancient community of practitioners and presence of destinations conducive for AYUSH healing.

KEY ACTIONS AND INCENTIVES MEDICINAL PLANTS

- ▶ Promote Good Agricultural Practices (GAP), quality standards and technology such as drones for better cultivation and monitoring
- ▶ Develop cold-storage facilities and aggregation platforms
- ▶ Introduce assured buy-back mechanisms and promote medicinal-plant cultivation
- ▶ Build a distinctive Uttarakhand/Himalayan brand for key medicinal



WELLNESS

- ▶ Provide additional capital incentives for eligible wellness centres, hotels and resorts in hill regions
- ▶ Promote AYUSH parks, yoga and meditation centres and wellness destinations through PPPs and private investment
- ▶ Undertake domestic and international campaigns to position Uttarakhand as a leading global wellness destination

AYUSH MANUFACTURING

- ▶ Provide additional capital subsidies for eligible AYUSH manufacturing units and encourage cluster-based manufacturing
- ▶ Promote WHO-GMP, AYUSH premium and AYUSH standard certifications
- ▶ Establish common testing laboratories and a dedicated Homeopathic Drug Testing Laboratory
- ▶ Position Uttarakhand as a leading AYUSH manufacturing hub

HEALTHCARE

- ▶ Encourage NABH accreditation of

Uttarakhand Pumped Storage Project Policy

This policy aims to set forth key objectives and mechanisms for development of Pumped Storage Projects in Uttarakhand. Pumped Storage Projects will be categorised in two main categories:

- **On-stream projects:** At least one storage located on river stream. The state government designated agency will identify on-stream projects from time to time. The projects may be allocated to CPSUs or State PSUs on nomination basis and to private developers through competitive bidding. The period of allocation and terms and conditions shall be as defined under this policy
- **Off-stream sites:** No storage located on river stream: The state government will invite developers to identify suitable sites for off-stream Pumped Storage Projects (PSPs) and submit proposals with details of their viability and storage potential. After evaluation, suitable projects will be

approved and formalised through an MoU/agreement with the developer

SUPPORT AND INCENTIVES

To encourage PSP development in state, the following support and incentives shall be offered:

- **Exemption of intra-state transmission charges:** PSP Developers shall be billed not more than 50% of intra-state transmission charges for a period of five years from the project CoD, if project CoD is before end of FY2033-34
- **Exemption of Local Area Development Fund:** Local Area Development Fund shall not be applicable to off-stream PSPs for the projects where power is purchased by state government
- **Exemption of free royalty power:** The state government shall not collect any free royalty power from Pumped Storage Projects



Policy objectives

Facilitate development of Pumped Storage Projects in the state and support state's growing energy demand in a sustainable manner.

- ▶ Harness the PSP potential in the state and encourage development of self-identified off-stream sites
- ▶ Leverage PSPs to generate public and private investment
- ▶ Encourage integration of renewable energy sources into the grid by promoting PSPs
- ▶ Leverage PSP storage to fulfil the drinking and irrigation needs of the regions wherever required and feasible



Grand Start

THE BJP is organising a grand ceremony at its headquarters in the Capital on Monday for its Vadodara MP Hemant Joshi to take charge as national president of the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha (BJYM). The ceremony will mark the formal beginning of Joshi's tenure at the helm of the BJP's youth organisation. The function will be attended by both experienced and young BJP leaders from across the country. According to insiders, the event seeks to symbolise organisational continuity as well as the party's commitment to strengthening youth participation in its declared aim of nation-building.

Sweet Surrender

RSS CHIEF Mohan Bhagwat found a way to bring some humour into his interactions in New York on Saturday, repeatedly turning to his own health while making a larger point about human nature. Speaking about how people sometimes succumb to temptation even when they know what is good for them, Bhagwat said he is diabetic but is still unable to resist sweets when someone offers them. Later, during his address at Madison Square Garden, Bhagwat returned to the subject while explaining how excessive indulgence can make people lose interest in what they desire. He used doughnuts as an example, wondering how many one could possibly eat before getting tired of them. He then added, with a touch of irony, that being diabetic meant he could not have even one.

Police summon Derek over billboard brawl

Kolkatta: The Kolkata police have summoned TMC MP Derek O'Brien in connection with the scuffle at 9 Camac Street on Thursday over the removal of an alleged illegal billboard. A team of three officers from the Shakespear Sarani police station arrived at O'Brien's residence on Sunday morning to hand over the notice on Sunday morning. As the MP was away, his staff accepted the notice. **ENS**

EVENT AT NEW YORK'S MADISON SQUARE GARDEN

Bharat's destiny is to make world realise unity in diversity: Bhagwat

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, August 30

IN AN apparent articulation of the RSS's worldview for an American audience, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat on Sunday said Bharat's "destiny" was to make the world realise that unity could coexist with diversity, and that the country had to demonstrate this "not by preaching, but by practice".

Addressing around 5,000 people at New York's Madison Square Garden, Bhagwat said nations were not merely geographical entities but had a "duty" to perform. Invoking Swami Vivekananda, he said every nation had a message to deliver, a mission to accomplish and a destiny to fulfil, and argued that Bharat's mission was to demonstrate the idea of unity underlying diversity.

"For Bharat, this unity and diversity are part of the DNA," he said. "Diversity has to be celebrated, but it has to be accepted. We must keep in mind this feeling of oneness. This is a real feeling."

The event, organised by the AHEAD Forum as part of the RSS's centenary-year global outreach, came amid a controversy in New York. Mayor Zohrab Mamdani said earlier this week, "I don't support the rally, but I don't know if the city has any jurisdiction on cancelling a private event."

Bhagwat said the idea of oneness was not merely philosophical but had implications for how human beings treated one another.



RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat in New York on Sunday. PTI

other. Asking the audience to imagine eating a meal while a hungry person watched them, he said a human being would find it difficult to continue eating because of the instinctive recognition of another person's suffering. "You will not be able to do it. Because we are human beings."

He contrasted two approaches — "live and let live" and "live and let others live" — and said that on those who have been wronged, he said that India was connected through the *atman*, like beads woven into a single thread. Differences of body, clothing and modes of worship, he said, did not alter this underlying unity. "It tells us that you are different but you are not. Because all these differences will fade. Your

body will die, but something lives permanently. We belong to each other," he said.

It was this understanding, he said, that India's ancestors had sought to give to the world. They had organised the people living "south of Himalayas up to the sea" into a nation with the task of communicating this task to the world. "That is the mission Bharat has to accomplish. Not by preaching, but by practice," he said.

Addressing the Indian diaspora, Bhagwat said their first responsibility was towards the RSS, which he described as their "karmabhoomi". If they wanted to do something for India, he said, they should first fulfil their duties towards the country where they lived. Bhagwat said Indians abroad should live by the values they received from India. "We take from the world and so we have to give back. How much we earn is not important. How much we distribute is," he said.

'Doublespeak': Opp parties slam RSS chief, say he can't tolerate diversity at home

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

THE OPPOSITION on Sunday accused RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat of indulging in doublespeak over his remarks on diversity, even as the BJP hailed him, saying he has shown the world what Hinduism actually means.

Reacting to Bhagwat's remarks, Congress spokesperson Shama Mohamed said the RSS chief should "stop lying" and alleged that the RSS's DNA has "hated and communalism".

Congress leader Udit Raj said Bhagwat made the statement to placate those protesting against the RSS in New York. "They are two-faced people, they change their colours like a chameleon. Since there were protests against them in New York, they had to try to counter it with such a jumble (rhetoric)...," he said.

AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi accused Bhagwat of indulging in "doublespeak" and termed the speech "the oldest trick in the RSS playbook". "Some words are for the world, and some are for its own members... What do they say about Muslims and other minorities?" My request to Bhagwat is that he should just recite choice extracts from the poisonous words of Savarkar, Hegdegar, Gokhale, etc. Let people decide

what they make of RSS," he said.

Shiv Sena UBT MP Sanjay Raut said the RSS chief needed to make the same statement in India. "This statement and ideology, Bhagwat ji should speak about it in India. Their people who are sitting in power in Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, those in Maharashtra... imported from other parties — he should tell them this... You will say something in New York and in Bharat, when there is a protest against you, you will say something different. This is not called dharma but dhong (drama)," he said.

Rajya Sabha MP Kapil Sibal took a swipe at Bhagwat, saying he was left wondering whether it was Congress leader Rahul Gandhi or the Sangh chief speaking. "If you want to convert the message for a drug-free life, you will say something different. This is not called dharma but dhong (drama)," he said.

Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnis said tolerance is the soul of Hindutva. "Tolerance runs in the blood of Hindus, it is a fundamental aspect of Hindutva... If someone attacks you, there must certainly be a counter-response; however, a Hindu never initiates an attack."

Cockroach Janta Party leader Abhijeet Dipke said the BJP thinks it has become bigger than the RSS, but it should pay heed to what the Sangh chief has been saying. **WITH PTI INPUTS**

MANN KI BAAT



Prime Minister Narendra Modi at a yoga session organised by the Yoga Federation of Uzbekistan in Tashkent. PTI

Play role in anti-drug drive, create slogans, songs: Modi to youth

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi urged the youth on Sunday to take "creative efforts" and bolster the campaign against drug abuse to create a powerful slogan or songs to convey the message for a drug-free life.

During his Mann Ki Baat address, Modi warned drug addiction is not just an individual problem but the entire family as he commended those raising awareness against drugs and stepping forward to help people struggling with addiction.

"Can you come up with a powerful slogan for a drug-free India? Can our young musicians create songs that convey the message of a drug-free life? Can students and theatre groups write touching short plays that highlight the dangers of drugs while also showing the path to recovery? Our country has no shortage of excellent content creators. I urge them to create content in various languages that helps society in this endeavour," he said. "You can use your creativity as a medium for social change... creative efforts prove more impactful than formal campaigns. Let us all play our part in this noble mission to keep India's youth away from drugs and free from addiction".

Launched on August 15,

2020, under the National Action Plan for Drug Demand Reduction, the Nasha Mukti Bharat Abhiyaan is a flagship government initiative.

This year, which marks the 150th anniversary of Vande Mataram, 8 crore Tiranga selfies were uploaded, the PM said. Through the Suryapath Tiranga initiative, the tricolour embarked on a unique journey across the globe, he said.

He said, "Nearly 46% of the beneficiaries of SVANidhi Scheme are women. Around 35 lakh women across the country are connecting with this scheme to advance their businesses."

Calling for honouring local artisans during Vishwakarma Puja in September, he said, "I once again urge you to be 'Vocal for Local'. Being 'Vocal for Local' doesn't merely mean buying earthen lamps... What ever item we purchase for our homes, do ensure it is made in India... Our friends from creative world, influencers and celebrities also have a significant role to play in it."

The PM also paid tribute to legendary Bengali artist and "Mahanayak" Uttam Kumar, whose birth centenary falls on September 3. "Mahanayak Uttam Kumar *chirodin manusher hridaye raj korben* (He will forever rule the hearts of people)," PM said.

Day after Jarange began fast, govt says ready to discuss legal validity

Vallabh Ozarkar
Mumbai, August 30

A DAY after Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange Patil resumed his indefinite fast at Antarwari Sarati, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis on Sunday said the government is open to discussing constitutionally valid and legally viable demands.

Deputy CM Eknath Shinde said the government's position was to provide reservation to the Maratha community without reducing the reservation available to other communities.

Fadnis said representatives of the government are attending the Parbani event to discuss the demands of demonstrators. "Earlier also we found a way to address their issues, and we are going forward to resolve their demands. Similarly, Eknath Shinde is also very sensitive to these issues from the very beginning," he said.

Shinde, who attended a farmer-youth meeting at Parbani, said, "I know Manoj Jarange Patil's concern. CM Fadnis and I have sent our ministers to examine the legal aspects."

41 nations, 135 movies: Kashmir set to host its first global film festival

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, August 30

FROM KASHMIR *Kali in the 60s to Kabhie Kabhie in the 70s to Highway (2014) and Raazi (2018)* more recently, the Valley has long attracted Hindi film industry to shoot its movies in the pristine landscape.

Now, with the hope of putting the region on the world cinema map, Kashmir is all set to host its first international film festival next month.

"Rang-e-Cinema", to be hosted by J&K government's Information and Public Relations department from September 7 to 10, aims to establish J&K as a "major international destination for cinema, filmmaking, creative collaboration and cultural exchange".

"The core objective is to rebuild J&K's historic relationship with cinema," said an official associated with the international festival. "It is also aimed at creating opportunities for local talent, attracting filmmakers, pro-

moting film tourism and placing Jammu and Kashmir firmly on the global cinematic map."

The organisers have announced a star-studded five-member jury for the festival. This includes eminent cinematographer and director Santosh Sivan, sound designer and sound mixer of *Shroog* *Mil-lionaire* fame Resul Pookutty, German film curator and journalist Dorothee Wenner, founder and CEO of Bang Singapore Keiko Bang, and film director Himansu Sekhar Khattua of *Sanya Swaroopa* fame.

"We had received over 1,100 submissions for the festival from over 80 countries," said a senior official. "Of these, 135 submissions, from 41 countries, have been shortlisted." While 64 entries have been shortlisted from India, 13 films from France and eight from Iran would be a part of the festival. The other participating countries include Turkey, Germany, Russia, Spain, Brazil, Qatar, Argentina, the US, South Korea and Taiwan.

IAS officer, who brought piped drinking water to UP village, quits

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, August 30

DIVYA MITTAL, who gained popularity for bringing piped water to a remote hilly village in Mirzapur district of UP as the District Magistrate three years ago, on Sunday announced her resignation from the IAS after a 13-year stint.

Announcing her resignation in a social media post, the 42-year-old officer of the UP cadre said she was now ready to "move on" from a journey in which she had learnt more from the people she served than she had given them.

"Today, I have voluntarily stepped away from an unforgettable 13-year journey by regaining from the IAS," the 2013-batch IAS officer said in a social media post. Mittal served as district magistrate of Mirzapur from September 2022 to September 2023, and later as that of Deoria from July 2024. In May this year, she was appointed Special Secretary, Revenue Department, in Lucknow.

Mittal's tenure in Mirzapur



Now, it was time to live the dreams I saw for my people: Divya Mittal posted on X. @DIVYAMITTAL_IAS_X

brought her considerable public attention in 2023, particularly after her intervention led to provision of piped water to Lahuria Dah village, where residents had long depended on tankers for drinking water. But soon after, she was transferred out of Mirzapur and placed on the waiting list from September 4, 2023, to February 1, 2024. On February 1, she was posted as CEO of UP Rural Road Development Agency and later served as district magistrate in Deoria.

Mittal said she initially believed she had entered public service to give something to society. "I was a fool to think I had come to give something. The truth is, I received the most, and that debt only grew deeper," she wrote.

Mittal did not specify what she had planned to do after quitting the IAS. In her final message, she said the dreams she had once seen for herself had already come true. "Now, it was time to live the dreams I saw for my people," she wrote.

Sources said that she plans to pursue academics and book writing. There are also speculations about her joining politics. SP chief Akhilesh Yadav alleged that honest officials in UP were being pressured under the BJP government to indulge in "unethical and illegal" activities, forcing them to quit the service.

"There are countless other instances where the BJP government puts pressure on officials to carry out unethical and illegal acts, because of which they are even forced to resign," Yadav said on X.

Mahila, Manusmriti, purification row: Rahul's new political pitch takes shape



WEEKLY INSIGHT INTO WHAT'S CHANGING IN NATIONAL POLITICS — AND WHY

"SHUDDHIKARAN (PURIFICATION), Manusmriti, 'Chhatron ki Goonj' event in Pune reflected a shift in the Congress's strategy. The LoP did not use the usual, mild words that political parties use to express concern for women, such as 'welfare' and 'empowerment'. Instead, he talked about 'smashing patriarchal' and accused the RSS and the BJP of possessing a 'Manusmriti mindset'."

The format of the meeting was also differently conceived and it even reflected in Gandhi's sartorial choice. He was dressed in a more stylish yellow shirt instead of his customary beige trousers and white T-shirt (with the trademark one hand in his pocket). At the 'Chhatron ki Goonj' address in Prayagraj earlier, he had worn a pink flowing shirt.

The idea of Gandhi's makeover, if Congressmen are to be believed, is to try and win over a large section of Gen Z, especially women, whom the party thinks it has not paid attention to until now. Many urban, educated, middle-class

that might enable them to come to power in Uttar Pradesh and other poll-bound states in 2027. Gandhi's words at his 'Chhatron ki Goonj' event in Pune reflected a shift in the Congress's strategy. The LoP did not use the usual, mild words that political parties use to express concern for women, such as 'welfare' and 'empowerment'. Instead, he talked about 'smashing patriarchal' and accused the RSS and the BJP of possessing a 'Manusmriti mindset'."

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and upper-caste Gen Z like the LoP's "inconsistent" ways — such as taking off for a break from time to time, unlike traditional politicians who are expected to work 24x7. For Gandhi to pay as much attention to his fitness and health as to his work is a model that interests them, and they like him for asking questions of the government as a 19-year-old put it. "To be modern is to ask questions."

In Pune, Gandhi also demonstrated a different way of political engagement. He walked up and down the stage with a mike in his hand, calling out groups of young women to come up on the stage and chat with him. They talked about their experiences — the safety constraints they face that have a bearing on their education or work, their inability to make decisions independently, as well as lack of finances. These were points that only interested women. Most of them were more at home in Marathi, managing to speak in Hindi that was disarming — their punchlines drawing applause from the audience, a large number of them women. It appears that

the Gen Z are viewing Rahul Gandhi as new eyes.

Why Gandhi brought up Manusmriti

Gandhi could just as well have made a powerful pitch for women's rights without referring to the controversial *Manusmriti*. But he chose to court a controversy because not only did he want to reach out to Gen Z women — and Gen Alpha girls — but also to Dalits. A century ago, B R Ambedkar had burnt the *Manusmriti* in public in 1927 to protest against its teachings, criticising it for endorsing untouchability and denying the lower castes and women equality and autonomy of functioning.

Then, on August 29, Gandhi upset the ante with his attack against the BJP for not acting against those who had washed the stage from which Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge had addressed a gathering in Haldwani earlier this month. This, the LoP argued, was just because Kharge is Dalit. Gandhi tried to make this 'shuddhikaran' (purification) act synonymous with continuing un-



Rahul Gandhi addresses a press conference in New Delhi on Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

touchability according to Dalits and project that the BJP, despite rapidly expanding its base and courting the OBCs and Dalits since 2014, remains the party of the upper castes — at the Brahmin-Bania party — at its core.

The BJP distanced itself from the incident and hit back, but Gandhi is not letting up, asking if the Dalit president of the largest Opposition party could be treated in this fashion, what might be the fate of ordinary Dalits in villages? Gandhi knows that the return of Dalits to the Congress fold holds the key to the party's future. It is the Dalit fear of losing their constitutionally guaranteed reservations that had led to the BJP failing to get a majority on its own in 2024.

Gandhi is also not abandoning his outreach to the OBCs, though he has not made much of a headway with them in the Hindi heartland. This was the sum total of the letter that he and Kharge shot off to Prime Minister Modi to reframe the questions in the caste census — many believe that it will not do justice to the OBCs.

Gandhi's problem, however, lies elsewhere. It is the emanation of the Congress organisation in large parts of the country. Winning elections is a complex business today. A buzz is not good enough without the machinery to convert goodwill into votes and that is where the Con-

gress has been found wanting.

Can BJP capitalise?

Paradoxically, the *Manusmriti* debate has also come as a godsend for a BJP on the back foot after the recent protests. It could help the ruling party to switch the narrative back to the Hindu versus anti-Hindu lines to polarise the polity. BJP leaders were quick to criticise the LoP, saying he targets only the Hindu religious texts for discriminating against women. The newly appointed BJP general secretary Smriti Irani, who defeated Gandhi in Amethi in 2019 and who has been rehabilitated to take him on, asked the LoP to walk the talk and support the implementation of the Women's Reservation Act and induce women ministers in the Congress's Karnataka Cabinet. Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath also took aim at Gandhi, accusing him of insulting the state and the country's religious traditions.

It is early days yet, but given that the *Manusmriti* gives primacy to the Brahmins and upper castes, the new controversy could help the BJP con-

solidate the upper castes behind it once again. Though they have been the most convinced of the BJP's supporters in the Hindi heartland since the Mandir movement, these communities have been feeling restive with what they see as the BJP's tilt towards the OBCs. They have reacted to the UGC equity norms now stayed, and even the caste census that is underway.

In 2018, the government, which had restored the SC-ST Act diluted by the Supreme Court, had to move with alacrity to bring a 10% quota for the economically weaker sections in the general category. As then, so also today, the BJP, whose base has expanded under Narendra Modi, is compelled to walk the tightrope.

In the end, the two "Ms" — *Mahila* and *Manusmriti* — may well define the 2027 elections in UP and other states, which will turn with a ripple effect in the big battle in 2029.

(Neeraja Chowdhury, Contributing Editor, The Indian Express, has covered the last 11 Lok Sabha elections. She is the author of *How Prime Ministers Decide*.)



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New Delhi

NEPAL DISASTER: MEA SHARES LIST OF 149 INDIANS RESCUED ON SUNDAY



The trail of devastation left behind in the riverside town of Betrawati in Nepal on Sunday. Betrawati is also on the main route used by pilgrims travelling to Gosaikunda, a pilgrimage site in Rasuwa. TASHI TOROGYAL

'Hope for some miracle'

403 Indians cross into Nepal from China; forensic team from India begins DNA tests

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 30

AS MANY as 403 Indian nationals safely crossed into Nepal from China on Sunday and 500 Indians are still in China and safe, the Ministry of External Affairs said on Sunday.

However, the ministry did not give any update on the missing Indians. On Saturday, as search and rescue operations continued in Nepal for the fourth day, the ministry had said 275 Indians and another 128 people of Indian origin — mostly Kailash Mansarovar Yatra pilgrims — remained missing.

On Sunday, the MEA on its X handle shared a list of 149 people who were rescued. It also said that a 19-member specialised forensic team from India began functioning in Kathmandu today.

"This team will help augment the analysis of DNA samples in Nepal for identification of the mortal remains of the victims. Ambassador of India to Nepal (Naveen Srivastava) met and briefed the forensic team. Subsequently, the team had discussions with counterparts in Nepal Police's Central Forensic Science Lab Laboratory in Kathmandu and Forensics Department of the Tribhuvan University Teaching Hospital," it said.

About the Indian tunnel rescue team, the MEA said, "Tunnel Rescue Operations Team continued its work today and

supplemented the research and rescue efforts of Nepal Army at hydropower sites in Chilime and Langtang." The team was able to enter a tunnel near Langtang hydroelectric project and retrieve the mortal remains of one person in spite of inclement weather. This team is continuing its support operations near the Langtang hydroelectric project," it said.

The death toll from flash floods in Nepal rose to 788 on Sunday, with bodies continuing to be recovered, as authorities warned of increased water levels in the Bhotokoshi river and urged residents and rescue personnel in flood-hit districts to remain alert.

More than 2,500 people still remain missing, while nearly 9,500 people were rescued, according to the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA).

In a statement issued on Sunday, the NDRRMA warned that water levels in the Bhotokoshi river had risen again. "The water level in the flooded Bhotokoshi river has risen to some extent, all concerned are urged to take precautionary measures," it said.

As many as 2,502 people, including 591 foreigners, remain missing, according to authorities. India has provided 68.5 tonnes of relief materials. "The fourth flight, carrying 11 tons of relief materials, has arrived in Nepal," the Indian mission said.

WITH AGENCIES FROM NEPAL



A photograph of a family lies amid the debris as search operations intensified. TASHI TOROGYAL

'Chances of survival look slim': 67 from Maharashtra still untraceable

Apoorva Agashe
Mumbai, August 30

AS MANY as 67 pilgrims from Maharashtra who were stranded in Nepal after the flash floods remained untraceable, with their families awaiting news of their loved ones.

Maharashtra government on Sunday said that 69 people from the state had crossed from China's Kodari Immigration Center into Nepal and were expected to reach Mumbai by Monday. Earlier 142 citizens were brought back to the state.

The Ramakrishnan family from Mumbai is among those whose members were headed to Tibet to complete their Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage before they went missing. At 8.21 am, I got a message from my brother-in-law Venkata saying, "We are at the immigration centre at

(Nepal), heading towards Tibet." He has been untraceable since then," C O Ramakrishnan told *The Indian Express*.

Ramakrishnan's sister, Meenakshi Subramanian, and her husband were among the 67 people who had travelled to the region on a pilgrimage led by Dr Milind Chitale. The group was at the Timure border immigration centre, preparing to cross into Tibet, when floods struck. Ramakrishnan said the family has been in touch with Indian, Nepalese and Chinese embassies. But there is no information about the whereabouts and status of 67 members of Richa Tours and Travels in Nepal and Hills and Trails in Mumbai.

Meenakshi Subramanian (60) and her husband Venkata Subramanian (67), from Kandivali were on Kailash Mansarovar. Their last known location is

Timure, Rasuwa, one of the worst-hit districts.

Ramakrishnan said, "From what we could gather from embassies in Rasuwa was the epicenter of the flash floods... We are anxious to about the whereabouts of our loved ones. Their phones are switched off or unreachable. Authorities are trying to find them but we are losing hope as the chances of survival look dim. We hope we are wrong and some miracle happens."

Thane-based Joshi family is also waiting to hear from their loved ones. Sachin Joshi, a relative of a couple who have been missing, said the families of those missing in Nepal have formed a WhatsApp group to coordinate their efforts. "My relatives, Samir Joshi and Aparna Joshi are missing. All relatives have formed a WhatsApp group for coordination."

Bengal couple returns, no word on Mukul Roy's daughter-in-law

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, August 30

RETIRED SCHOOLTEACHER Anukul Poddar and his wife Reba Poddar, who had been in the vicinity of the flash flood-affected area in Nepal, returned home in Basirhat in North 24 Parganas district on Saturday and recounted how a timely decision by their driver saved their lives when the flash floods struck on August 26.

"We returned by Mithila Express. We had gone there for the Mansarovar and Kailash yatra. However, as we left Kathmandu for our journey ahead, our driver came to know about the floods and took us to a safer location at a higher altitude and we returned to our hotel 40-45 minutes later. It is because of our driver that we are safe today," Anukul said. Their arrival had ended the agony for their family. But for many across the state, every moment is mounting for anxiety as they wait updates on several with most of the tourists yet to be traced or located.

Among those untraced is Sharmista Bhowmik Roy, wife of ex-TMC MLA Subhanshu Roy and daughter-in-law of late politician Mukul Roy. She left Kolkata on August 21 as part of a 30-member Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage group and was reportedly around 10 km from site of deluge when communication with her was lost. "I could only get information they had cleared immigration and crossed into China side. There is no further update," Subhanshu said.

NEET-PG: Power cut hits two Jaipur centres, retest on Sep 5; panel formed

Hamza Khan & Anonna Dutt
Jaipur, New Delhi August 30

A FRESH exam will be held on September 5 for candidates affected due to power cut issues during the NEET-PG 2026 exam held at two ION Digital Zone IDZ centres in Jaipur's Sitapura area, the National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS) said on Sunday.

As per NBEMS, the examination could not be completed at test centres numbers 41,682 and 41,683 in Jaipur "due to internal power failure issues at the centre, attributed to M/s TCS Ltd., the exam conducting agency."

The Board said the re-test would be held on September 5 at 3pm in Jaipur. Other details regarding the re-exam centre will be released separately, it said, adding that revised admit cards will also be issued. It said, "NBEMS apologises to the affected candidates for the inconvenience caused."

According to sources, the NBEMS has constituted a three-member committee to look into the power supply issue, the reasons for disruption, and the circumstances leading to it. The committee will include a senior official from Rajasthan government, a joint secretary from the Union health ministry, and a senior engineering official from the Central Electricity Authority. The committee will submit its report within the stipulated time-frame, sources said.

Dr Abhijit Sheth, NBEMS president, said, "There was no paper leak, cybercrime, or hacking. There were no complaints received. There was one problem, however. Around 2,445 candidates in Jaipur's Sitapura centres could not complete their examination due to internal power failure. And, we had to postpone the examination to preserve its sanctity."

He said, "We will conduct the test in the same manner and keep in mind that the scores are not affected."

According to Union Health Ministry officials NBEMS has also expressed regret for inconvenience caused to the affected candidates and said the re-examination is being conducted to ensure that they receive a fair and equitable opportunity.

Dr Gaurav, who wrote the exam, said, "In two hours, the exam began 10 times and ended 10 times." While several other candidates alleged lack of proper electricity supply at the centre which hampered the exam, some demanded its cancellation across the country.

Vishnu Sharma, another candidate, said, "The system shut down repeatedly right from the beginning, even before the exam could properly start. It would work for barely two minutes before crashing. This happened at least 20 times."

He said, "We kept cooperating, hoping it would work the next time, but the system continued to shut down. When candidates are charged such a substantial fee, is it too much to expect proper facilities for an exam of this scale?"

In a post on X, Congress said, "The NEET-PG exam scheduled for 9 am in Jaipur could not even start until noon. Students and their families continued to suffer due to (PM Narendra) Modi's pathetic system, while the entire government slept soundly under the covers. Once again, it has been proven that the Modi government cannot conduct even a single exam properly. Shame on them."

As per NBEMS, NEET-PG 2026 exam was conducted on August 30 at 1,111 centres across 339 cities for 2,73,096 registered candidates. Of them, 2,65,980 candidates appeared for the exam and 2,63,535 completed it.

8-yr-old boy dies after being run over by car in Mumbai; woman held

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 30

A 45-YEAR-OLD woman was arrested after her Innova Crystal allegedly hit an eight-year-old boy while he was crossing the road in Bandra West on Sunday afternoon, resulting in his death.

The deceased was identified as Ansh Gupta, 8. The accused driver has been identified as Megha Rawal, 45, a Bandra West resident, who is a fitness coach and nutritionist. She is the founder of Mezmoo candy, a healthcare brand which makes gummies out of real fruit.

According to police, the incident took place between 2.15 pm and 2.30 pm in front of Jijamata Garden on John Baptist Road, Bandra West. Ansh was allegedly crossing the road when the Innova Crystal driven by Rawal hit him. Following the accident, Ansh sustained grievous injuries

and was rushed to Holy Family Hospital for where doctors declared him dead on arrival.

"He had sustained grievous injuries so we had rushed him to Holy Family Hospital. The doctors had declared him dead on arrival. The family of Ansh Gupta is still shocked," police said.

The police said they were investigating whether the accused was using a phone while driving when the accident occurred. It is alleged that the woman was on a phone call at the time of the incident.

"The woman has been identified as Megha Rawal, and we suspect she was talking over a phone call when the incident took place. We are investigating," a police officer said. Rawal has been booked under BNS Sections 105, 281 and 125, along with Section 184 of the MV Act, which deals with dangerous driving.

'Delay in justice': Kin of Dalits killed in 2012 Gujarat firing link suicide to father's grief

Brendan Dabhi & Parimal A Dabhi
Ahmedabad, August 30

ALMOST 14 years ago, three young Dalit men were killed in alleged police firing in Gujarat's Surendranagar district, in what remains one of the most sensitive and controversial cases of its kind in the state in recent years.

Earlier this week, the father of one of the three men died on the railway tracks in Thangadh, allegedly by suicide, metres from a memorial erected to the memory of the youths — Mehul Rathod, Prakash Parmar, and Pankaj Sumra.

Prakash Parmar's father Babubhai had died of heart failure in 2015. After Pankaj Sumra's father Amarsi Sumra died Wednesday night, only one of the three grieving fathers now survives.

Valji Rathod, the father of

Mehul Rathod, told *The Indian Express* he believed it was the failure to get justice for their sons that had in some way led to the deaths of both Babubhai and Amarsi.

"We believe it is the delay in justice that finally took the life of Amarsi Sumra, just like it did of Babubhai Parmar a decade ago," Valji Rathod said. Mehul Rathod, Prakash Parmar, and Pankaj Sumra were allegedly shot dead by police in two separate but related incidents on September 22 and 23, 2012, which followed a clash between Dalits and non-Dalits at a local fair.

Prakash Parmar was 26 when he was killed. Mehul Rathod and Pankaj Sumra were only 17 and 16 respectively. Amarsi Lakha Sumra, the 53-year-old father of Pankaj Sumra, died at 10.21 pm on August 26 after he was run over by the 1268H Hapa-Mumbai Central Duronto Express as he

train crossed Thangadh," ASI Jagdish Dhoraliya of Government Railway Police, Surendranagar, said.

Police have registered an Accidental Death (AD) report. But the three Dalit families see a link between Amarsi's death and those of his son and the two other youths in 2012. "No one can really comprehend a father's grief over the loss of his son. These three men, Amarsi, Babubhai, Valji, and Babubhai, went through pain that is hard to describe," Valji Bagda, Amarsi Sumra's younger brother, said.

"Two families have been completely destroyed. I am the only one of the three fathers left now. I have no support any more. Amarsi, Babubhai would constantly ask me to stay strong, but now he is gone himself," Valji Rathod said.

Vinu Bagda said Amarsi



Amarsi Sumra, whose son Pankaj was among the three youth killed in 2012, died allegedly by suicide on Aug 26

was dismayed at the way justice seemed to be denied to his son. "He would say that the cases go on and on without any conclusion... This time of the year is particularly hard for us because preparations have begun for the Tarnetar fair during which his son was killed," Vinu said.

"Amarsi had spoken with his daughter a couple of days ago, and she had told him she

regretted no longer having a brother with whom she could celebrate Raksha Bandhan. This may have exacerbated his grief," Vinu said.

The two brothers had met four days before Amarsi died. "He told me he no longer had the will to live. I told him he should not think that way, and tried to reassure him that justice will be done," Vinu said. "Many people told us Amarsi had gone to the memorial around 9.30 pm that day. We think he may have gone to the tracks shortly after," Vinu said.

On September 22, 2012, an argument broke out between groups of young men of two communities during that year's Tarnetar Mela organised by the local civic body, PM Narendra Modi, who was then CM of Gujarat, was visiting the district at the time, and police moved quickly to break up the scuffle.

They used tear gas and fired at the crowd. A bullet allegedly hit Pankaj Sumra in the back. He was taken to Surendranagar hospital and then to Rajkot civil hospital, where he was declared dead. On September 23, members of the Dalit community came out in protest, and the police allegedly fired again. This time Prakash Parmar and Mehul Rathod were killed. A fourth Dalit youth, 25-year-old Chana Vanjiya, was injured.

In 2012, the Gujarat government ordered an inquiry under Sanjay Prasad, then principal secretary in the Social Justice and Empowerment Department. Prasad submitted his report in May 2013. But its contents were never made public. This inquiry was not by IPS officer Anupam Singh Gahlot.

The SIT filed a chargesheet in the case of Pankaj Sumra's alleged murder, in which his mother Baluben was the com-

plaint. The other two cases, involving the alleged killings of Prakash and Mehul, were closed.

Three of the four policemen accused in Pankaj's killing are facing trial in district court in Surendranagar. The case is at the stage of recording prosecution evidence. "It will be 14 years on September 22 this year," Valji Rathod said. "The report by Prasad inquiry is still not public, and no accused has been arrested. How long must we wait for justice?" In protest, Valji fought the 2019 LS election to the Gandhinagar seat as an Independent against Amit Shah, who would go on to become Union Home Minister.

Chandrika Rathod, Mehul's mother, said, "In 2017 we moved Gujarat HC seeking the release of Sanjay Prasad report. We have protested in Delhi, Gandhinagar, and Thangadh, but the findings were not released."

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

GLOBAL

Can Trump rename Lake Ontario as Lake America?

Rishika Singh
New Delhi, August 30

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump last week signed an executive order to rename Lake Ontario, situated on the US-Canada border. The order said the lake was a "tremendous asset to the United States and part of our Nation's heritage".

In response, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney wrote in a post on X that the name Ontario (also the name of a Canadian province) comes from the indigenous Wendat people. "The name is more than 400 years old, predating both the Confederation of Canada and the Declaration of Independence of the United States of America... reality means calling it Lake Ontario - then, now and always," he wrote.

Why the move

Lake Ontario is part of the Great Lakes system, along with Lake Superior, Michigan, Huron and Erie, spanning the US-Canada border. According to the US National Ocean and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), the lakes system holds about 90% of the freshwater in the US and approximately 20% of the world's freshwater supply. Forty million people across the two countries depend on it for clean drinking water.

In his executive order, Trump cited a range of reasons for the decision — including the US's investments in the lake to keep it open for free shipping, Canada spending comparatively less on it, and the lake's history as an "asset to American exploration, settlement, commerce, and defense." But more pressingly, it comes amid heightened trade tensions between the countries. Trade talks collapsed last week and led to the US imposing tariffs on Canada, with Carney promising to match them "dollar for dollar" against American imports. The US is Canada's largest trading partner, while Canada is the US's second-largest trading partner.

GREAT LAKES

- Lake Ontario is part of the Great Lakes system, along with Lake Superior, Michigan, Huron and Erie, spanning the US-Canada border.
- Forty million people across the two countries depend on it for clean drinking water.

What changes

The name change will apply to how the US officially refers to the lake, but will not affect what Canada or the rest of the world call it. No single global organisation is tasked with ensuring uniformity among names of water bodies, and the decision to use a certain name is often based on historical precedent.

In a social media post, Trump stated that the US Geological Survey was officially changing the name to have it reflect in all official USGS electronic documents.

This is not the first time that disagreements over trade and other issues have prompted Trump to use nomenclature as a tool.

In January 2025, Trump renamed the Gulf of Mexico as the Gulf of America, amid tensions with Mexico over immigration and tariffs. It took about two weeks for the US government to update the official federal nomenclature to reflect those changes. The change was also reflected on Google Maps. Google Maps is now reflecting the changed name for Lake Ontario too.

How Google Maps names disputed features

According to Google, the names seen on Maps are based on information such as a user's country location and phone operating system (e.g., iOS and Android). In 2025, users in Mexico saw "Gulf of Mexico" on Maps while those in the US saw "Gulf of America". For other users, both names are visible. For example, in the present case, users in India can see "Lake Ontario (Lake America)".

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

The many hurdles ChatGPT for Teens safeguards could run into for Indian users

Anagha Jayakumar
New Delhi, August 30

OPENAI RECENTLY announced the launch of a version of ChatGPT exclusively for teenage users.

Teenagers are already using ChatGPT extensively, with OpenAI saying nearly nine in 10 teens turn to it for learning, information, skill-building or productivity in a week. But their growing use of AI tools has also spurred concerns over how these systems respond to young users, particularly when conversations move beyond homework or information-seeking into emotional support, mental health and companionship.

Crucially, the new offering is not a separate application or website. Teenagers continue to use the regular ChatGPT, but with additional, age-appropriate features built in. These are automatically enabled when a user's stated or verified age, or OpenAI's age-prediction system, indicates that they are under 18. OpenAI does not allow children below age 13 to use ChatGPT.

Establishing user age

According to OpenAI, it uses information associated with an account, including a user's stated or verified age, as well as an age-prediction system that looks at signals such as how long the account has existed, the times of day it is typically used, general conversation topics, and patterns of use.

In India, the relationship between a device, an account and the person using it is not always straightforward. The RATTI Foundation's Ideal Internet 3.0 study, released in November 2025, found that 62% of Indian teenagers surveyed used shared devices. Moreover, 42% reported that other people operated their social media accounts, while 56% said they could log into someone else's.

The 62% figure was acknowledged in OpenAI's Teen Safety Blueprint for India, released this January. While this does not directly imply that teenagers are using shared ChatGPT accounts, it raises questions for a system attempting to determine the age of the person behind an account. Pragna Misra, Head of Strategy & Global

Affairs, OpenAI India, told *The Indian Express* that ChatGPT for Teens is designed around the account rather than the device. This means that if a teenager and an adult use separate accounts on the same shared device, each can receive the experience appropriate to their age. "It is not intended to distinguish between multiple people using the same shared account or to switch experiences person by person within one login," Misra said of the age-prediction system. When uncertain about a user's age, OpenAI defaults to the under-18 experience.

Potential pitfalls

A risk assessment undertaken by Common Sense Media, an independent media watchdog for content consumed by children, and Stanford Medicine's Brainstorm Lab for Mental Health Innovation found that leading AI chatbots failed to recognise and appropri-

ately respond to mental health conditions affecting young people.

Robbie Torney, Head of AI and Digital Assessments at Common Sense, told *The Indian Express* that meaningful testing of safeguards requires "testing the product that teens are using, not a model in isolation over an API". Traditional benchmarks, he pointed out, are often based on collections of single-turn conversations, which do not necessarily capture how teenagers interact with these products.

The assessment found that chatbots frequently missed warning signs of mental-health distress, including when users disclosed them indirectly.

The researchers also found a marked difference between isolated prompts and longer interactions: while safeguards performed better when presented with explicit, single-turn prompts, they became

less reliable over extended conversations that more closely resembled how young people might actually use a chatbot.

The Common Sense-Stanford assessment also warned that the features that make chatbots engaging, including empathetic responses, follow-up questions and memory, could encourage young users to rely on them for emotional support when human intervention may be necessary.

Asked whether OpenAI had tested the teen experience over sustained interactions, Misra said ChatGPT for Teens was supported by "ongoing safety research, red-teaming, evaluations, and adversarial testing", including teen-specific evaluations covering self-harm, eating disorders, violence, age-restricted goods and services, and sexual content.

"The experience also includes proportionate break prompts during unusually long, active sessions, along with safeguards designed to reinforce real-world support and reduce emotional dependence," she said.

Different user needs

OpenAI has acknowledged that safety features designed for Indian teenagers may run into a unique set of challenges. The Teen Safety Blueprint for India notes that Indian teenagers often access technology in "shared, multilingual and mediated contexts", rather than through the single-user, private devices many safety tools assume.

The RATTI report notes that this divide is amplified in rural and low-income contexts. Only half of the teenagers surveyed had a personal email ID, compared with 28% among rural low-income teenagers.

This divide matters because how some of the additional safeguards work. Parents can link their ChatGPT account to their teenager's through an email invitation, after which they can set quiet hours, manage certain settings and receive safety notifications. This could put teenagers in lower-care households at a disadvantage in using these parental controls.

LONGER VERSION

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ECONOMY

Worries behind India's robust GDP, inflation data

Six months after the war in West Asia broke out, the Indian economy appears to be holding up. But several risks to growth remain.



GRAPHS, DATA, PERSPECTIVES
BY UDIT MISRA

WEEKLY ECONOMIC AND POLICY INSIGHTS USING DATA

OVER THE past three financial years, the Indian economy recorded a GDP (gross domestic product) growth rate of more than 7%, alongside a sharp drop in the inflation rate. Many analysts expected the US-Israeli War on Iran to dent this trajectory, owing to factors like an increase in the prices of crude oil and a reduction in foreign investments. Making matters worse was the prospect of high temperatures thanks to El Niño, which threatened to hit food production.

The growth rate was expected to fall, while the inflation rate was expected to skyrocket from 2% in 2025-26 to near 6% — from the lower end of RBI's "comfort zone" to its upper limit. On May 11, Prime Minister Narendra Modi even appealed to Indians to tighten their belts by stopping gold purchases and reducing fuel consumption, among other measures.

But macroeconomic data shows India hasn't fared as poorly as feared. On Monday, GDP data for Q1 will be released and is expected to yet again cross the 7% mark.

Resilient economy?

Six months since the war began, the GDP growth rate, inflation rate, and current account balance do not show the impairment initially feared.

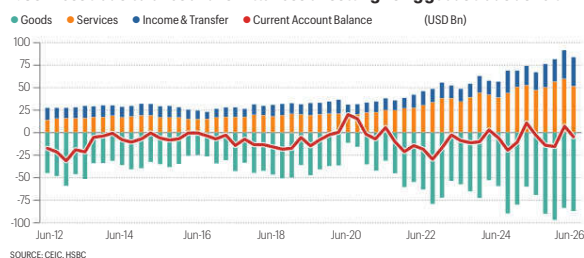
A research note from HSBC states: "Growth remains high, inflation remains low, and the current account deficit surprisingly contained. Headline numbers across the board feel more goldilocks than crisis."

"Goldilocks" refers to a term analysts used at the start of the year to describe the economy, referring to an optimal state of affairs. The term, however, quickly lost favour once the West Asia war exposed persistent weaknesses in the Indian economy, best captured by the sharp fall in the rupee's exchange rate. As such, it makes sense to examine whether the economy has genuinely returned to a "Goldilocks" scenario or if the data hides risks.

On GDP growth

In a detailed note, HSBC economists led by Pranjal Bhandari have explained both scenarios — why India's macros did not worsen as much as expected, and the

1. Services trade balance and remittances offsetting rising goods trade deficit



SOURCE: CEC, HSBC

triggers that could make the picture worse.

HSBC's 100-indicators of growth data base points towards India's GDP growing by 7-7.5% during the first quarter (April, May and June). SBI's research team has gone a step further, projecting an 8% growth.

What's driving this? Some of it can be ascribed to the 125-basis point cut in the repo rate between December 2024 and December 2025. The repo rate is the interest rate at which the RBI lends money to commercial banks. A lower repo rate makes it cheaper for banks to borrow money from the RBI and, in turn, cheaper for individuals and businesses to borrow from commercial banks. Cheaper loans incentivise economic activity, thus boosting growth. Often the "transmission" of a repo rate cut takes a couple of quarters to show up as faster GDP growth.

Another factor could be the effect of cuts in Goods and Services Tax in 2025. Lower tax rates reduced prices and improved people's purchasing power, resulting in higher economic activity. Yet another factor noted by HSBC economists is the rise of India's exports to the US as Donald Trump's tariffs were removed. Lastly, evidence suggests that manufacturers front-loaded production as they were anxious about future energy availability.

On inflation, CAD

First, while the monthly retail inflation rate — the rate at which the general price level went up over the year — has moved up since October, it is still well-contained and near the RBI's target level of 4% (see chart). Often, inflation remains muted be-

Heavy lifter

HSBC researchers argue that it is the services sector that is saving India the blushes as of now.

Accounting for 55% of India's GDP, the sector heavily affects where growth and inflation will land and how external deficits will be contained.

cause growth is muted. In this case, however, inflation has remained muted despite supply pressures, as well as demand holding up fairly well.

Secondly, the current account refers to the net amount of money flowing in or out of India as it trades (exports and imports) goods and services with the world. Typically, when the GDP is growing fast, or when imports are getting costlier, the country imports more than it exports, leading to a trade deficit. It translates into the outflow of billions of dollars.

What India often earns from exports of services (like software services) as well as from remittances from Indians working abroad is not enough to make up for the dollars India shells out for imports, in general. The net result is called a current account deficit (CAD). But despite fast growth and costlier imports, India's CAD too has remained fairly muted. "The headline c/a deficit is low at 0.3% of GDP as per RBI's aggregated monthly data, and not showing signs of excesses," note HSBC economists (see chart).

Reading the numbers

While macro indicators look counter-intuitively robust on the face of it, risks to growth and inflation persist.

On growth, HSBC researchers state that a lot of the credit growth (increased loans) has been driven by factors such as "the new government credit guarantee scheme for small firms, the rise in working capital needs spurred by higher commodity prices, and the proliferation of gold loan growth (which can sometimes be seen as

an indicator of stress)". Moreover, the front-loading of manufacturing could be followed by a lull, and agricultural growth could weaken if the El Niño strengthens.

On inflation, the overall benign levels hide fairly divergent trends. HSBC Research stated that food inflation and non-food goods inflation are already averaging 5.4% (year-on-year) in July (see chart). What is holding back the headline inflation from surging is that services have remained "remarkably low at 2.5%". Therein lies the risk. "Low services inflation data is keeping headline (rate) contained. If it rises from here, reflecting growth better, headline inflation numbers could rise quickly," notes HSBC.

Similarly, on CAD, a closer look at the chart shows that it is low as of now because even though the goods trade deficit is growing, rising services exports and remittances are offsetting the rise in the trade deficit. HSBC states, "Given the uncertainties around the impact of AI on services exports growth, one needs to be careful on how long services can fund a rising goods deficit. Already, services exports have grown at a softer pace this year."

Few expected India to survive this phase of global disruption without taking a big hit. HSBC researchers argue that it is the services sector that is saving India the blushes as of now. Accounting for 55% of India's GDP, the sector plays a crucial role in determining where growth will land, how long inflation will remain low, and until when external deficits will be contained. If services inflation goes up and services exports take a hit, the RBI may be forced to raise interest rates, which could dampen growth.

DEFENCE

Why India took 16 years to acquire fire-and-forget Javelin missiles

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, August 30

AFTER YEARS of deliberation, India finalised a deal last week to purchase the Javelin anti-tank guided missile (ATGM) system from the US through the latter's Foreign Military Sales (FMS) process.

The journey to procure the Javelin system, which began in 2010 and has now culminated after several passed attempts, highlights the lengthy and complicated nature of major defence acquisitions in India.

Initial interest

In August 2010, then Defence Minister A K Antony told Parliament that the government intended to procure third-generation Javelin ATGMs through the FMS route, which would also include a transfer of technology (TOT). The move was fuelled by a shortage of ATGMs in the Indian Army's inventory and a delay in the original timelines of indigenous ATGM systems developed by the Defence Research and Development Organisation.

The idea was to replace the ageing



Milan-2T and the Konkurs missile systems in use with the Army. Javelin was highly sought as the choice to immediately fill up the ATGM gaps, after the US forces actively showcased them during the 2009 bilateral exercise "Yudh Abhyas".

But the acquisition was eventually shelved owing to stringent technology transfer restrictions imposed by Washington. The US refused to share the missile's core seeker technology under a 100% TOT model,

The Javelin anti-tank guided missile system.

LOCKHEED MARTIN

causing India to pivot to Israel's Spike missile system — manufactured by Rafael Advanced Defense Systems Ltd — in 2014.

Deal for Spike

In 2014, India decided to go ahead with the Spike ATGMs as against the Javelin, after it was understood that it could offer greater flexibility of technology transfer and local production. The Defence Acquisition Council cleared the purchase of over 8,000 Spike ATGMs. But this also ran into long contract negotiations. Concerns over the Spike's performance in trials, technology transfer, and progress in India's man-portable ATGM programme led to a cancellation of the \$500 million order in 2017.

The deal was revived in 2018 following Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's visit, but was subsequently shelved again. India, however, undertook an emergency purchase of a limited quantity of the fourth-generation Spike-LR ATGMs in 2019 to meet an immediate operational gap.

In August 2023, Kalyani Rafael Advanced Systems Pvt Ltd — a joint venture between Indian conglomerate Kalyani

Group and Rafael — said it had bagged a Rs 287.51 crore order from the Defence Ministry for the supply of the missile systems.

Back to Javelin

The Javelin reappeared in India-US strategic discussions at a time when defence cooperation between both countries had deepened. A US Congressional Research Service report, updated in 2025, noted that co-production discussions involving the Javelin were ongoing.

In February 2025, the Javelin Joint Venture — a partnership between US defence majors Lockheed Martin and Raytheon — said it was exploring co-assembly and co-production opportunities of the Javelin in India. It signed a memorandum of understanding with Bharat Dynamics Limited.

The discussion gained pace after Operation Sindoor in May last year. By July 2025, India was negotiating to get the Javelin systems, both as an emergency procurement and through a long-term contract — the latter likely involving co-production of the weapon systems. In November 2025, Washington officially cleared the sale.



The Indian EXPRESS

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RAMNATH GOENKA

IN 1932

BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

As glaciers melt, prepare for Himalayan challenge

THE HIMALAYAN mountain system is the ecological mainstay of large parts of the Indian Subcontinent. It is the wellspring of rivers and shapes the monsoon. Its forests support biodiversity, and the region is home to several pilgrimage centres. However, the range has become increasingly fragile in recent years. The mounting toll of the flash floods that struck Nepal last week after a glacier collapse near the country's border with China sent torrents of water down the Bhoti Koshi River is a grim reminder of the region's precarity. It underscores how a disturbance in higher altitudes can swiftly become a downstream catastrophe.

Several studies, including IPCC reports, have documented the retreat of glaciers in the rapidly warming Himalaya. The meltwater accumulates in glacial lakes, many of which are held back by unstable dams of boulders. These lakes can suddenly burst, sending enormous volumes of water and debris down narrow valleys. Landslides, avalanches and erratic rainfall can trigger cascading events. The Nepal disaster appears to have involved an ice-and-rock avalanche. It is not an isolated incident. A glacial lake outburst in Nepal's Everest region led to massive flooding two years ago. A 2021 study by scientists from IIT Roorkee, IISc Bengaluru, University of Dayton, University of Graz, and the Universities of Zurich and Regensburg suggested that the Khimti Lake in Sikkim. The warning went largely unheeded — the lake burst two years later, killing at least 50 people.

The expansion of roads, hydropower schemes and tourism facilities in the valleys has added another layer of risk. Such projects are necessary for livelihoods, energy security and connectivity. But infrastructure development must factor in the idiosyncrasies of mountain ecology. Environmental assessments must account for the cumulative risks from infrastructure projects, while construction standards must reflect the requirements of an unstable landscape. Glaciers need continuous monitoring, with information shared across borders because Himalayan rivers and hazards do not respect political boundaries. Some efforts are underway. India is accelerating early-warning systems for the region's lakes, while Nepal and China share information on Himalayan ecology. But last week's disaster is a stark reminder of how much more needs to be done. The Bhoti Koshi's warning system, designed to track the gradual movement of glacial water, could not detect the sudden surge of debris. The experience of Switzerland, where advance monitoring and evacuation helped limit casualties after a glacier collapse destroyed much of the Blatten region in 2025, offers useful lessons. The geology of the Alps and Himalaya is, of course, vastly different. Even then, the salience of sharing expertise across mountainous regions cannot be understated. These imperatives must now be integrated into technology transfer programmes under climate pacts.

Meta's US deal redraws line of accountability

THE SETTLEMENT between Meta and 29 US states over the harm its platforms can cause children is a veiled admission of truth that Big Tech has spent years resisting. That these platforms are built to capture attention, and therefore have responsibility towards how they affect young users. Meta will pay up to \$18 billion over a decade and introduce a series of restrictions on Facebook and Instagram, including two-hour daily limits for under-18 users, a midnight-to-6 am curfew, stronger age verification mechanisms, default safety settings, and reduced notifications during school hours. The company has denied wrongdoing, and the settlement leaves untouched some of the more fundamental questions about personalised recommendations and the advertising-driven business model. Even so, it marks a significant step towards recognising that children's safety can no longer be treated as a matter of self-control or parental vigilance, that product design itself should come under regulatory scrutiny.

That is the direction that global regulation has been increasingly moving towards. There is a recognition of the fact that these platforms are built to make stopping difficult — the infinite scroll ensures recommendations continuously supply the next piece of content; notifications and other "hooks" are designed to bring users back; likes, streaks and personalised feeds turn attention into a measurable commodity. They are features of an engagement economy in which time spent is valuable because attention can be monetised. Technology companies have long pushed much of the responsibility towards parents who must monitor screen time and users who must exercise self-control. The new curbs begin to move responsibility upstream, towards the companies that build and profit from systems engineered to resist disengagement.

The American settlement offers a useful model for India as it contemplates regulation around children's social-media usage. A system reliant solely on parental supervision will inevitably leave protection uneven, depending on digital literacy, time, and household resources. Regulation should instead ask harder questions of the platforms: Why should an engagement-maximising feed be the default for a child? Why should a young user have to opt out of personalisation rather than have a safer feed by default? And why should the burden of resisting an infinite stream of content fall on the user rather than on the company that created it? Meta's US deal could mark the beginning of a broader effort to redraw the boundaries of responsibility.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



When one moves away from the language of backwardness towards that of caste oppression, the picture becomes clearer

On OBCs, the way forward is to shift the frame



ROHAN MANOJ

ONE OF the most famous Malayalam novels, Thakazhi Vasankaran Pillai's *Kayar*, chronicles social change in central Travancore over the 19th and early 20th centuries. In one passage, Thakazhi touches on one of the most important realities of caste. The patriarch of a prominent real-life Ezhava family, with the hereditary title of *channar*, is educated, extremely rich and highly orthodox. If he encounters any "Shudra" (Nair) on the road, he will move aside, maintaining the distance prescribed for Ezhavas under the system of "untouchability" — because he wants "Parayans and Pulayans" (Dalits) to keep moving aside for him.

If this *channar* were alive today, how would he be classified? OBC, being an Ezhava? But how "socially and educationally backward" is he? Creamy-layer? Very Shudra? No — in south India, especially Shudras were often dominant castes, as seen above. "Untouchable"? Yes. Does that make him a Dalit? Probably not. Such examples demonstrate the incoherence of "backwardness" as a rubric to classify castes, as does the inclusion of dominant and upper castes. When "backward" encompasses both former "untouchables" and former kings, little survives of conceptual coherence. Without shared experience, there can be no shared identity. And when income becomes the criterion, Trojan Horses such as quotas for "economically weaker sections" of the upper castes infiltrate the system.

There are at least three ongoing developments that should be of particular concern to OBCs. First, the sabotage of the caste count in the Census through the use of an open column. Second, the government telling the Supreme Court that it is reconsidering the UGC Equity Regulations. And third, the government pushing back on implementing a Supreme Court judgment against the mechanical consideration of parents' salaries to identify and exclude creamy-layer candidates selected in the civil services examinations.

Will any of this lead to an OBC reaction? Some activists are trying to raise awareness, but a response proportionate to the political power of this demographic is unlikely. Little solidarity has been built within the category across regions and individual castes.

AS A frequent visitor to the Himalayan region in India, Nepal and Bhutan over four decades, I have witnessed the relentless pollution of this majestic but fragile mountain zone. The eternal is becoming episodic as the snows covering the high peaks melt at an accelerated pace from global warming, exacerbated by indiscriminate ecological degradation. Despite persistent and alarming warning signs, human greed and cupidity have continued to provoke the fury of the mountains, visiting death and destruction on communities residing in their valleys and along river banks.

Nepal is the latest victim of catastrophic flash floods, sweeping down from mountains just across the border with Tibet, caused by what is technically termed a glacial lake outburst flood (GLOF). A mountain river upstream may be blocked by a portion of a glacier breaking away or by an avalanche, thereby forming a lake. When the loose banks of this lake burst under pressure, then a huge volume of water hurtles downstream. It is reported that about 20 km east of the Rasuwagadhi Nepal-Tibet border crossing, a massive avalanche brought surging waters and sheets of mud down the Lhunde River, sweeping away villages, settlements, and a large number of people downstream. The avalanche may have been triggered by a 4.4 magnitude earthquake recorded in the area just minutes earlier.

The border crossing connects Nepal's Rasuwagadhi with Ghyrong county on the Tibetan side. Chinese media report similar loss of life and property across the border. The flash floods spread south from Rasuwagadhi, Gorkha and Nuwakot districts in Nepal, and the impact will be felt across the border in India. At least six hydropower

projects downstream have been wiped out, causing a loss of 405 MW of power capacity, constituting 12 per cent of the national total. This is a loss of power that Nepal can ill afford. Recovery and rehabilitation may take several years. Some video reports on this Himalayan tsunami are most disturbing. One sees a huge wall of water and mud tossing aside buildings, cars and frightened people with an elemental fury — a reminder once again of how utterly defenceless humanity can be before the raw power of nature.

Rasuwagadhi is the most important border crossing between Nepal and Tibet for trade as well as tourism, including for pilgrim tours to the holy Kailash-Mansarovar. It is reported that over 160 Indian pilgrims are missing. The hotels and guest houses in which they were staying were washed away in the flood. Cross-border trade and traffic are likely to remain suspended for the foreseeable future.

India has been quick to respond to the disaster in a friendly neighbouring country, sending urgent medical and food supplies and specialised rescue teams.

There are 48,000 sq km of glaciers spread over the Himalaya. Another 18,000 sq km are located in the Karakoram. Researchers have mapped over 5,000 glacial lakes in the Himalaya, of which about 500 are classified as "hazardous" or "significantly hazardous". There have been at least 388 recorded instances of GLOF so far in the Himalaya-Karakoram mountains but their frequency has been increasing in recent years.

In August 2025, there was a GLOF event in Dharali in Uttarakhand on the route to Gangotri, which caused large-scale loss of life and property. One should also recall the 2013 Kedarnath flash flood caused by a combination of torrential rains and a GLOF at the Chorabari lake to the north. The surge of flood waters and debris washed away towns and settlements along the highway to Gangotri. In the immediate aftermath, there was talk of how the human carrying capacity of these remote pilgrimage places should be assessed and strictly observed. No construction 500 metres from the river banks was to be permitted hereafter. But no lessons have been learnt.

Hotels and guest houses have mushroomed once again on the river banks. During the pilgrimage season, Kedarnath may have a daily turnover of 15-20,000 pilgrims. Even at 18,000 feet elevation, there are pre-fab guest houses, restaurants and dhabs with gas cylinders being transported back and forth for heating and cooking. There are no proper arrangements for waste management. The Uttarakhand government is reportedly considering making Badrinath and Kedarnath open for pilgrimage the whole year round.

Hydropower development continues apace in the Himalayas despite the risk of GLOF and earthquakes. This is known to be an active seismic zone. In October 2023, a GLOF from the South Lhonak lake in Sikkim completely washed away the 1200 MW Teesta-III hydropower dam and power station. Earlier in 2021, a sudden flash flood triggered by a glacial collapse in Chamoli in Uttarakhand wiped out the Rishiganga Hydropower project and blocked the associated Chamoli tunnel.

Despite this mounting and compelling evidence, major hydropower projects continue to be pursued across the mountain zone, creating mounting risks to life and property. But these are being cynically ignored

The writer is senior assistant editor, The Indian Express. rohan.manoj@expressindia.com



SHYAM SARAN

Despite compelling evidence, major hydropower projects continue to be pursued across the mountain zone, creating mounting risks to life and property. But these are being cynically ignored

call the 2013 Kedarnath flash flood caused by a combination of torrential rains and a GLOF at the Chorabari lake to the north. The surge of flood waters and debris washed away towns and settlements along the highway to Gangotri. In the immediate aftermath, there was talk of how the human carrying capacity of these remote pilgrimage places should be assessed and strictly observed. No construction 500 metres from the river banks was to be permitted hereafter. But no lessons have been learnt.

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sued across the mountain zone, creating mounting risks to life and property. But these are being cynically ignored.

The three successive rivers that rise from the Tibetan plateau and flow through Nepal and India. There have been flash floods on some cross-border rivers that have caused large-scale damage on the Indian side.

The sharing of information and early warning between India and China has never been regular and has been subject to the state of their political relations. We now have, potentially, an even greater threat facing India from across the border with Tibet. China has begun constructing the gigantic Medog dam at the great bend of the Brahmaputra River just across the border. It is slated to deliver 300 billion kWh of power annually and will be several times larger than the largest hydro project in existence anywhere in the world, the Gezhouba on the Yangtze River, which is rated at 15.6 billion kWh of power annually. Chinese scientists have warned that the project sits very close to the Paizhen Fault, a major fracture in the Earth's crust, making it vulnerable to seismic events. Should there be a major earthquake in the project vicinity, there could be a massive discharge of flood waters and debris into India's Northeast.

The Himalayan glaciers have been a source of life-sustaining rivers for the entire Indo-Gangetic plain, populated by over 500 million people. It is this life-source that we are despoiling and for which our succeeding generations will pay the price. The mountains have sounded a loud warning of a cataclysm that lies around the corner. We ignore it at our collective peril.

The writer is a former foreign secretary and was ambassador to Nepal from 2002 to 2004

Unlocking soft power with Saptadharma



CV ANANDA BOSE

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi introduced Saptadharma from the Red Fort on August 15. This concept includes seven streams of national strength that can help India achieve its Viskit Bharat goal. One of these is soft power. Coined by Joseph Nye Jr, soft power is about influencing others through attraction and co-option. India has a wealth of soft power, including a long civilisational history, rich cultural diversity, and a strong tradition of knowledge. Yoga connects people worldwide with India. Ayurveda develops a philosophy of wellness. Our spiritual centres draw people seeking peace, and our festivals celebrate harmony and renewal. Indian literature, music, dance, and cinema transcend language barriers. Our cuisine is recognised globally. Handicrafts and handlooms reflect the skill and creativity of generations. India's democracy, scientific progress, digital systems, space programme, and global diplomacy further enhance its global reputation.

However, India lacks a coherent system to turn its cultural assets into influence, economic value, and sustainable livelihoods. Having cultural wealth doesn't guarantee global influence, and appreciation won't ensure income for artists or knowledge-holders. The Saptadharma vision offers a chance to fix this gap.

Each district should create a soft power and creative economy plan. This plan should identify local artists, artisans, writers, and cultural workers. It should connect them to training, technology, finance, intellectual property protection, local markets, and international opportunities. Experienced practitioners should mentor young apprentices. The *guru-shishya* system should receive modern support while staying authentic. Schools and universities should introduce studies in India's cultural diversity.

Soft power can drive significant employment. Areas like tourism, cinema, music, fashion, and education can create millions of jobs. The government should enable this growth. It should invest initially, set standards, connect markets, and be a first customer when possible. Cultural workers should not rely solely on grants but should be empowered to earn regular incomes.

A national mission can aim to create 1 crore new jobs in tourism, arts, media, and the creative economy. Districts should prepare soft-power employment plans. Indian missions abroad should facilitate market access and promote Indian culture and businesses. Success should be measured by real livelihoods created and opportunities gained. Missions can help creators create opportunities for touring, publishing, and international collaboration. Young people must be central to this movement. They should become creators and innovators. By blending heritage with technology, young Indians can share their stories and cultures with the world through digital platforms and new industries.

India does not need to create soft power; it should enhance, connect, and protect it. The path forward should be clear: *Kala* (art) to *kaushal* (skill), *kamai* (earning) to *rozgar* (employment), *bazaar* (market) to *viswva prabhu* (global influence). Saptadharma ensures that those who preserve traditions receive dignified livelihoods and that youth inherit both identity and opportunity. This way, India's cultural voice will confidently reach the world.

The writer is former governor of West Bengal

14 gunned down in Tripura

FOURTEEN PEOPLE were shot dead and 10 injured by Tribal National Volunteer (TNV) extremists at Siripuram village in Kamalpur sub-division of North Tripura district. A gang of 15 to 20 extremists, reportedly led by "general" Kartick Koloi, raided the village and resorted to indiscriminate firing.

PM holds pre-summit talks

THE OUTGOING chairman of the Non-Aligned Movement, Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi, opened pre-summit consultations with other

NAM leaders on his proposals to assist the frontline African states to counter the threat of retaliatory sanctions by South Africa. Gandhi, who arrived in Harare to a warm welcome, held talks with the Zimbabwean Prime Minister, Robert Mugabe, on the issue coming up before the summit.

Pakistan leader's claims

THE PRESIDENT of the Pakistani National Awami Party, Khan Abdul Wali Khan, who is the Soviet Union these days, has told the press in Moscow that Islamabad is interfering in India's internal affairs. He cited develop-

ments in Punjab. Wali Khan, son of the legendary Frontier Gandhi, Khan Abdul Gaffar Khan, has been in the forefront of the struggle for restoring democracy in Pakistan.

Civilian killed in border firing

JAGDISH LAL, a porter with the Army, was killed in firing by Pakistani troops in the 13th Digwar area, about 4 km from Poonch town. Poonch police chief Kuldeep Khanna said over the telephone. Jagdish Lal, who was in his early 30s, is the second civilian to be killed in firing by Pakistani troops in the Poonch sector this month.

40 YEARS AGO

August 31, 1986





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• **WHAT THE OTHERS SAY**
Israel must close down itself and its West Bank settlements.
—Haaretz, Israel

Atmanirbharta in fuel must strengthen, not undermine, India's food security



FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH
BY ASHOK GULATI
AND TANMOY ADHIKARI

SUGAR PRICES have spiked sharply within weeks. The all-India modal retail price climbed from around Rs 45/kg on July 24 to about Rs 65/kg by August 24 — a nearly 44 per cent increase in a month. The government has blamed traders and millers for hoarding and threatened strict action. While speculative behaviour may have amplified the spike, the deeper reality is a tightening of the supply situation just before the festive season.

Three supply-side pressures seem to have caused a "perfect storm". First, open stocks in the current sugar year (October to September) were significantly lower (5 MT) when compared to the situation last year (8 MT). The lower carry-over stocks reflected weak production in the previous season and left little room to absorb another supply shock.

Second, sugar production in 2025-26 fell short of expectations. The initial estimate was around 34.3 MT, but the government has now revised it to 30.6 MT, citing damage from red rot and top borer. About 27.35 MT of sugar had been produced by June, implying that another 3.25 MT would have to be produced during July-September to reach the revised estimate. Yet the production in these three months averaged only around 0.38 MMT over the previous six seasons. We expect a further downward revision of sugar production — between 28 and 29 MT.

Third, the ethanol programme diverted about 2.75 MT of sugar even when supplies were tight. The more important issue is that ethanol blending has progressed much



ILLUSTRATION: C R SAKSHI

faster than feedstock supplies. Ethanol blending remained largely stagnant for years, reaching only 1.53 per cent in 2013-14, before accelerating to around 5 per cent by 2019-20 and ultimately 20 per cent in 2025-26. The feedstock supplies could not keep pace with the blending programme. No wonder energy policy started competing with food markets.

The timing is particularly difficult. The festive season is approaching, when sugar demand typically rises, while fresh cane supplies will not arrive in significant quantities until mid-October. The market must, therefore, rely on existing stocks for many more weeks. Thin inventories are pushing up sugar prices, which could go even higher if timely action is not taken.

In a more open economy, a production shortfall would normally be corrected through price signals triggering imports and changes in consumption. But India's sugar sector remains heavily regulated. Sugar cane pricing, sugar sales, imports, exports and ethanol feedstock allocation are decided by the government. When the government controls every step of the sugar/ethanol value chain, the resulting spike in sugar prices also has to be owned by the government. It is a classic case of policy failure.

The government's response so far has been to allow 1 MT of duty-

free raw sugar imports. We feel this is too little, too late. Our calculations suggest that the government needs to import at least 3-4 MT of refined sugar and increase supplies in the open market before and during the festive season. The import duty on refined sugar (100 per cent) must be slashed to zero or just 5 per cent.

The second response should be to temporarily alter the ethanol feedstock mix. Sugar-based ethanol should be drastically reduced, with greater use of alternative feedstocks. FCI is overflowing with rice stocks far in excess of buffer norms. The government can allocate more from these stocks and minimise the use of sugar for ethanol. But FCI must charge at least the procurement price of rice from ethanol plants, if not its full economic cost.

However, maize is the best option as a feedstock for ethanol. It doesn't guzzle as much water as rice or sugarcane. The government is already using maize as a primary feedstock for ethanol. Although maize production has been increasing over the last decade or so, our productivity levels hover around 3.5 tonnes/ha — way below the US's 11 tonnes/ha. Further use of maize for ethanol without a commensurate increase in production will put pressure on maize prices and, consequently, on poultry meat,

eggs, and milk, where it has been the main feed. Thus, shifting from sugar to rice or maize does not eliminate the food-fuel trade-off. The only way to generate large surpluses of maize by raising its productivity, would India allow GM maize, which drives US yields?

The third response could be either to directly import ethanol, when domestic supplies are putting pressure on food prices, or reduce the blending from 20 per cent to about 15 per cent.

The deeper lesson is that India's ethanol programme needs a little rethink and recalibration. We need to know the net energy balance with different feedstocks. Rather than rigidly allocating the amount of ethanol from sugar, rice or maize, oil marketing companies could be given flexibility to choose the most economical source, subject to safeguards for food security, farmers and the environment. The government should focus on strategic buffers and food-security safeguards rather than managing every feedstock allocation.

The immediate response is clear: Bring in enough sugar to rebuild the stock cushion, temporarily shift ethanol away from sugar, use FCI grain only when genuine surplus exists, and retain imported ethanol as a safety valve. Maize-based ethanol would save water and would be more benign to the environment. But we need to invest more in raising its productivity. India's ethanol programme has made major strides, and going from 5 per cent blending in 2019-20 to 20 per cent in 2025-26 is putting huge demand on its feedstocks. Overall, we feel that fuel self-reliance should never force a choice between food and fuel. *Atmanirbharta* in fuel must strengthen, not undermine, India's food security; food must remain the higher-order priority.

We hope the Modi government can undertake a 360-degree evaluation of its ethanol programme and recalibrate the policy design so that it does not push up food prices.

Gulati is distinguished professor and Adhikari a research assistant at ICRIER. Views are personal

Believing in her strength, putting her at the centre of nation's story



VASUNDHARA RAJE SCINDIA

IN 2001, as Gujarat Chief Minister, Narendra Modi had certain rituals performed. The obvious choice to carry the sacred *kalash* would have been a *purohit* or a *mahatma*. Breaking with convention, Modi chose Ravina Jadav, a Dalit girl who lived in a slum. For him, the dignity of women was the first step towards their empowerment. Over the years, he has shared with me, and several others, his conviction that dignity should never be reserved for the powerful, and that those at the margins must be brought to the forefront.

I have seen this conviction from close quarters. Women who had, for generations, remained outside the circle of opportunity were to be partners in development, decision-makers and leaders, and not just recipients of welfare. For someone who has spent much of her public life witnessing the aspirations of women in villages and cities, this distinction has always been important. Empowerment means creating an environment in which a girl can grow into a confident citizen — her basic needs are secured and she is given the tools and opportunities to reach for the sky.

Modi's years in Gujarat set the template. He launched the Kanya Kelavani Yojana for girls' education and travelled from village to village to urge parents to send their daughters to school. Over the years, in one form or another, states across India, including those governed by political opponents, adopted, adapted and renamed similar schemes. After the Kutch earthquake, he asked that rebuilt homes be registered in the name of both husband and wife. He also confronted the entrenched practice of the sarpanch *pati*, telling women sarpanches plainly: "The power is yours, and you alone must exercise it."

After taking over as Prime Minister, he launched schemes for women, placed them at the centre of India's economic transformation and envisaged them as drivers of the economy. Under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana, crores of women got bank accounts for the first time in their lives. Sixty-eight per cent of beneficiaries of the MUDRA scheme are women. There is extraordinary power in a woman having

a bank account in her own name, and access to credit that she can draw upon herself. I witnessed this transformation on Women's Day in 2018, when the Prime Minister came to Jhunjhunu in Rajasthan. He launched the Beti Bachao Beti Padhao (BBBP) Abhiyan nationwide and also initiated the nationwide Poshan Abhiyan, the country's flagship nutrition mission. I was witness to the excitement of a crowd of more than 1,00,000 people, nearly half of them women. BBBP now also focuses on increasing girls' participation in vocational training in areas traditionally dominated by men.

The NaMo Droni Dide scheme places agricultural drones in the hands of 15,000 women's self-help groups. More than 75 per cent of beneficiaries of the Stand-Up India scheme are women entrepreneurs.

Under Modi's leadership, women were granted permanent commissions in the armed forces, admitted to the National Defence Academy and inducted into combat roles. Squadron Leader Shivangi Singh made history as India's first woman fighter pilot to qualify as a flying instructor, and she flies the Rafale. The Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam — reserving a third of the Parliament seats for women — passed under his leadership.

Several Opposition leaders lecture the nation on women's rights while governments led by their own parties struggle to find room for women at the decision-making table. Under Modi's leadership, in contrast, women have occupied important offices — from Parliament to Rashtrapati Bhavan, from the battlefield to the boardroom. The difference between the two approaches is the difference between a slogan and a life-long commitment.

Symbolism matters in India. For PM Modi, however, symbolism has always carried substance. On International Women's Day in 2020, he did something unprecedented. He temporarily handed over his social-media accounts, followed by millions, to seven women achievers. He repeated the gesture in 2025, and this time Rishi Sunak's Aajeeb Shah was among those who were recognised. Shah, a Tufts University alumna, has worked tirelessly to empower women, including in Dholpur in Rajasthan.

I have known Narendra Modi as a *karyakarta*, a guide and a leader. India has known him as a man who believed in the strength of its women long before many others did.

The writer, a former Rajasthan chief minister, is vice president, BJP

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Preparing for disaster

THIS IS not a man-made tragedy; it is the result of nature's fury ('Himalaya needs shared early-warning system', *IE*, August 28). But does this mean people should avoid living in places identified as vulnerable to natural disasters? Should governments also refrain from developing such vulnerable areas as tourist destinations without adequate safeguards? We must follow the time-tested adage, "Prevention is better than cure." Governments and people must therefore exercise greater caution in identifying disaster-prone areas, regulating construction and human habitation, and ensuring adequate preparedness.

Tharcus S Fernando, Chennai

NEPAL HAS again been hit by a major natural disaster ('Himalaya needs shared early-warning system', *IE*, August 28). The floods also raise a larger question: Are they purely natural events, or are human actions and climate change aggravating their impact? Global warming is accelerating glacier melt, weakening mountain slopes and increasing the risks of landslides and sudden flooding. The Rasuwagadhi floods in 2016 highlighted the importance of timely sharing of weather- and flood-related information across borders. Yet the latest incident suggests gaps persist in information-sharing between Nepal and China.

Tushar A Rahatgaonkar, Dombivli East

Take a break

THIS IS one of the most relatable pieces I have read as a teenager in this newspaper ('Don't herd children through narrow tunnels', *IE*, August 28). Parents and children alike do not know where they are trying to reach when parents get their children involved in various activities. Parents are often confused about what the future holds, and in order to create a false sense of control, they enrol their kids in a score of different activities, thinking they are making them better prepared. This has made children unable to experience boredom. Children, like everyone else, need time to think. Time to take a break.

Divot Rao, Gurugram



GITANALI J ANGMO

Don't make Vande Mataram a religious quarrel

IT TOOK until India's 80th Independence Day for 'Vande Mataram' to be rendered, for the first time, as part of the celebrations at the Red Fort. There was something strangely poignant about it. The war cry that had escaped a novel, entered the streets, unlearned an empire and accompanied bravehearts to prisons and gallows has taken nearly eight decades to reach independent India's most symbolic ramparts.

But even this sacred inheritance is not without its share of objectionable arguments. Veteran actor Sharmila Tagore and many others, like the Congress in 1937, proposed restricting its national use to the first two stanzas. How can a Muslim bow to Durga, Lakshmi and Saraswati invoked in its later verses? Doesn't its origin in Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's *Anandamath*, with its difficult depiction of Muslim rule, make it exclusionary? Was India even a nation when Bankim imagined her as Mother?

These are not frivolous questions. But sometimes answers lie in recovering meanings we have lost. India was certainly not a modern nation-state for most of her history. India imagined herself differently. Long before passport, parliament or political boundary stood Bharatavarsa: a cultural and spiritual geography. The *Vishnu Purana* describes Bharata as the land north of the ocean and south of the Himalayas. Across this vastness, languages, customs, deities and philosophies differed, yet beneath them ran the same insistent question: What is the ultimate reality,

and how may the human being know it? Kashmiri answered through its Shaivism; Karnataka through Madhva's Dvaita; Dwarika worshipped Krishna.

India did not wait for the modern state to know herself. Her unity lay in a civilisation asking the eternal questions in a thousand different ways. This is where Sri Aurobindo helps us understand 'Vande Mataram'. He called Bankim a *rishi* who had taught Indians to see India: "The mantra had been given. The Mother had revealed herself."

What Mother? Look again at Bankim's poem. She first comes without weapons, crowns or temples. She is *sujalam, suphalam*: Abundant waters, cool breeze, green harvests, moonlit nights, flowering trees. Before she is Goddess, she is the land beneath our feet. Perhaps patriotism begins in such intimacy: A river remembered from childhood; the language in which one's grandmother told stories; the smell of the first rain, food, music, mountains, festivals, memories. Slowly, geography becomes beloved. Earth becomes Mother.

Sri Aurobindo took this further. A nation, he wrote, was "not a piece of earth". It was the *shakti* of its millions: A living being formed by its people, culture, civilisation, and aspiration. It helps us understand Bankim's Durga, Lakshmi and Saraswati. Read literally, and we have three Hindu goddesses and, inevitably, another TV debate. But India has always spoken through symbols. Durga is *shakti*; Lakshmi is abundance; Saraswati is knowledge.

In Bankim's poem, she first comes without weapons, crowns or temples. She is 'sujalam', 'suphalam': abundant waters, cool breeze, green harvests, moonlit nights. Before she is Goddess, she is the land beneath our feet

Strength. Prosperity. Knowledge. Which civilisation does not need all three? A Muslim need not worship Durga to value courage. A Christian need not worship Lakshmi to desire prosperity for India. An atheist need not worship Saraswati to hold knowledge sacred. The imagery is culturally Indian; what it signifies is universal.

The tragedy is in reducing 'Vande Mataram' to a religious quarrel. One sees a Hindu goddess and feels excluded; another sees a Hindu goddess and wishes to exclude. But if she is the 'shakti of her millions', the Muslim farmer, Christian nurse, Sikh soldier, Jain businessman, Buddhist monk, and atheist scientist are not guests in somebody else's India. They are strands of her being.

Perhaps that is why the Red Fort moment mattered. Not because everyone must now sing 'Vande Mataram', but because an old song returned carrying a question for our future: What do these two words ask of us?

If India is merely territory, citizenship becomes transactional: What are my rights? What do I receive? But if India is Mother, the grammar of patriotism changes. Rights remain, but responsibility enters. The question turns from "What has India given me?" to "What am I giving India?" That is the enduring power of Bankim's two words. Not an instruction to worship a goddess, but an invitation to enter into a relationship with her. The nation-state may be modern. The Mother is ancient. The relationship is sacred. And so we bow to her. *Vande Mataram*.

The writer is founder, Himalayan Institute for Alternatives, Ladakh

Typhoid control needs more vaccine, less antibiotic



KAMINI WALLA

EVERYONE is talking about increasing influenza and swine flu cases. Another disease where cases are unobtrusively mounting is typhoid. This should concern us, not simply because typhoid remains a common infection, but because every suspected case can become a trigger for inappropriate or unnecessarily broad-spectrum antibiotic use.

Typhoid presents a particularly difficult paradox. It is a vaccine-preventable bacterial disease, yet in India we continue to diagnose it imperfectly and treat it empirically. The fundamental problem is the absence of a simple, reliable, accessible diagnostic test. A single Widal test is not sufficient to establish

a diagnosis of acute typhoid. In an endemic country such as India, background antibodies and previous exposure to vaccination can make interpretation difficult. Yet, in routine practice, a positive Widal result may still be treated as confirmation of typhoid.

Blood culture remains the conventional laboratory standard, but it too has limitations. The WHO's latest typhoid guidance notes that the sensitivity of a single blood culture is only around 55-60 per cent, with yield influenced by the volume of blood collected and, critically, prior antimicrobial exposure. This creates a vicious cycle: A patient develops prolonged fever, takes an antibiotic before seeking care, undergoes blood culture, and receives a negative result. The clinician is left with suspicion but no microbiological confirmation — and may respond by escalating or changing antibiotics.

The result is an antimicrobial-resistance (AMR) problem. In a country already struggling with increasing resistance to *Salmonella typhi*, every unnecessary antibiotic course creates additional selection pressure, while every missed diagnosis undermines surveillance of resistance patterns. But there is another question we should be asking: Why are we trying to solve a vaccine-preventable disease primarily through antibiotics? India is one of the countries where the case for typhoid

vaccination is compelling. The WHO has prioritised typhoid-conjugate vaccine (TCV) introduction in countries with high AMR levels. India has already produced the world's first WHO-prequalified TCV, Typhar-TCV, in 2017. Since then, additional Indian TCV products have achieved WHO prequalification. The scientific and manufacturing capability exists. The vaccine exists. What remains inadequate is the scale and rigour of use.

Vaccination should not be viewed as a substitute for clean water, sanitation, food safety or better diagnostics. It must be part of an integrated typhoid-control strategy.

First, reports of increasing typhoid should trigger strengthened surveillance. Hospitals and laboratories should systematically document suspected and culture-confirmed cases, antimicrobial susceptibility

patterns and prior antibiotic exposure.

Second, diagnostic stewardship needs to become part of antimicrobial stewardship. Blood cultures should ideally be obtained before antibiotics are started, with adequate blood volume and appropriate laboratory practices. India also needs investment in a better point-of-care or rapid diagnostic test for typhoid. We also need to revisit the place of TCV in our public-health strategy.

We should respond to the rising typhoid cases with better diagnostics, stronger surveillance, responsible antimicrobial use, and, above all, prevention. India should not have to choose between better diagnosis and vaccination. It needs both.

The writer is senior scientist and programme officer, AMR, ICMR

NEPAL DISASTER: DIFFICULT TERRAIN AND FORMATION OF NEW 'DAM LAKE' ADD TO WOES

Toll rises to 788, rescuers keep digging

Bhotokoshi river rises, authorities call for caution

Press Trust of India
Kathmandu, August 30

THE DEATH toll from flash floods in Nepal rose to 788 Saturday, with bodies continuing to be recovered, as authorities warned of increased water levels in Bhotokoshi River and urged residents and rescue personnel in flood-hit districts to remain alert.

More than 2,500 people still remain missing, while nearly 9,500 people were rescued, according to the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRMA).

In a statement issued on Sunday, the NDRMA warned that water levels in the Bhotokoshi River had risen again. "The water level in the flooded Bhotokoshi River has risen to some extent; all concerned are urged to take precautionary measures," it said, adding that it will provide updates on the situation after receiving additional information.

data released by Nepal's education ministry, the missing persons include 238 students and 18 teachers from different schools in three flood-affected districts. Nearly 9,500 people were rescued from flood-affected areas till Sunday evening, which includes locals and tourists from multiple countries, including India, the US, China, Russia, the UK, Spain, Belgium, Germany, Italy, Malta, Turkey, Switzerland and Portugal, officials said. Photographs have been pasted outside hospital walls, where huge gatherings could be seen scanning them with attention. However, of the bodies recovered so far, only 17 have been identified, police said.

Nepal's Foreign Secretary Amrit Bahadur Rai said in a press briefing on Sunday that the mortal remains of victims who could not be identified, including those that were unrecognisable, amputated or decomposed due to prolonged exposure to water, had been buried following "standard and accepted protocols".

On Sunday, fresh reports said a landslide near the natural dam led to the formation of another "dam lake", prompting rescue personnel to evacuate the area.



Flood-hit houses covered in mud and sludge in the aftermath of the flash floods, in Nepal on Sunday. TASHI TORGYAL

'We will rebuild it': Families pick up pieces

Press Trust of India
Nuwakot, August 30

"EVERYTHING WAS here before, but now there is nothing left," said Nayan Tiwari, one of many residents returning to flood-hit Galchhi in central Nepal to recover whatever belongings remain and to restore homes that once held their everyday lives.

The August 26 flash floods, which originated in the Nepal-Tibet border, travelled downstream through the Bhotokoshi and Trishuli river systems, leaving a trail of destruction across

northern and central Nepal. The death toll crossed 750 on Sunday, while more than 2,500 people remained missing.

Survivors are now picking their way through mud and debris, families are searching for missing relatives and rescue teams continue to reach people stranded in the affected areas.

Tiwari, a Class 11 student, and his cousin Nivi Tiwari are among those trying to piece their lives back together.

The two have been clearing debris from their flood-damaged home, salvaging whatever they can find beneath layers of

mud and sand and separating belongings that can still be used as the family begins the painstaking task of rebuilding.

Nayan sai he was in Kathmandu when the flood struck. After learning what had happened, he immediately told his family in Galchhi to leave the house and move to safer, higher ground. Soon after they left, the flow intensified and swept away everything in its path.

Galchhi, in Dhading district of Bagmati province, lies about 50 km northwest of Kathmandu. For the Tiwari family, the house represents nearly a

decade of memories, including their childhood and years spent together. "It feels really bad. But we will rebuild it. We will work hard and make the house like it was before," Nayan said.

Nayan said more than 15 houses around their home were completely washed away by the powerful current. "I had never seen such a devastating flood before. When I came back and saw my house, I felt completely helpless," she said.

Despite the destruction, Nivi and her family have begun clearing the house and removing the debris.

Over 500 remain missing at hydropower projects

Press Trust of India
Kathmandu, August 30

NEPALI ARMY engineers intensified efforts on Sunday to reach people believed trapped inside Upper Trishuli-3A hydropower project tunnel in flood-hit Nuwakot, using heavy equipment and blasting to widen an opening into the buried structure.

As many as 537 workers and employees remained unaccounted for at nine hydropower projects in Nepal's flood-hit Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts, according to the Independent Power Producers' Association, Nepal (IPPAN). The Trishuli-3A project is among them, with 42 people reported out of contact at the 60 MW facility.

According to the PMO, a joint 90-member rescue team comprising 66 Nepali Army personnel, 18 Armed Police Force personnel and six Nepali Police personnel reached the main section of the tunnel, known as the "crown head", around 2pm and created a 2-by-3-foot opening.

The Nepali Army also airlifted excavators and bulldozers to Battar in Nuwakot after dismantling the machinery into sections for helicopter transport.

Across the nine projects, 898 workers and employees were initially reported out of contact following the August 26 floods, of whom 361 have been rescued, IPPAN said.

International assistance has also reached Nepal. An 11-member Indian technical team comprising doctors, paramedics and tunnel engineers carried out reconnaissance of hydropower tunnels, while a separate 22-member Indian Army team was deployed to support the operation.

A six-member Chinese tunnel expert team also arrived to assist with rescue efforts. The operations have been complicated by tunnels and access routes buried under mud and debris, damaged infrastructure, difficult terrain and hazardous conditions.

Fresh deluge in Trishuli river sweeps away suspension bridge

Kathmandu: A suspension bridge in central Nepal was swept away on Sunday morning due to a fresh flood in the Trishuli river, officials said.

The bridge connected Ghyalchowk of Gandaki Rural Municipality-8 in Gorkha district of Gandaki province with Charaudi along the Prithvi Highway.

The flood, which lasted for around three hours, swept away the bridge at around 11.30 am, said security officials.

The 130-metre Ghyalchowk-Charaudi bridge served as a major route for 400 households to transport their goods and vegetables to agricultural cooperative in Charaundi. PTI

260 foreigners from 23 nations missing in Tibet, says China

Lily Kuo & Pei-Lin Wu
August 30

MORE THAN 260 foreign citizens from 23 countries are among the hundreds of people missing in Tibet after last week's devastating flood, the Chinese authorities said on Sunday, offering their most de-

tailed accounting yet of those caught in the disaster on their side of the border.

The largest groups of missing foreigners were 104 Nepalis, 49 Indians, 33 Latvians, 18 Americans and 15 British citizens, according to Xinhua, China's state news agency. In total, 546 people remained missing. NYT

8 dead after ferry with 270 people capsizes off northern Cyprus



Associated Press
Bodrum, (Turkey) August 30

AT LEAST eight people have died after a ferry carrying around 270 passengers and crew capsized off the coast of the breakaway north of ethnically divided Cyprus on Sunday, Turkish media reported.

Unal Ustel, the north's Turkish Cypriot PM, told Turkish state broadcaster TRT that 237 people have so far been rescued.

Ustel said the ferry faced adverse weather conditions and began taking on water just 15 minutes after departure. A call for help was issued shortly after, he said. Police detained eight people - including the ferry captain - as part of a probe into the sinking, according to Ustel.

Turkish Cypriot leader Tufan Erhürman said weather conditions "were not bad" and urged against speculating about the cause of the accident.

'Confront real enemy': Khamenei urges Gulf states to unite

Reuters
August 30

IRAN'S SUPREME Leader Mojtaba Khamenei urged Muslim countries, particularly those in the Gulf, to unite against what he called their "real enemy" and said divisions among Muslims served the interests of their adversaries.

The message was published on Khamenei's Telegram account for Islamic Unity Week, which marks the birthday of the Prophet Muhammad.

It called for Muslim unity, cooperation in various fields and mutual defence, saying anyone who creates divisions among Muslims, "knowingly or unknowingly," helps Islam's enemies. It asked whether Palestinians would have been left "so helpless" if Muslims had been united.

My emphatic and repeated recommendation to the rulers of Islamic countries, especially the countries of West Asia and the Gulf, is to identify your real enemy, understand his plan and



Mojtaba Khamenei. FILE

confront it," Khamenei said. Khamenei has not been seen in public since being injured in US-Israeli airstrikes six months

ago that launched the Iran war, killing his father and previous supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

His call for unity echoes a statement he made on Friday to Iranians, when he said he had banned actions that harm social cohesion and urged authorities to avoid "discouraging statements" that weaken national and public morale.

Khamenei specifically asked Gulf Arab rulers whether "rogues without identity" would have dared to covet their lands

and possessions if the peoples and governments of the Gulf had been "united under the flag of Islam." Since the 1979 Islamic Revolution, Gulf Arab monarchies have viewed Iran's revolutionary ideology, including its anti-monarchic rhetoric and regional influence, as a threat to their political systems.

During the present conflict, Tehran has struck US military facilities as well as other infrastructure in Gulf states, underscoring the tensions between Tehran and its Gulf neighbours.

• BRIEFLY



A sign reads 'Lake Ontario, Now and Always,' unveiled by Ontario Premier Doug Ford near Grimsby town, Canada, on Saturday. AP

CANADA

Ontario premier hits back at Trump's Lake America with Lake Ontario sign

ONTARIO PREMIER Doug Ford answered President Donald Trump's "Lake America" decree Saturday with a billboard-sized message on the Canadian shoreline: "Lake Ontario. Now and Always", as Canadian leaders met the move with ridicule rather than outrage. "Long after President Trump is gone, it will still be called Lake Ontario," Ford said in a video posted on social media. AP

NORTH KOREA

Kim names new defence minister

NORTH KOREAN leader Kim Jong Un overhauled his senior military leadership, appointing Kim Song-gil as defence minister and restoring veteran strategist Pak Jong-chon as vice chairman of the Central Military Commission, state media outlet KCNA reported on Sunday. AP

UNITED KINGDOM

2 missing after trawler capsizes

TWO SAILORS were missing Sunday after a French-registered fishing trawler sank southwest of the British port of Plymouth, French authorities said. The *Maranello* contacted another trawler, the *Stradale* to report a problem with its fishing gear. The *Stradale* managed to recover three of five crew. AP

1 killed, 5 injured in shooting at Swiss rave, manhunt on

Geneva: A shooting at a rave in the northern Swiss canton of Aargau left one person dead and five wounded early Sunday, local police and media reported. Police said they are still looking for potentially more than one suspect.

Aargau cantonal police wrote earlier on X that a 22-year-old woman died of injuries at the scene. Four men and one woman, between 24 and 27 years old, were taken to the hospital with injuries ranging from minor to severe.

All of the victims are residents of Switzerland, police said. They did not release their names in line with Swiss privacy rules. "The manhunt is continuing nonstop at full speed," police spokesperson Bernhard Graser told reporters on Sunday afternoon.

He said police had no information yet about possible motives. Asked whether a terrorist attack was a possibility, Graser said that "the fact that the rave was already winding down suggests that's not the case. A fight could also be a possibility."

"In terms of its nature, this incident is certainly unique in recent years," Graser said, adding that "we don't yet know the full extent of it, but based purely on the circumstances, it is something truly extraordinary. That's why there's such a large police presence."

Iceland referendum: People reject govt push for EU membership

Reuters
Reykjavik, August 30

ICELANDERS VOTED to stay out of the EU, referendum results showed Sunday, as they rejected a government push to rejoin membership talks and sided with those who said Iceland's fishing waters were too important to risk.

The Arctic island of 400,000 people has debated whether to join the EU for well over a decade and had initially been expected to narrowly back holding membership talks, but opinion polls this month showed views had changed. "This is a clear setback for Brussels," an EU diplomat

told Reuters, adding that the issues of fishing and independence had been decisive.

In Saturday's referendum, 52.8% of ballots cast were in favour of the government's proposal to hold negotiations with Brussels, 47.2% were in favour, and 82.5% of eligible voters took part, public broadcaster RUV and other Icelandic media reported.

Out of six constituencies, only the two central Reykjavik had a majority that voted in favour, while rural areas and the Reykjavik suburbs voted against.

The government framed membership as a shield against trade wars and Arctic rivalry and presented the referendum as a

"now or never" moment. Prime Minister Kristinn Frostadottir said a "no would end the debate for as long as her centre-left coalition was in power."

In Brussels, some officials had voiced hopes a vote to join from Iceland could ease scepticism toward EU enlargement and strategically strengthen the bloc when Arctic security is in focus.

Iceland, a NATO member state but with no standing army of its own, also debated whether EU accession could boost the country's security when US President Donald Trump has cast doubt on the US commitment to the military alliance.

Indian-origin 'child genius' aces math exam decade earlier in UK

London: A seven-year-old Indian-origin boy has aaced a mathematics exam almost a decade earlier than most schoolchildren in the UK and is already preparing for the next level.

Jivyan Reddy Dhruvasud 196 out of 240, achieving a high Grade 8 - equivalent to an A - across three papers in a General Certificate of Secondary Education (GCSE) exam, normally taken by pupils aged 16 years.

He appeared for the Pearson Edexcel GCSE Higher Mathematics exam back in May and received his results along with other GCSE pupils last week. "I felt really excited when I saw my result. My parents were very happy, and they hugged me," Jivyan told PTI.



Jivyan scored 196 out of 240 across 3 papers in GCSE exams

"I wanted a Grade 9, so I was a little disappointed at first, but then I was very happy that I got Grade 8. I like maths because I like solving difficult problems and finding different ways to get the answer."

Jivyan attended a mainstream primary school in London until February this year, after which his parents moved him to home education so he could learn at a pace more suited to his sharper abilities. PTI

• THE BUS-SIZED TELESCOPE, NAMED AFTER LATE NANCY GRACE ROMAN, NASA'S FIRST CHIEF ASTRONOMER, WILL TAKE MORE THAN 3 MONTHS TO REACH ITS DESTINATION

'To find the rare & unusual': NASA launches new space telescope

Marcia Dunn
Cape Canaveral, August 30

NASA'S NEWEST crown jewel blasted off Sunday to hunt for planets around other stars, explore secret dark energy and survey the cosmos like never before.

SpaceX launched the \$4.3 billion Roman Space Telescope shortly after daybreak aboard a triple-the-fire-power Falcon Heavy rocket from Kennedy Space Center, Roman blasted toward an observation point 1.6 million kilometers away that's home to the Webb Space Telescope, one of NASA's other big-terrestrial eyes in the sky.

The bus-sized telescope - named after the late Nancy

Grace Roman, NASA's first chief astronomer - will take more than three months to reach its destination.

Once there, it will cast the widest gaze yet on the hidden parts of the universe from space, uncovering the unimaginable with unsurpassed speed.

"It's going to find thousands of supernovae, tens of thousands of planets, billions of galaxies and tens of billions of stars," said NASA science mission director Nikky Fox. "It's going to be able to do things that we've never been able to do before with its massive field of view."

Roman's field of view is more than 100 times wider than



A SpaceX Falcon Heavy rocket launches NASA's new Roman Space Telescope in Cape Canaveral, Florida, on Sunday. REUTERS

that of NASA's Hubble Space Telescope, still churning out celestial glamour shots after 36 years in orbit. Webb joined the

effort several years ago with an even narrower yet spot-on vision capable of zooming in on objects almost as old as the uni-

verse-creating Big Bang.

These three orbiting powerhouses will join forces - along with the European Space Agency's Euclid spacecraft and the National Science Foundation's Vera C. Rubin Observatory in Chile - to reveal some of the universe's biggest secrets.

Inside the countless galaxies awaiting discovery are stars with planets. Once these new worlds are spotted by Roman, the more powerful and sensitive Webb will take aim to fill in the blanks.

"Roman's vast reach will allow us to find the weird, the rare and the unusual," senior project scientist Julie McEnery said on the eve of launch. "We'll redefine what it means to find a

needle in a haystack."

Perhaps even more important, astronomers expect Roman to shed light on the dark matter and dark energy that make up most of the universe yet remain concealed. Roman's catalog of galaxies will help scientists ascertain how quickly the universe is expanding due to these puzzling, unseen forces.

Roman's superpower is speed. A month of Milky Way observations by Roman would take Hubble a century to complete, according to McEnery. Romans should make quick work of scanning the galactic bulge at dead center, she added, providing the deepest look yet into the heart of our galaxy. AP

MOST ECONOMISTS SEE GDP GROWTH IN APR-JUN WELL ABOVE RBI'S FORECAST OF 7%

GDP surprise expected after best Q1 in over 10 years for loan growth

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 30

ONE ECONOMIC indicator after another is showing that on the whole, the Indian economy has weathered the storm that is the West Asia conflict and the resultant energy shock. The biggest proof of this may come on Monday (August 31), when the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) releases GDP data for the April-June quarter.

According to the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), GDP growth in the quarter may be 7%. But economists from various banks and agencies think the headline growth figure may exceed the central bank's forecast by at least half a percentage point, with some even of the opinion that growth may come in as high as 8%.

"An upswing in GDP growth close to psychological 8% threshold in a quarter laden with macro geopolitical tensions and spike in oil prices to an average \$97/bbl is a positive surprise," said Union Bank of India economists led by Kanika Pasricha. They think GDP growth in April-June will be 79%, "likely a blockbuster beating all odds".

The economy's performance has been surprising on the upside for some time now, with the last three quarters seeing GDP growth rates of 8.3%, 8%, and 7.8%.

Of the 50-plus indicators tracked by State Bank of India — which estimates around 8% GDP growth in April-June — 86% of them accelerated in the quarter, up from 69% in April-June 2025.

Underpinning the robust performance in April-June is the pace at which loans are being taken.

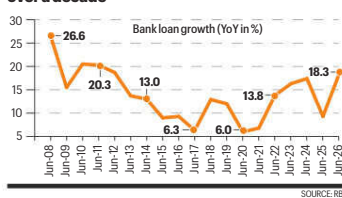
Decadal high loan growth

The first quarter of a new financial year is usually the weakest in terms of corporate performance and demand for loans from lenders. Why? Because activity takes a breather after the hectic last quarter of the financial year and companies are busy making their plans for the year ahead.

However, the first three months of 2026-27 have been the best for demand for bank loans in more than a decade.

RBI data shows outstanding non-food loans of banks were up 18.3% year-on-year as at the

Loan growth at end of June highest for Q1 in over a decade



"Overall, we are seeing a shift in credit outlook from personal loans towards industry and services, reflecting strong credit demand in the more productive sectors of the economy. Economic activity, and as a result credit growth, has held up despite uncertainties from the West Asia war," Upasani Bhardwaj and Harsh Doshi, economists with Kotak Mahindra Bank, said in a report earlier this month.

It is not just India that is seeing a pick-up in demand for loans, with the 8.5% growth in bank credit in Asia excluding China the highest in 18 years, according to Morgan Stanley.

"Surging capex, booming trade and the rise in PPI (Producer Price Index) inflation explain this acceleration in credit demand," Morgan Stanley economists led by Chetan Ahya, the investment bank's Chief Asia Economist, said last month. According to them, Asia's entering its "strongest industrial cycle since the 2000s" thanks to the "sustained, multi-year rise in capex across AI and AI-related digital infrastructure spending, energy, defense and industrial supply chains". FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

end of June. The last time bank loan growth was higher at the end of the first quarter of a financial year was back in June 2012, when it was 18.7%.

While some of the high growth in bank credit can be attributed to a change in the reporting format of the data to the last day of the month as well as the high wholesale inflation in April-June, due to the war, there are solid underlying reasons driving demand for money.

At the end of June, bank loans to the industry were up 19.2% year-on-year, services 21.4%, and personal loans 15.8%. In June 2025, the corre-

sponding growth rates were 6.3%, 8.8%, and 11.7%.

The inflection point

According to Barclays economists Aastha Gudwani and Amruta Ghare, while demand for bank credit post Covid from industry has largely been lower than that from agriculture, services, and the retail sector personal credit, things changed in mid-2025. "continued acceleration over the past year in industry growth is now driven by 'large' industry bank credit: where pace has nearly risen 4x from 2% outstanding in June 2025 to 16.6% in June 2026."

Subhash Chandra says borrowers assure settlement of Rs 4,262 crore

George Mathew
Mumbai, August 30

Lenders exposure

HDFC Bank	₹775 cr
LIC Housing	₹1,322 cr
IndusInd	₹240 cr
Canara Bank	₹348 cr
Union Bank	₹164 cr
RBL Bank	₹119 cr
Franklin Templeton	₹729 cr
Edelweiss	₹565 cr

SOURCE: STATEMENT FROM SUBHASH CHANDRA'S OFFICE

with an outstanding dues of Rs 775 crore. However, these are claims without a valid personal guarantee, it said. Canara Bank has an outstanding dues of Rs 348 crore. This was borrowing

against the borrower's assets in the US, the statement said. LIC Housing has an outstanding amount of Rs 1,322 crore. This has been offered for settlement and part security is available, it said. Union Bank has an outstanding amount of Rs 164 crore, against which security is available. RBL Bank has an outstanding amount of Rs 119 crore. They were offered to pay by the borrower as settled with the large lender, but they refused," the statement said. IndusInd Bank has an outstanding amount of Rs 240 crore. "They also had adequate security during the default period but did not convert it to cash. Hence, kept security for further gains, at their own risk," it said. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

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India eyes 4th spot in forex reserves ranks

On Friday, Reserve Bank of India data showed India's foreign exchange reserves hit an all-time high of \$729.33 billion, cementing its position as the country with the fifth-largest reserves in the world and approaching Russia in fourth.



With the RBI's three concessional swap schemes for Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits, Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings, and External Commercial Borrowings still open, reserves should swell further.

as has been the case over the last year. But how much is enough?

According to former RBI Deputy Governor Michael Patra, the target should be at least \$1 trillion. "Punting against such a level should be beyond the reach of the opportunistic and/or the faint-hearted," Patra wrote in a column in March.

SOURCE: PEOPLE'S BANK OF CHINA, JAPAN MINISTRY OF FINANCE, SWISS NATIONAL BANK, BANK OF RUSSIA, RBI

SBI, arm to dilute up to 1% in NSE via public offer

New Delhi: State Bank of India (SBI) and its subsidiary SBI Capital Markets Ltd together plan to dilute up to 1% stake in the National Stock Exchange (NSE) through the exchange's proposed Rs 30,000-crore initial public offering (IPO).

The bank is participating in the NSE IPO and will dilute a 0.65% stake in the exchange, SBI Chairman C S Setty told PTI in an interview. "We are participating in that investment. We propose to dilute 0.65% and 0.35% by SBI Capital Markets because both of us hold the stake. So together, about 1% as a SBI group... it could be less depending on any other shareholders joining," he said. PTI

'Madhepura loco factory builds global skills; 30% of Alstom work now in India'

THE LOCOMOTIVE factory in Bihar's Madhepura has created a large pool of engineers, contributing to 30% of Alstom's global engineering work now being done in India, according to Vivek Garg, managing director of Madhepura Electric Locomotive Pvt Ltd (MELPL).

MELPL manufactures India's most powerful 12,000-horsepower locomotives, which run on dedicated freight corridors and can haul loads of up to 6,000 tonnes. The company is a joint venture between Indian Railways and French major Alstom, with Alstom holding a 74% stake. It supplied its 650th locomotive to the railways on August 15.

In an interview with *The Indian Express*, Dheeraj Mishra, Garg also discussed Make in India manufacturing, global practices, the new suppliers it has brought into the ecosystem and future plans for the project, one of the largest foreign direct investments (FDI) in India's railway sector. Edited excerpts:

What has changed from your first to 650th locomotive, and how much of it is 'Made in India'?

There has been a massive change. Our centres of competence are based across Europe. Initially, the locomotives were designed there, and some of the first locomotives also had key components manufactured there, while assembly was done in India, as permitted under the contract.

When quickly transferred the technology and manufacturing capabilities to India. Today, we manufacture the motors here, propulsion systems at our Coimbatore facility, and locomotive shells (car bodies) at our manufacturing facility in Kolkata. When we entered into the joint venture in 2015, there was no formal Make in India policy. Even then, we made it a point to localise production and build the entire ecosystem in India. Today, we have more than 90% localisation across all components. We have also brought more



than 30 established suppliers into the railway manufacturing ecosystem. There are still a few components that we import, such as wheels and axles, because there is currently no supplier in India for this particular design and specification. At present, these components are sourced from China and Ukraine.

What is your plan for future expansion after the contract?

The existing contract is for 800 locomotives, with the contract period running until March 2028. We have supplied 650 locomotives so far, and the remaining 150 will be delivered by March 2028. The contract also gives Indian Railways an option to order an additional 200 locomotives.

We are in discussions with Indian Railways on how we can maintain continuity of production at Madhepura. We are hopeful that something will come out of these discussions.

And is there any plan for exports?

We are exploring every possible way of maintaining continuity. We have this land lease for 35 years. The entire investment and the facility you saw will remain in place. It therefore makes sense to continue utilising the facility for regular business hours.

What has been the impact of this project so far?

Today, more than 30% of Alstom's engineering work globally is done in India, and the confidence and capabilities developed through the Madhepura project have been an important part of that journey. We have created a large pool of engineers in India who are now contributing to the design of locomotives as well as urban trains for global projects.

We are also changing the locomotive maintenance system. Traditionally, it was largely schedule-based — the locomotive had to return to the depot at fixed intervals. However, our teams at Saharanpur, Nagpur and Sabarnai use condition-based monitoring to assess the actual health of the equipment and determine what maintenance is required. On top of this, digital tools help with predictive maintenance. With the help of these tools and by skilling workers, we have been able to cut down our maintenance time by almost 20% and material requirements by close to 15%, which is a huge efficiency gain.

The average speed of freight trains is still around 25 kmph. How can it be increased?

We are not really specialists when it comes to operations. But we can contribute from the product design and manufacturing point of view. For example, the Railways has a vision of reaching a 45% market share in five years and increasing freight haulage from around 1,600 million tonnes to 3,000 million tonnes. To achieve that, the Railways need heavy-haul locomotives that can haul long trains and heavy loads at high speeds. Our locomotive can haul a 6,000-tonne load even on a gradient of 1-in-150 at a top speed of 120 kmph. This capability can contribute to Indian Railways' vision of increasing freight haulage to 3,000 million tonnes.

The reporter was in Patna at the invitation of Alstom. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

India aims to seal Chile trade pact this year

New Delhi: India is committed to conclude negotiations for a comprehensive trade agreement with Chile this year as it would help further strengthen economic ties between the two countries, the commerce ministry said on Sunday.

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal was there in Santiago, Chile to review the progress of the talks. The proposed comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEPA) is expected to open new avenues for greater trade and investment, while fostering cooperation in technology, talent and resilient supply chains. "India remains committed to concluding the CEPA negotiations within this year, with the aim of delivering a balanced and mutually beneficial framework that provides equitable and commercially meaningful outcomes for businesses on both sides," it said. PTI

Dy MD Kaizad Bharucha in HDFC Bank CEO race

Reuters
Mumbai, August 30

HDFC BANK is likely to name Deputy Managing Director Kaizad Bharucha as one of two options for its next CEO after incumbent Sashidhar Jagdishan retires at the end of his second term in October, two people familiar with the matter said. India's largest private lender is also searching for an external candidate in keeping with a central bank rule requiring banks submit multiple names for the CEO position, the people said, declining to be identified as the information was private.

The Reserve Bank of India approves top banking appointments. Neither HDFC Bank nor Bharucha responded to emails seeking comment outside of regular business hours.

The CEO search comes after about six months of upheaval at HDFC Bank where

leadership issues have weighed on its shares.

The bank announced Jagdishan's retirement on Saturday. He had been widely tipped to continue as CEO before Atanu Chakrabarty resigned as chairman in March saying practices at the bank were at odds with his "personal values and ethics".

An external legal review found no evidence to substantiate Chakrabarty's governance concerns. Last month, the board penalised Jagdishan and three others in a separate matter related to the pricing of large deposits. The bank said on Saturday without elaborating that its CEO since October 2020 had decided not to seek reappointment and that it would fast-track the appointment of a successor.

Among the leading internal candidates is Bharucha, a long-serving executive overseeing the retail and wholesale businesses, the people said.

RBI AND SEBI ARE STRENGTHENING CYBER RESILIENCE, INCIDENT REPORTING AND AI SAFEGUARDS AS THREATS TO THE FINANCIAL SECTOR GROW MORE SOPHISTICATED

Why regulators are tightening the cybersecurity net around India's financial sector

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, August 30

AS ARTIFICIAL intelligence (AI) fuels rising cybersecurity threats, regulators are tightening oversight of the financial sector, with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) reiterating their focus on protecting critical parts of the financial ecosystem.

SEBI, for example, on Monday introduced an IT Resilience Index (ITRI) for Market Infrastructure Institutions — entities like clearing corporations and exchanges that enable trading in financial markets. "Any disruption, degrading in performance or compromise of these (IT) systems may adversely impact critical market operations and

pose risks to the trust in the securities market," the market regulator noted in its circular. The RBI released a new comprehensive cybersecurity framework late last month for banks and financial institutions, and also flagged the possibility of a "kill switch" mechanism.

The mechanism allows users to freeze all financial transactions in their accounts during fraud in the RBI's case, while the markets regulator is evaluating a similar mechanism as part of its AI guidelines. Both regulators are also looking at quantum risks as AI makes fraud easier to scale. This includes deepfake voices used to bypass KYC checks, as well as complex scams that infiltrate critical financial services institutions. In fact, we already seen cyberse-

curity threats infiltrating a few banks so far in 2026.

Measuring cyber resilience

SEBI's ITRI for market infrastructure institutions quantifies cyber resilience and turns it into something tangible. The index has 9 parameters — availability and security have a weightage of 20%, integrity, governance, reliability and monitoring, modularity and flexibility, and business continuity have a weightage of 10% each, while scalability and an "others" parameter with miscellaneous requirements have a weightage of 5% each.

"SEBI's IT Resilience Index is significant in that respect because resilience becomes something that can be measured,



AI-driven fraud, deepfakes and cyber threats are pushing regulators to strengthen monitoring and response. REUTERS

benchmark and ultimately brought into boardroom accountability," said Himanshu Bagai, partner at Saikrishna & Associates.

The framework, which will come into effect from early 2027,

will also include an "early warning system" and continuous monitoring to flag risks early. "MIs (Market Infrastructure Institutions) shall compute ITRI on a half-yearly basis within a period of 60 days from the end

of each half-year and submit the comparative analysis of two consecutive half-years (on a rolling basis) and corrective action," SEBI's circular noted.

The regulator on Monday also said that it has aligned its cyber incident reporting portal for regulated entities with standardised "Format for Incident Reporting Exchange" or FIRE format. This "will facilitate reporting of incidents in stages to reflect incident life cycle from initial report to investigation, containment and final closure, while acknowledging that certain information may not be available at the time of initial reporting," it said.

AI raises the stakes

RBI last week said it will

"shortly" issue guidelines for responsible use of AI and machine learning. While the regulator already has AI models monitoring to flag suspicious trading patterns, Whole-Time Member Samresh Chandra Varshney has indicated last week that he has also developed a team to work on AI models covering corporate investigations.

"Now, a team has already been constituted. Like we have a system for trading data, can we have a system for quarterly results that are filed?" said Varshney at an event in Mumbai.

The regulator now flags risks related to AI and the need to improve surveillance at almost all public forums, signifying the scale of the challenge

lying ahead as technology keeps on changing.

The RBI last month tightened cybersecurity rules for banks and financial institutions, mandating board-level oversight, dedicated IT risk committees and a six-hour window to report cyber incidents. In June, it had revised its fraud compensation mechanism for victims, increasing the scope of those who can claim compensation and included newer-age digital scams in its definition.

While the regulators have shown interest in modernising cyber regulations, many challenges remain. They must remain nimble as threats evolve with rapidly changing technology. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

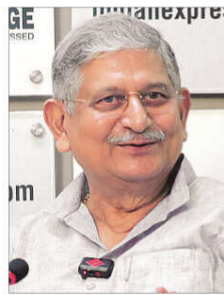
WHY RAJIV RANJAN SINGH

Rajiv Ranjan Singh, also known as Lalan Singh, is the Union Minister for Panchayati Raj and Minister of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying. He is heading the fisheries department at a time when the sector is facing challenges amid tariffs by the US, a major importer of shrimps from India. Singh began his political journey as a student leader, participating in Jayaprakash Narayan's movement. He was also a prominent voice against the fodder scam in the 1990s. He entered Parliament in 2000 after being elected to the Rajya Sabha and was elected to the Lok Sabha from Bihar's Begusarai in 2004 and 2009, and from Munger in 2019 and 2024.



ON BJP LOSING BANKPUR IN BYPOLLS

In a bye-election, many factors are involved. In 2009, eight by-elections happened at once. We lost six of those eight seats. But in the 2010 general election, out of 243 seats, we won 206



ON NAVIGATING CLIMATE CHANGE FOR FISHERIES

Transponders have been put on vessels, connecting them to satellites for fishermen to remain in touch while at sea. The system also indicates where fish are likely to be found, saving fuel

‘Despite US tariffs, our fish export has increased... now exporting to the UK, Japan, China, Thailand and EU’

Rajiv Ranjan Singh, Union Minister of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying, on transforming fisheries and dairy, building new export markets and navigating the political questions around student protests and Bihar. The session was moderated by Harikishan Sharma, Senior Assistant Editor, *The Indian Express*



(Right) Rajiv Ranjan Singh, Union Minister of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying, with Harikishan Sharma, Senior Assistant Editor, *The Indian Express* RENUKA PURI

Harikishan Sharma: When you took office as Minister of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying, you said the government had set a target to double fisheries exports. What is its current state, and what is your vision for this sector over the next two decades?

Before Prime Minister Narendra Modi came to power in 2014, this entire ministry was with the agriculture ministry. Three crore people are directly connected with fisheries as fishermen or fish farmers. If you look at the entire value chain, the livelihood of almost six crore people depends on it. The PM recognised this as a neglected sector and began efforts to strengthen it. In 2015, he started the Blue Revolution, followed by the Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY). In 2019, the fisheries department was separated from agriculture and a new ministry was created.

In 2013-14, the country's total fish production was 95.79 lakh tonnes. Through schemes such as Blue Revolution, PMMSY and the Fisheries and Aquaculture Infrastructure Development Fund, with an investment of more than Rs 39,000 crore, production increased to 197.75 lakh tonnes in 2024-25 — a growth of 115 per cent. Inland fisheries grew by 147 per cent. Many states have become self-reliant. In Bihar, 90-95 per cent of the fish sold earlier came from Andhra Pradesh. Today, only about five per cent comes from Andhra. Bihar's production has grown 11 times since 2005 and has reached approximately 10.89 lakh tonnes. Bihar now even exports freshwater fish to Nepal, Bengal and Jharkhand.

Harikishan Sharma: What about exports?

In 2013-14, fish exports were Rs 30,213 crore. In 2024-25, they reached Rs 62,408 crore. Then, in 2025, the US imposed a tariff of more than 58 per cent on Indian goods, which was a major challenge for our fishing community. We encouraged exporters to find new markets. We coordinated with MPEDA (Marine Products Export Development Authority) and held round-table conferences with ambassadors and high commissioners of 49 countries. European countries and the UK, for instance, did not want fish imported if harmful antibiotics were used. We banned such antibiotics and prepared a traceability framework under which the origin of fish has to be provided through a QR code.

Harikishan Sharma: Inland fisheries have grown, but marine fish catch has not increased as expected.

No, that is also growing. There is 115 per cent growth and our exports have increased from Rs 30,213 crore.

Unni Rajen Shankar: Does this export also include fresh water fish?

The export of freshwater fish, inland fish, contributes only two per cent to our total exports. So the export that is growing is of marine products. In 2013-14, it was Rs 30,213 crore and became Rs 62,408 crore in 2024-25. After the US tariff, there was a challenge, but the result of all the efforts we made is that instead of decreasing, our export increased by almost Rs 11,400 crore. Our export for this year (2025-26) was Rs 73,890 crore, an increase by Rs 11,000 crore. If our production of marine fisheries is not growing, how is our export growing?

Liz Mathew: Which are the new markets?

The UK, Japan, China, Thailand and several European Union countries.

Sandeep Singh: How much benefit have we seen from countries with which FTAs were signed?

Our exports to the US declined by around 19-20 per cent, but we saw more than 20 per cent growth in the European Union and countries where FTAs were signed. That is how exports reached Rs 73,890 crore.

Harikishan Sharma: What about the new fishing infrastructure in Lakshadweep and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands?

In Lakshadweep and Andaman, almost one lakh tonnes of tuna were believed to have died naturally because there was no fishing infrastructure. We did not fish in the Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) or the high seas.

In the 2024 Budget, the Finance Minister announced that fishing infrastructure would be developed there. We formulated guidelines for the EEZ and high seas and held investor meetings in both islands. Only vessels with our national flag will be allowed to fish in the high seas because the sea is a national security concern. Tuna will be the biggest catch. It is among the most expensive fish in the world and has high global demand.

Harikishan Sharma: Four states recently banned analogue paneer. What is your take on this the Dairy and Animal Husbandry Minister?

India is number one in milk production and second in egg production. But we have a problem: animals have foot-and-mouth disease and brucellosis, which prevents us from exporting as much as we could. We are running vaccination campaigns to eradicate FMD. Outbreaks have fallen from

132 in 2019 to 40 now. As for paneer analogue, paneer is made only from milk. What is being called analogue paneer is not paneer at all; it is an artificial product. Naturally, it can compromise human health.

Harikishan Sharma: Jayaprakash Narayan wrote that students and youth would lead a peaceful, party-less revolution. Student protests are now taking place in different parts of the country. How do you view them?

The student protests in Jharkhand and the one that happened in Delhi are different. The Delhi protest was connected to NEET. The paper was leaked, so the government cancelled the exam and conducted it again. Those involved were arrested. The law had loopholes, so Parliament brought in a stricter law requiring investigations and trials to be completed within specified time limits. What happened in Jharkhand will be known only after an investigation. But according to newspaper reports, the alleged fraud involved the public service commission, with money being demanded for examinations. So, you can't compare the student protest in Jharkhand and the one here.

Now, the Congress is supporting the student movement. It makes me laugh. The biggest student movement — or people's movement — in this country was in 1974 under Loknayak Jayaprakash Narayan. I participated in it. At that time, the Congress government tried to suppress the movement. Thousands of students and youth were killed in firing. Jayaprakash Narayan would ring a bell at 6 pm to signal a black-out, and the entire city would go dark. Today, they are shedding crocodile tears. During the Emergency, the Constitution was amended to increase Parliament's term from five-six years. There was no freedom of the Press.

Liz Mathew: The Delhi student protest was described by many ruling party MPs as being influenced by external forces. And Mohan Bhagwat has said the students' demands are legitimate.

If any student demands transparency in an examination, that is genuine. Such incidents should not happen again, which is why the government also brought in laws. But the people hiding behind the students cannot be considered genuine. I am not talking about any party but everyone knows who came into the movement from behind.

Harikishan Sharma: What about the force used by police against peaceful demonstrations in Delhi?

You must have seen how many police personnel were injured. If you use sticks or throw bricks at police personnel who are there for security, they will react. So how was it peaceful? There were people behind the students who wanted to give the movement a violent form. Despite that, there was no firing.



SCAN THE QR CODE TO WATCH THE VIDEO

Manoj CG: Why didn't the government initiate a dialogue with the protesters before the situation reached that point?

Conversation was happening. People were appointed from the government's side to talk to them. We were having discussions even when Sonam Wangchuk sat on hunger strike. Until there is an outcome, however, those conversations do not come to light.

ON POLICE USING FORCE AT CJP PROTEST IN DELHI

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- WNY -

ing, Nitish ji travelled across Bihar, visited every district and sanctioned the work that remained. A Rs 45,000-crore scheme has been sanctioned and is now being executed. Nitish ji's acceptability increased because of his work. We formed the Samata Party in 1995, but it was only after Nitish ji became Chief Minister that the situation in Bihar changed.

Shahid Pervez: The NDA won the 2025 Bihar election with Nitish Kumar as its face. Four or five months later, he moved to the Rajya Sabha. Isn't that a betrayal of the public mandate?

Nitish ji had already decided that he wanted to go to the Rajya Sabha. There was no Rajya Sabha election when the Assembly election was held, so he became Chief Minister and was the face of the election. In 2026, he felt that the RS opportunity would otherwise come only after two years. There was no betrayal of the public mandate. Samrat Choudhary was Nitish ji's choice.

Nikhil Ghanekar: Climate change is affecting fisheries. What policies are you bringing in to improve the resilience of communities dependent on these sectors?

Climate change affects the sea through storms and cyclones. The PM has launched an initiative which is putting transponders on vessels. These are connected to satellites. Fishermen who remain at sea for 15-20 days can stay in touch with their families through an Android phone connected to the transponder. Alerts can warn them about storms and tell them to move away from danger. The system can also indicate where fish are likely to be found, saving fuel.

Harikishan Sharma: But what about rising sea temperatures, changing rainfall and their impact on fish, endangered species, dairy and animal husbandry?

Climate change is a global problem and comes under the ministry of forest and environment. There are many reasons for it, including deforestation. That ministry is looking at it.

Nikhil Ghanekar: In Bihar, Mangur fish are being confiscated because of concerns about their impact on native species and livelihoods.

Mangur is being produced through farming. You can see how the farmed fish becomes massive in six months. People use injections to increase the size of animals or vegetables, but ultimately it affects health.

Nikhil Ghanekar: The PESA Act completes three decades this year. Its implementation has been delayed in several states. What is your view?

Under the 73rd Constitutional Amendment, the panchayat is an independent government. The Government of India has no control over it. The laws you are referring to are under the state governments. States have the right to make laws, so we do not interfere. Our role is to provide the grants recommended by the Finance Commission. We send the money to the states in a 90:10 ratio based on population and geographical conditions. States have to transfer it to panchayats within 10 days, otherwise the second instalment is not released. We also work on capacity building, including training women representatives, with trainers from institutions such as IIM Ahmedabad. The 16th Finance Commission has recommended that 20 per cent of the grant be performance-based. Panchayats will have to develop their own sources of revenue. If they depend only on grants, they will not be sustainable.

Swati Mishra: Your ministry promotes milk and egg production, while malnutrition remains a major problem. At the same time, some political leaders oppose the sale of eggs and meat on religious grounds.

You are combining the responsibilities of several ministries. My ministry looks at production. It does not deal with malnutrition or mid-day meals.

Damini Nath: What is your view on the proposed delimitation exercise, particularly from Bihar's perspective?

We will see when we come to it. Bihar has always supported women's empowerment. It was the first state to give 50 per cent reservation to women in Panchayati Raj in 2006 and in local bodies in 2007. Today, lakhs of women are in mainstream politics. In the last panchayat election, despite 50 per cent reservation, 53 per cent of those elected were women.

Harikishan Sharma: What is the government doing about stray animals, including cows and dogs?

Stray animals are a state subject. We are using artificial insemination and sexed sorted semen, through which around 90 per cent female calves are born. Most animals are born on roads or near a male because oxen are no longer needed for farming. Tractors have replaced them. With more female calves, livestock owners will have more milk and income, giving them an incentive to rear the animals rather than abandon them. But the issue of stray animals remains a state subject.

Manoj CG: You are a voter of Bankpur, where the BJP has had a winning streak since 1995. What went wrong that a person who started a party three years ago won such a big BJP seat?

In a bye-election, many factors are involved, including the candidate's popularity. Look at Bihar's history. In 2009, eight bye-elections happened at once. We lost six of those eight seats. But in the 2010 general election, out of 243 seats, we won 206. So you cannot assess the strength of a party from one bye-election.

Liz Mathew: For the first time in many years, the NDA went to an election without Nitish Kumar's leadership in Bihar. Did his leaving have any impact?

No. It was Nitish ji's wish to go to the Rajya Sabha. He had been a member of the Lok Sabha, Assembly and Legislative Council; the Rajya Sabha was the only house left.

Jatin Anand: Student politics traditionally brings people above 18 into party organisations. But today politics seems to be influencing younger people. Should children below 18 be brought into politics?

It is changing continuously. The PM has said that youth are the future of the country. Lakhs of young people are connected with youth wings and come to meet us even today. The younger they are, the better it is for the country. They can contribute to constructive work.

Jatin Anand: Do you think the people of Bihar have accepted Samrat Choudhary?

You are talking about acceptability after three months. Right now, he is carrying forward the work Nitish ji started. Before leav-

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Depression stalls brain neurons

A MAJOR STUDY by the Columbia University Irving Medical Center found that adults with depression show disrupted production of neurons in the hippocampus, potentially weakening the brain's ability to separate new experiences from painful memories. The researchers also identified broad molecular changes that could open the door to new treatments tailored to different biological forms of depression. The findings provide the first evidence that neurogenesis, the process of producing new neurons, stalls in the brains of adults with major depressive disorder.



Shingles vaccine slows dementia

OLDER ADULTS who received the Shingrix shingles vaccine were 24 per cent less likely to be diagnosed with dementia over four years in a study of more than 500,000 people. Researchers at Brown University estimate the difference could amount to roughly one dementia case prevented for every 17 people vaccinated. Dementia developed in 18.8 per cent of vaccinated participants, compared with 24.6 per cent of those who were not vaccinated. The study included Medicare claims and electronic health records from patients admitted to more than 5,500 skilled nursing facilities.



Brain 'brake' that calms pain

RESEARCHERS at Washington University School of Medicine discovered a brain-based 'brake' that can shut down chronic nerve pain in mice by calming an overactive pain circuit. Targeting this system more precisely could one day lead to powerful pain relief without affecting opioid receptors throughout the entire body. These receptors were already known for their role in stress, but the new findings suggest they can also quiet a pain-producing circuit and reduce chronic neuropathic pain caused by nerve injury. Neuropathic pain develops when injured nerve fibres repeatedly send abnormal signals to the brain.



Gene decides diet effect on LDL

LOW-CARB diets have become increasingly popular but their effects on cholesterol are far from uniform. Some people see little change, while others experience a substantial increase. New research suggests that genetics may help explain why. The findings indicate that saturated fat, which can make up a larger share of some low-carb diets, may interact with a person's genetic makeup to raise low-density lipoprotein (LDL) cholesterol, a major contributor to heart disease risk. This genetic influence could help explain why two people following similar diets can have different cholesterol responses.



Common drugs change your gut

COMMON MEDICATIONS may reshape the gut microbiome long after the last dose is taken. In a study of more than 2,500 people, researchers found lasting microbial changes linked not only to antibiotics but also to antidepressants, beta-blockers, acid-reducing drugs and benzodiazepines. Effects were detectable years later, suggesting past medication use may strongly influence the gut bacteria people carry today. One striking finding involved benzodiazepines, commonly prescribed for anxiety. Their associations with the gut microbiome were comparable to those seen with broad-spectrum antibiotics.



CONSULTATION ROOM

DR AMIT SEN

CHILD AND ADOLESCENT PSYCHIATRIST,
DIRECTOR, CHILDREN FIRST

Meta's child safety deal can change digital childhood

The settlement marks a crucial shift in responsibility from parents to tech cos

META'S AGREEMENT to settle the US states' landmark case over Facebook and Instagram's impact on children is significant because of its size and because it signals a possible change in who bears responsibility for children's online safety. Meta has agreed to pay up to about \$18 billion and introduce protections for under-18 users, including a default two-hour daily limit, a midnight-to-6 am block, muted notifications during school hours, stronger age assurance, parental controls and greater restrictions on harmful content. The agreement follows allegations that Meta encouraged compulsive use and mishandled children's data.

The importance of the settlement lies in the shift away from the familiar argument that parents alone must control children's digital lives. For years, technology companies have pointed to parental supervision, while families have struggled to manage products engineered around engagement, notifications, recommendation systems and endless scrolling. The agreement places responsibility back on the platforms. It, therefore, represents more than a financial penalty: it challenges the idea that a profitable digital environment can be treated as neutral while its youngest users carry the risks.

This matters because the post-Covid generation of children and teenagers has grown up with an extraordinary expansion of screen-based life. In clinical practice, screen addiction is a real and serious problem. Children may reach a point where they stop attending school, withdraw from friends and family, lose interest in ordinary activities and become unable to regulate their use of phones, gaming or social media. Often there is an underlying vulnerability — anxiety, depression, learning difficulty, neurodevelopmental difference or family distress — that makes the virtual world attractive. That does not make the technology harmless; it makes vulnerable children more deserving of protection.

The developmental concern is not simply the number of hours spent on a screen, but what is being consumed and what is being disused. Sustained play, reading, creative activity, physical movement, face-to-face conversation and downtime help children practise attention, language, emotional regulation and social skills. When every pause is filled by a device, children may lose opportunities for reflection and assimilation of the day's experiences. In clinical assessment, difficulties with attention, frustration tolerance, impulse control, organisation and emotional regulation can become strikingly visible.

Neuroscience adds weight to the concern. A systematic review and meta-analysis of problematic internet use found convergent reductions in grey matter in frontal and anterior cingulate regions involved in reward processing and top-down inhibitory control. Reviews of problematic gaming in adolescents similarly identify alterations in prefrontal, attention, emotion-regulation and reward networks. These findings are associations, not proof that social media alone damages every child. But they reinforce the need to take compulsive digital behaviour seriously.

Mental health is another concern. Research has linked heavier social-media use with anxiety, depressive symptoms, body dissatisfaction and disordered eating. A 2026 meta-analysis of 45 studies involving more than 33,000 adolescents found significant associations between social-media engagement and body-image and eating-disorder symptoms, with stronger associations for Instagram. The digital environment can also expose children to self-harm material, eating-disorder content, exploitation, misogyny, violent imagery and other age-inappropriate material. Recommendation systems can intensify exposure by repeatedly feeding users what keeps them engaged. Yet this is not an argument for banning technology. Digital tools can expand access to education, support differently abled learners and create opportunities for creativity, connection and participation.

That is why the Meta settlement could become a turning point. The two-hour limit, night-time restrictions, school-hour notification controls, age assurance, reduced social-comparison features and stronger parental controls are useful steps. The crucial question is whether platforms will change underlying addictive design and recommendation systems. Schools, governments and technology companies must share responsibility. Schools can establish clear rules, reduce unnecessary access to social media on school devices and teach digital literacy. Governments can demand transparency, independent audits and age-appropriate design. Companies should remove addictive features, limit harmful recommendations and make child-safety protections the default rather than an optional setting.

— As told to Rinku Ghosh

Peptide boom: Miracle molecules or hype?

Rinku Ghosh

THE LATEST wellness craze comes in tiny chains of amino acids — the building blocks of protein — and it is being sold with very big promises. Peptides are increasingly being touted as the next frontier in weight loss, muscle recovery, anti-ageing and longevity, with products available online, through wellness clinics and, in some cases, directly delivered to consumers for self-administration. The fad has now moved from online forums and biohacking circles into the real world: Bengaluru announced the first "Peptide Party" on August 29, an invite-only gathering, which was later cancelled by the administration. It got more than 200 registrations for around 50 places, underlining just how quickly the fascination has spread.

But the hype drowns this absolute truth: While a handful of peptide-based medicines have been rigorously tested and approved, many of the compounds now being marketed for "biohacking", recovery and longevity have little or no adequate evidence from human clinical trials. Dr Anoop Misra, Executive Chairman, Fortis C-DOC for Diabetes and Allied Sciences, who has been researching the subject, found that the growing peptide market is blurring the line between established medicines and experimental compounds. "The word 'peptide' itself can sound reassuring because some of the world's most successful modern medicines are peptides. But scientific credibility does not automatically extend from semaglutide or insulin to every compound sold online under the same broad label," he told *The Indian Express*.

What are peptides and where are they available?

Peptides are short chains of amino acids — the same building blocks that make up proteins but smaller. Some peptides, such as insulin and semaglutide, are well-established medicines manufactured in regulated facilities and available only by prescription. However, several others — including BPC-157, TB-500, epitalon, MOTS-c and others — are sold openly online by "research chemical" suppliers. They may be shipped as injectable vials directly to people's homes, often without a prescription. A growing number of wellness and longevity clinics in India also offer them off-label, sometimes as part of "anti-ageing," "recovery" or "longevity" packages.

Some websites claim that "many peptides used in longevity and optimisation protocols are available through licensed compounding pharmacies." This can create an impression of safety and legitimacy that may not necessarily be justified. Many "peptide capsules" are also available online, sometimes costing Rs 10,000-15,000 for 60 capsules.

Do these peptides actually work as claimed?

For approved and properly tested medicines such as semaglutide and tirzepatide, the answer is yes — their benefits are supported by large, well-designed clinical trials. For many of the peptides being sold online, however, the honest answer is, we simply do not know. Most claims are based on animal studies, laboratory findings, anecdotal mechanisms or personal anecdotes rather than controlled human clinical trials.

What are peptide rave parties?

These refer to social gatherings or online communities where people come together to discuss, and sometimes use, peptide products for weight loss, muscle building, recovery, anti-ageing or "longevity." Participants may share personal experiences and discuss which peptide to use, how much to take, how frequently to take it and which route of administration to use — oral, topical or injectable.

Doses and schedules may then be changed according to how individuals feel the peptide is working, rather than on the basis of clinical trials or medical advice. The concern is that such settings can normalise peptide stacking, self-injection and unsupervised dose changes, while creating a false sense of safety because other people report similar experiences.

In reality, many people having the same experience does not make an unapproved



GETTY IMAGES

peptide safe or effective. Anecdotes are not a substitute for clinical evidence.

What's behind the sudden peptide craze?

The highly visible success of drugs such as Ozempic has made the word "peptide" sound almost synonymous with guaranteed results. That credibility has spilled over to completely different peptides now being promoted for muscle recovery, sleep, skin health, anti-ageing and longevity. Biohacking culture, celebrity endorsements and aggressive social-media promotion have further fuelled the trend.

The result is a rapidly expanding market in which scientific evidence and regulatory oversight are struggling to keep pace.

How different are approved medicines from the peptides sold online?

They are hugely different. Semaglutide, for example, underwent years of large-scale human clinical trials, is manufactured in regulated and inspected facilities, and is prescribed with appropriate medical monitoring. In contrast, many peptides sold online have little or no adequate human clinical evidence supporting their safety or effectiveness.

What are the biggest health risks of unsupervised use?

Potential risks include immune reactions, infections at the injection site, unpredictable effects on hormones or organ function, and adverse effects that may go unnoticed because there is no medical monitoring. Another major problem is that doses may not be standardised and the actual amount of peptide in a product may differ from what is stated on the label.

BPC-157, for example, is a synthetic 15-amino-acid peptide derived from a protein associated with the stomach. It has shown potential cell-protective effects in laboratory and animal studies. Despite its growing popularity among athletes and its availability through non-regulated sources, there is very limited human clinical evidence.

In July 2026, the US FDA (Food and Drug Administration) recommended adding BPC-157 to the FDA's compounding list, citing the lack of adequate human evidence demonstrating its safety and effectiveness. Non-clinical evaluations



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have also raised concerns regarding safety and product quality, including findings of blood-clotting abnormalities and liver changes in animal studies, as well as concerns about inconsistent quality between batches. Injection or inhalation may also trigger unwanted immune reactions. There have been ongoing debates and challenges involving industry groups, political figures and patient demand on relaxing regulatory status of BPC-157 and pharmacy compounding. Such developments, however, should not be interpreted as proof that the peptide has been established as safe or effective.

What does the "research chemical" label mean, and why should buyers be cautious?

The term can function as a regulatory workaround. Sellers may label a product "not for human consumption" or "for research use only" while simultaneously marketing it in a way that clearly encourages human use, including self-injection. It is important to understand that "research chemical" is not a safety certification. If anything, it should make consumers more cautious because the product may not have undergone the quality, safety and efficacy testing required for an approved medicine.

Can buyers be sure of what they are actually getting?

Often, they cannot. Testing of some peptides obtained online in Belgium found contamination with toxic heavy metals such as arsenic and lead. Testing by a US laboratory specialising in these products has also found that a proportion of samples did not match their labels in terms of purity or quantity.

Peptides can be relatively fragile molecules and may be affected by inappropriate storage or transportation, including inadequate temperature control. This means that a product may potentially deteriorate before it even reaches the consumer.

Research examining online peptide forums has also shown how digital communities can develop their own form of "folk pharmacology", where users collectively exchange information and experiences about drugs, doses, combinations and administration methods without the safeguards of formal medical evidence.



PEPTIDE, PROTEIN OR HORMONE? WHAT'S THE DIFFERENCE?

AMINO ACID The basic building block. Amino acids join together to form peptides and proteins.

PEPTIDE A relatively short chain of amino acids. There is no single universally agreed cut-off separating a peptide from a protein, but peptides are generally shorter.

PROTEIN A larger, folded chain or chains of amino acids that perform a huge range of functions in the body — from building tissues and transporting molecules.

PEPTIDE HORMONE Some hormones are peptides. They act as chemical messengers, carrying signals between cells and organs.

WHY DOES THIS MATTER? Peptide is a description of what something is made of, not what it does. Two peptides can have completely different structures, biological effects, medical uses and levels of evidence. That is why the fact that a well-established drug such as insulin or semaglutide is a peptide tells us little about an unrelated experimental peptide.



The success of semaglutide has turned peptides into a wellness buzzword. But compounds for recovery, anti-ageing and longevity lack human evidence

What happens when people combine peptides or follow influencer dosing advice and tips?

This is where the risk can rise sharply. Combining peptides — for example, stacking BPC-157 with TB-500 — is particularly concerning because there are inadequate human data about their interactions. Doses promoted by influencers or online communities are generally based on personal experience and anecdote rather than clinical trials.

Another concern is self-directed dose adjustment. People may increase or decrease the dose, change the frequency, or alter the duration of treatment depending on how they feel or on advice received from online communities.

Changes in appetite, sleep, energy, mood, libido, gastrointestinal symptoms, skin, muscle soreness or weight may then be interpreted as signs that the dose should be changed.

However, such an approach does not provide a reliable assessment of safety and may overlook less obvious problems, including hormonal disturbances, abnormal glucose regulation, inflammation, contamination or damage to specific organs.

The route of administration can also change the nature and magnitude of the risk. Products that begin as oral or topical preparations may be switched to injectable forms because injections are assumed to produce stronger or faster effects.

But injection introduces additional risks that may have little to do with the peptide itself. With self-injection, there are concerns about incorrect dosing, improper mixing or dilution, inadequate sterility, unsafe needle practices and local infections such as cellulitis or abscesses. There is also the possibility of greater systemic exposure to a product whose identity, concentration, purity or contamination status may not have been adequately verified.

Are there long-term risks we simply don't understand yet?

For many of these compounds, we do not have adequate data on what happens when they are used continuously for months or years. Even when short-term effects appear harmless, that cannot establish long-term safety. This lack of evidence is particularly important because many people using these products are doing so for prolonged periods for purposes such as anti-ageing, muscle building, recovery or longevity.

What should people check, and when should they avoid a peptide entirely?

Before considering any peptide, people should ask three basic questions: Has it been prescribed by a qualified doctor after proper medical evaluation? Is it being dispensed by a licensed pharmacy with a traceable manufacturer and batch number? Is there credible, published human clinical-trial evidence supporting its safety and effectiveness?

People should be particularly cautious if a product is self-sourced online, labelled as a "research chemical", promoted as part of an influencer-recommended stack, or advertised as providing rapid results without medical supervision.

England beat Pakistan by 194 runs to win Test series at Lord's



Ollie Robinson (R) took a total of 16 wickets in the two Tests. AP

Reuters
London, August 30

ENGLAND BEAT Pakistan by 194 runs in the second Test and sealed their first home Test series victory for two years as they bowled the visitors out for 194 at Lord's on Sunday.

The outcome was a formality as Pakistan were reduced to 14-3 before lunch chasing an unlikely target of 389 but Saud Shakeel provided some resistance with a magnificent fighting 97.

Ollie Robinson was Pakistan's chief tormentor again as he took four wickets for 24 to bow out the four for 11 he bagged in the first innings, taking his total in the two tests to 16.

After a rain-hit Saturday, England resumed on day four on 177-7 but were all out for 208 after Pakistan quick Mohamud Abbas helped mop up to finish with five wickets.

Robinson removed Azan Awaib lbw with a delivery that nipped back off a length and three balls later produced a stunning delivery that hit the top of Abdullah Shafique's off stump, leaving Pakistan reeling on 7-2. There was no respite before lunch for Pakistan as captain Babar Azam tried to fend off a vicious Jofra Archer bouncer but could only edge it via his helmet to Jordan Cox at third slip.

Shan Masood and Shakeel dug in though and at least steered Pakistan to their highest score of the series so far. Robinson removed Masood for 26 after lunch, but Shakeel provided some afternoon entertainment as he struck 13 fours and two sixes in a brilliant knock.

There was genuine disappointment around the ground when he fell three short of a deserved century, trying to launch Josh Tongue over the deep square leg boundary but picking out Harry Brook, before walking off to a hearty reception. With Pakistan opener Imam-ul-Haq again unable to bat because of an injury sustained in the field on Thursday, England only needed nine wickets to finish the contest and Tongue completed the victory by dismissing Mohammad Ali. The third and final test will start at Edgbaston on September 9.

The outcome was a formality as Pakistan were reduced to 14-3 before lunch chasing an unlikely target of 389 but Saud Shakeel provided some resistance with a magnificent 97

WOMEN'S ASIA CUP

Big victory margin, but familiar failings remain

India thrash Thailand by 94 runs in opener, but over-reliance on openers remains a worry for the team

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, August 30

ON THE eve of India's Women's Asia Cup opener against Thailand, Amol Muzumdar had made a pledge. After nine defeats in 16 T20Is this calendar year, India's head coach wanted his team to set the tone for the remainder of 2026 through this tournament. In sport's most fundamental currency—victory—the start was as promised.

India began their Asia Cup campaign with a 94-run demolition of Thailand at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium on Sunday. Asked to bat first, they made 159 before bowling the underdogs out for 65. The emphatic result, though, came courtesy of a few individual performances that papared over some familiar collective cracks. The gulf in quality between the two teams was considerable—a nine-place difference in the T20I rankings underlined it— but Thailand still managed to expose some of the frailties that had bothered India at the Women's T20 World Cup. Chief among them was India's overwhelming dependence on their openers.

Quick start

Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma were the only Indians among the World Cup's top 10 run-scorers. They began the Asia Cup in much the same vein, India's top scorers in their first 17 deliveries, 19 of those coming from Mandhana off just 10 balls, before she was run out off the 18th delivery of the match.

Shafali ensured the momentum did not suffer. The powerplay brought India 65 runs. Her partners could not match either her range of strokes or her power, but Shafali continued undeterred. Pratika Rawal, making her T20I debut before playing a game in the Women's Premier League, scored a 22-ball 18, her



Deepthi Sharma scalped three wickets without conceding any runs to derail Thailand's innings. CREMAIS

strike rate of 122.22 piling beside Shafali's.

Skipper Harmanpreet Kaur blew hot and cold in England. And cold it was, on this occasion as well, losing her wicket to Tipthapacha Putthawong, who led the women's T20I wicket-takers' leaderboard at the time. Despite the repeated setbacks, Shafali had taken India's score to 112 in 12.4 overs before losing her wicket. In the subsequent 44 deliveries, India mustered only 47 runs.

Bharti Pulkarni's attempt to take her IPL form into international cricket continued without much success, as she made 13 from 14 balls. Her T20I career remains in its infancy, but she has crossed 20 runs only once in seven innings. Richa Ghosh's stay lasted a solitary delivery. Her recent T20I form has hardly been encouraging, and the three of her T20I ducks have now come in the Women's Asia Cup.

On her 150th T20I appearance—only two women have represented India more often—Deepthi Sharma made five. Prema Rawat, on her second international appearance, scored a run more.

And so, in the post-Shafali phase of the innings, India unravelled from 112/3 to 137/9. The

The gulf in quality between the two teams was considerable but Thailand still managed to expose some of the frailties that had bothered India at the Women's T20 World Cup

next 22 runs owed as much to India's Nos 10 and 11, Shree Charni and Kranti Gaud, as they did to Thailand's underwhelming fielding.

Strongers suit

Bowling, meanwhile, was unlikely to be a source of anxiety. India had recorded the second-best bowling average at the T20 World Cup. That, coupled with Thailand's highest-ever score against India being 74, had hinted at the second phase of the game being a foregone conclusion. It was Gaud, fresh from etching her name on the Lord's honours board, needed only five deliveries to provide India their first breakthrough. The more efficacious pacer in this game, however, was her partner, Nandani Sharma. The

24-year-old had benched the pair of Renuka Thakur and Arundhati Reddy—combined 119 T20Is between the pair—and showed why with figures of 4-0-18-3.

Deepthi, who India would ideally want to contribute more with the bat, made her historic appearance even more memorable with three wickets, taking her to the top of the women's T20I wicket-takers' list. Then there was Charni, the supporting act in this game, who has increasingly become a protagonist in her own right. Among players from Test-playing nations, no bowler has taken more T20I wickets this year than the left-arm spinner. She took two wickets in this game.

With a margin that large, searching for shortcomings can easily resemble desperate nit-picking. But Harmanpreet, more than most, will know that the scoreline cannot obscure the immense room for improvement, with more difficult fixtures coming up.

BRIEF SCORES: India Women 159/9 (Shafali Verma 64; Suleeporn Laoml 3/26) defeated Thailand Women 65 all out (Nannapat Konchareonkai 41; Deepthi Sharma 3/0) by 94 runs.

Unsung Abhijit combines with Shami and Mukesh to restrict Central Zone to modest 266

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 30

WHEN A bowling attack has two India internationals in Mohammed Shami and Mukesh Kumar, the expectation is that they will do most of the damage. It is not often, then, that a domestic pacer bowling alongside them stands out more.

On Sunday, Abhijit Sarkar did just that on the opening day of East Zone's Duleep Trophy semi-final against Central Zone at the BCCI's Centre of Excellence (CoE) Ground 1 in Bengaluru.

Sarkar made the early inroads before Shami and Mukesh used the older ball well as East Zone bowled Central Zone out for 266 in 80.1 overs on Day 1. Sarkar finished with 3/38 from 16.1 overs, including six maidens, while Mukesh took 3/56 and Shami 2/42. First-class debutant Kounain Quraishi also took two wickets when Central Zone was reduced to 107/2.

East Zone were familiar with the conditions, having won their quarter-final against North East Zone at the same venue, and made a strong start after opting to bowl. Shami began by testing Aman Mokhad and Aryan Juyal, but Sarkar provided the breakthroughs. He hit a good length consistently and found enough away movement to have Mokhad caught by Abhimanyu Easwaran at slip.

Four overs later, he struck again. Sarkar brought the ball into Kunal Chandela, who tried to work it through the leg side, played around it and was trapped in front. Chandela reviewed, but ball-tracking returned three reds, leaving Central Zone 36/2.

Sarkar's impact went beyond the wickets. His accuracy made scoring difficult and he kept Central Zone to maintain pressure when Shami and Mukesh were out of the attack. His first eight overs cost a mere 13 runs. Anukul Roy also kept things tight as Central Zone rebuilt.

The pressure showed in Rajat Patidar's innings. The Central Zone captain took 35 balls to reach double figures before Shami returned and began troubling him. He nearly bowled Patidar off an inside edge and then beat him outside off.

The wicket eventually came through Mukesh. A short ball outside off caught Patidar half-committed to the pull and an under-edge crashed into the stumps, sending him back for 12.

As the ball grew older, Shami and Mukesh came into their own. Mukesh ended Juyal's 113-ball stay for 46, getting the ball to move away and take the outside edge. The on-field umpire gave it not out, but stand-in captain Vaibhav Sooryavanshi successfully reviewed the decision. Sooryavanshi had taken charge after Kishan left the field with a thumb injury. Kishan later returned to captain. Mukesh Kumar Kusagra continued behind the stumps.



Mohammed Shami (C) celebrates after taking a wicket. PTI

Shami dismissed Yash Rathod for 27 with a delivery that left him blind, reducing Central Zone to 125/5. Rinku Singh then led Central Zone's recovery. He looked comfortable against pace and spin, with his back-foot play against the pacers standing out. Harsh Dubey offered support, and the pair added 55 for the sixth wicket.

While Rinku handled Shami and Mukesh well, Dubey attacked the spinners, going over the infield when they bowled full.

Quraishi's strikes

Just when Central Zone were fighting their way back, Quraishi struck. The debutant trapped Dubey leg-before for 27 after Kishan, persuaded by Sooryavanshi, reviewed the not-out decision with a second left.

Ball-tracking showed three reds, giving Quraishi his maiden first-class wicket and ending the 55-run stand.

Rinku reached his fifty from 71 balls with an inside-out boundary through the covers off Quraishi. The off-spinner struck again when Saransh Jain played back to a straight ball and was trapped leg-before for 13.

Mukesh then returned to take the wicket East Zone needed most. Coming around the wicket, he bowled short, and Rinku went for the pull, only for Roy to take a fine catch at deep mid-wicket. Rinku departed for 60, having held Central Zone's innings together.

Shami added his second when he had Arshad Khan caught at slip. The wicket was his 900th across first-class, List A and T20 cricket, making him the sixth Indian pacer to reach the mark.

East Zone, however, had to wait for the final wicket. Aryan Pandey and Yash Thakur added 45, the second-highest partnership of the innings, as Pandey's 22 and Thakur's unbeaten 30 off 26 balls lifted Central Zone from 221/9 to 266. Sarkar eventually returned to dismiss Pandey with the second new ball and take his third wicket to give East Zone the advantage after Day 1.

BRIEF SCORES: Central Zone 266 all out in 80.1 overs (Rinku Singh 60, Aryan Juyal 46; Abhijit Sarkar 3/38, Mukesh Kumar 3/56, Mohammed Shami 2/42) vs East Zone.

Kaverappa triggers North Zone collapse on Day One

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

AS MANY as 12 wickets fell on the opening day of the Duleep Trophy semifinal with only 235 runs scored.

The decision to bat first didn't pay dividends for North Zone as they were bowled out for 195 in less than 60 overs. The South Zone reply didn't begin on an auspicious note and they finished the day at 40/2 with two of their best batters—Ricky Bhui and Shaik Rasheed—already dismissed.

The story of the North Zone innings was written around two mini-collapses. They were comfortably placed at 71/1 before losing three wickets for 24 runs. After they had recovered to 161/4, another stumble saw them lose their last 6 wickets for merely 34 runs.

It was Vidwath Kaverappa who was the wrecker-in-chief with figures of 4/66. Jammu and Kashmir opener Qamran Iqbal almost batted through the innings, being the ninth batsman out for 76 off 82 balls. His 53-run stand for the second wicket with Ayush Doseja (23) and the 66-run partnership with skipper Kanhaiya Wadhawan (35) were the only positives for North Zone. Apart from these three, the highest scorer for the team was Abdul Samad with 16.

If South Zone had hoped for an incident-free end to the first day with the bat, they were mistaken. In Arshdeep Singh, Surman Brar and Anshul Kamboj North Zone have a potent pace attack, and the openers didn't have things going their way.

It seemed that they had weathered the storm when Bhui and Narayan Jagadeesan took South Zone to 34 without loss. But there was a sting in the tail as Bhui was castled by Kamboj for 5 before Rasheed was trapped in front by Brar without opening his account.

Jagadeesan has captain Tilak Varma for company when stumps were drawn. **BRIEF SCORES: North Zone 195 all out in 59.4 overs (Qamran Iqbal 76; Vidwath Kaverappa 4/66) vs South Zone 40/2 in 18 overs.**

There was sameness to the bowling: Gavaskar

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

GOING INTO the final day of the Colombo Test, all India had to do was pick up the remaining four Sri Lankan wickets and try to chase any required runs. However, things did not go to plan for Shubman Gill's men as Sonal Dinusha helped the Sri Lankan lower order put on a firm resistance to frustrate the Indian batters.

Former Indian cricketer Sunil Gavaskar acknowledged that the off-spinner might have

been a bit nervous, but also said India's inability to dismiss Sri Lanka's tail is a concern.

"The debutant off-spinner looked an honest trier with little variety to trouble batters at this level. Sure, he could have been nervous considering that he was making his debut, yet there was no deception through the air and an over-reliance on the pitch for assistance," Gavaskar wrote in his Mid-Day column.

"If they couldn't dismiss the lower order batting on a pitch where there was some turn, it

does make Indian cricket fans a bit nervous. There was a sameness to the bowling. On a pitch that got slower as the match progressed, the fast bowlers struggled to get the ball up towards the batters' shoulders. Here perhaps the extra pace and height of Gurnoor Brar may well have come in handy," he added.

Kuldeep Yadav, who played the first Test, was out of the line-up for the second game. The former opener opined that Kuldeep Yadav, a left-arm wrist spinner, could have troubled

the Sri Lankan lower order, and that Jasprit Bumrah's yorkers too might have been pretty brutal.

"Kuldeep Yadav's absence also did not help, as a good wrist spinner can get the lower-order batters out in a jiffy most of the time," said Gavaskar.

"A fast bowler with a good yorker is also terrific to have in the side when the opposition batters are looking good. So Bumrah was badly missed, especially when the batters thwarted India on the final day of the second Test."

LEGEND'S TAKE

Anand backs Praggnanandhaa for the first board at the Chess Olympiad

Amit Kamath & Mayank Chaudhary
Mumbai/New Delhi, August 30

IT PROMISES to be one of the hottest debates in Indian chess: who plays for India on board one at the upcoming Chess Olympiad, with at least three contenders in the race—D Gukesh, R Praggnanandhaa and Arjun Erigaisi. It's a question that has even the OG of Indian chess Viswanathan Anand curious.

"I have no part in the board order debate. I don't know what the order will be. I don't think Srinath Narayan (the Indian team's non-playing captain) takes the decision unilaterally. I think he also talks to the players and figures out what they're comfortable with. But

these guys will say yes to everything. They're flexible. They'll say, your decision, I'll go with it," Anand told The Indian Express in an interview.

The five-time world champion didn't believe it was a "contentious decision," regardless of the call.

"Right now, it's very tempting to drop Praggnanandhaa on the first board. I think that's probably what it's going to be like. As for the others, I know that Arjun likes to drop down. He already showed this last time, at the 2024 Olympiad, where he played board number three. And for the rest, I'm just as curious as to what the final composition will be."

Gukesh is the reigning world champion, and the man who won India two gold medals on board one across the last two

Olympiads. Praggnanandhaa is the in-form player, having won Norway Chess and the Grand Chess Tour Finals. Arjun is India's top-rated player, per the August 2026 rating list. Arjun sits at world No. 9, with a rating of 2759; Praggnanandhaa is 12th, at 2750; Nihal Sarin is 25th, at 2718; Gukesh has slipped to 31st, at 2703, having lost 174 rating points since January 2025, when he was the newly-minted world champion. Vidit Gujrathi is 33rd, at 2697.

The playing order isn't just a matter of prestige. The person on the first board faces every opposition nation's top player at the Olympiad. Anand also weighed in on the board order for the women's Olympiad team, where gold is also hoping to defend their gold medal. This



Vishy Anand (C) believes players will be flexible on board order. FILE

time, Koneru Humpy will be available after missing the last edition. Harika Dronavalli, meanwhile, will not be part of the side, with Vantika Agrawal

and Savitha Shri rounding out the five-player squad. "On the women's side, I think it's slightly simpler. You have R Vaishali and Divya

Deshmukh really for the top two boards. I don't know how they'll swap it around. And then Koneru and Vantika - I think probably Humpy on third and Vantika on fourth. It seems more straightforward, but maybe they also want to juggle a bit," he said.

No foregone conclusion At the 2024 Olympiad, India were in rampaging form in the open section, scything through the field and losing just once in the 44 games they played over 11 rounds. This time around, India is not looking as imperious as two years ago.

Ask Anand if India can retain their Olympiad gold, and he says: "The gold was not asured even with that team in 2024. But an Olympiad always comes down to a few moments and some unpredictability. For

the same reason, it's very difficult to repeat."

However, he is not lacking in confidence in his compatriots.

"But I don't see a particular problem (in India winning gold again). Gukesh has had a difficult year and so on, but there's no reason why the curve doesn't turn again. I think there are other very good teams, Uzbekistan and the US certainly, and you also have a few other teams with lots of young players. The chess scene is exciting in general. I don't particularly have a prediction, but I've not given up on the Indian team."

These days, Anand is the FIDE interim president, but still enjoys playing in team events. He recently played in the German Bundesliga and the World Rapid and Blitz

Teams event. In a week's time, he will play on the top board for the PBC Alaskan Knights in the fourth season of the Global Chess League (GCL), after three seasons with the Ganges Grandmasters team.

"When you've decided to play, each event is something you look forward to, maybe, slightly more," Anand says before praising the buzz he experiences during the GCL. "It is fun being with team. The atmosphere in GCL is generally quite relaxed. The team normally looks after us very well."

He is technically from another era, but Anand would have enjoyed being part of the current Indian Olympiad team. "That thought about this in 2024 and this year as well. It's not possible, but why not? I think it would be a fun team."

Tanvi, 15, stuns two Top 100 players to win Pontianak IC



Tanvi Patri. **BAI**
Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

RANKED 132nd IN the world, Indian teenager Tanvi Patri stunned two Top 100 players on consecutive days to win the Pontianak International Challenge in Indonesia on Sunday. Yesterday in the semifinal, Tanvi knocked out top seed and world no 51 Rachel Chan of Canada defeating her 21-9, 21-19 in the straight. In the final today, she dominated world no 82 Kim Min Sun of South Korea.

The Indian shuttler won 21-5, 21-6 in just 32 minutes. This is first title of the season for Tanvi who had finished runners up at the Antica Singapore Challenge last week. One of the highest-rated teenagers in India, Tanvi spent her formative years training in China. PPFA coach Sagar Chopra said that Tanvi's strong technical base was evident from the outset. "She has trained in China, so she is technically very strong — everything, from her movement to court coverage to the sense of when to play a stroke. There are some shuttlers who are coached, think she won't reach, but she gets under them. This is something very rare in a 13-year-old," he told the *Indian Express* in an interview previously.

Panda Sisters win
At Lagos International Challenge, Indian women's doubles pair Rutuparna Panda and Swetaparna Panda defeated compatriots and top seed Kavipriya Selvam and Simran Singh to win their first title of the season.

The Panda sisters won the final in a 21-14, 25-23 in 45 minutes defeating the higher ranked Indian pair who recently played at the World Championships in New Delhi. Similarly to the women's doubles, the men's singles and mixed doubles were also all Indian finals. Gnana Dattu defeated Hmar Lalthazuala in the final 21-9, 22-20 to win his first international title of the season. In the mixed doubles, Satwik Reddy and Radhika Sharma retired in the third game of the final as Dhruv Rawat and Manisha K lifted the title. Dhruv and Manisha were leading 16-11 in the decider when the Indian pair retired.

One of the highest-rated teenagers in India, Tanvi spent her formative years training in China.

LEGEND LEFT EMOTIONAL

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

MIRKA FEDERER summed it up even before husband Roger took the stage. The titles, the records, the elegance, yet extraordinary, are only part of the Swiss legend's rich legacy. "What makes me proudest," he smiled on Sunday, is that Roger accomplished when he the world was watching. "It's who he is when nobody's watching." And thus when Roger was inducted into the International Tennis Hall of Fame in Newport, Rhode Island, it was a celebration of the remarkable career of the player who wielded his racquet like a wand. While the grace and effortless ease on court "never stopped amazing" Mirka, she was more impressed by the devoted father, kind husband, loving son and ever-present friend. Her moving introduction brought Roger to tears, and the

DEVELOPING AN 'INDIAN STYLE'

The apps and drills making India a doubles force in badminton

With 3 of India's last 6 Worlds medals coming in paired events, getting targeted coaching is paying off

Shivani Nair
Mumbai, August 30

'KOREAN DEFENCE' is a full-fledged drill that entire training sessions at Hyderabad's Pulla Gopichand badminton academy are devoted to, in recent years. It's fast-paced, low-crouched, relentless extending of rally in which hypnotic shuttle exchanges both unlock and unleash reflexes — for that the Operating System of doubles: speed, laced with power. While Taufik Hidayat, Lin Dan, Lee Chong Wei, Lee Hyun-il and Tai Tzu-ying were emulated for their game styles as singles legends, Korean doubles stalwart Lee Yong Dae and current World champs, Baek Ha Na and Lee So-hee, have been the gold standard in terms of footwork, stance, rhythm and racquet angles. Three of India's last six World Championship medals have come in doubles, and it reflects in the training lingo, the buzzwords, catchphrases and the actual court drills and off-court habits that are slowly ushering in a doubles culture.

Even the applications downloaded on phones are geared towards improving reflexes and mental agility needed in doubles. Treasa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand kept India's World Championships streak going with a bronze in Delhi, after taking over World Nos. 7 and 4 pairings on the way. But it's Satwik Reddy and Chiranjeev Shetty who deserve lion's share of the credit in placing doubles front and centre for completing a decade together with multiple achievements.

But with women's doubles also scoring its second Worlds medal for India now, the vocabulary and the lens with



India's World Championships bronze medal-winning pair of Treasa Jolly (R) and Gayatri Gopichand (L). **FILE**

which it got viewed is changing quickly. Badminton's next generation has arrived, and it speaks 'Doubles'.

Training the eye

On an average training day, it won't merely be the crowded court with 4-6 players engaged in fast exchanges, hooting, whistling and bantering about as doubles courts tend to be. Doubles shuttlers now have their eyes trained, with colour cones at four corners serving as cues for which shot to play and where on a verbal prompt. In another colour-coded drill, two different coloured shuttles are fed at fast clip with players required to play either attacking counter-drives and pushes or soft drops and cross-court blocks depending on the colour of the shuttle.

Spending nearly two months' training only on net dribbles might've sounded like an unconventional way to prepare for a World Championships, but much of the doubles coaching work going on at Hyderabad, in developing an 'In-

dian style', relies on Indian smarts and good hand skills to break down a rally while keeping pace with the East Asian speed on the flat drive game. So while the Korean style works on transitions from defence to offence with racquets redirecting the shuttle, India's top mixed doubles shuttler Tanisha Crasto adds that they are using tennis balls bouncing off walls and ground for plain reflex activations. BlazePods or digital reaction lights are deployed where during a flat-drive or mid-court monotone passage of play, the players have to stay alert to randomly flashing lights of their designated colour. This increases peripheral alertness because so much is happening in a doubles game at the same time. "Building reflexes and reducing reaction times is the goal. We all have different games, but I use the 'One Brain' app on my phone for reflex training," Tanisha says.

Changing culture

Doubles often faces the prob-

lem of Indian parents pushing their wards towards singles because they don't want to deal with partnership hassles. So while increasing depth after trusting coaches and stepping back is just the first step, the real doubles struggle starts after committing to a partner. "I've served and received to tally different from singles," coach Sumeeth Reddy explains. The assortment of wicked serves — tumble, straight, fast, legal-spin and flick — get deservedly disproportionate time as coach Gopichand ominously says, "You will see a bunch of Indians honing those serves and using them."

The drives-game (flat parallel) is something that's not seen in singles, but is on the menu in doubles. Attack-defence also means two vastly different things in doubles than singles. "In singles, you are looking for gaps. Doubles is not about finding gaps," Sumeeth says. "It's about sensing which opponent is slow or tentative on the day, and targeting them with the right attack."

The nature of the nemesis has undergone a change too. The training courts in Hyderabad that a decade ago were devoted to solving the Vilhan Wang puzzle for Saina-Sindhu, now have Liu Shengshu and Tan Ning on their dartboard. "It's not good when you lose to them," Treasa says, adding every loss has given the Indians enough arsenal to strike the next time, but deciphering the Tan tumble-serve and devious counters will happen in training.

"It's a matter of time. We just need to believe we can beat those players," she says of the 1-7 head-to-head against the dominant World No. 1s, who won silver in Delhi. "We both are here to do something big," Treasa says of what drives her and Gayatri, a pairing that many clamoured to split up and disregard before the bronze.

Five of the last six World Championships medals for India have now come from the Hyderabad training base; three in doubles. India's doubles DNA is commensurately changing.

BRIEFLY



Cole Palmer (centre) celebrates with teammates after scoring. **AP**

Palmer scores for Chelsea in second straight Premier League win

COLE PALMER showed more signs of a return to his top form by completing the scoring for Chelsea in their wild 4-3 win over Brighton in the Premier League on Sunday. In front of England coach Thomas Tuchel, Palmer ran 30 metres before curling home a shot from the edge of the area for Chelsea's fourth goal at Stamford Bridge to end Brighton's realistic hopes of a comeback in an end-to-end thriller. Romeo Lavia and Pedro Neto put Chelsea 2-0 ahead in the 14th minute before Joao Pedro added a third in the 32nd for Xabi Alonso's team. Malik Valcouye pulled a goal back for Brighton just before halftime, and the visitors further reduced the deficit when Pedro deflected a cross from Pascal Gross into his own net in the 63rd. Palmer's goal clinched a second straight victory for Chelsea, who opened their league campaign by beating Fulham 3-2. Palmer scored in that game, too. **AP**

Nabi to play three matches for Surrey

AUQIB NABI left for the UK to play three matches for Surrey in the County Championship Division One with an eye on India's tour of New Zealand in October. The Jammu and Kashmir pacer was recently drafted into the Indian squad as a replacement for the injured Jasprit Bumrah in the two-Test series in Sri Lanka but did not get a chance to make his debut. **PTI**

Messi nets four goals as Miami rout Montreal

LIONEL MESSI scored thrice in the second half to finish off his first post-goal effort in MLS play while adding an assist, and Inter Miami scored six unanswered goals in a 7-1 romp over CF Montreal. Messi snapped a 1-1 tie in the 40th minute when he found the net for the 15th time, and scored again in the 52nd, 83rd minutes and in stoppage time. **AP**

Ruparelia, Negi win India Junior GP titles

DEV RUPARELIA and Ishita Negi won the boys' and girls' titles, respectively, at the India Junior International Badminton Grand Prix, while Pavan and Punith Suresh claimed the boys' doubles crown in Pune. Ruparelia beat Nishchal Chand 21-16, 21-16 in the boys' final and Negi beat Maharastra's Gatha Suryawanshi 21-19, 21-18 in the girls' final. **PTI**

Abhay wins 13th PSA Tour title in Malaysia

TOP SEED Abhay Singh clinched the Tuantu Mndir Trophy squash event, a USD 15,000 PSA Challenger event in Negeri Sembilan, Malaysia, defeating third seed Henry Leung of Hong Kong in five games. World no. 24 Singh defeated Leung, ranked 59 in the world, 11-7 11-3 11-11 11-5 12-10 to bag his 13th PSA Tour title in 18 finals. **PTI**

Germany make sole chance count to down Spain, bag fourth World Cup

British Raj
New Delhi, August 30

"IT WAS painful," Spain men's hockey team skipper Marc Miralles said with a smile after defending champions Germany defeated his side 1-0 to retain the Hockey World Cup title.

If one looks at the numbers of the final, it indeed appears painful as Spain did everything right on paper, except finishing the chances created. Spain had double the circle entries (24 as compared to Germany's 12), almost double the number of shots (9 as compared to 5), and more penalty corner chances. However, Germany took the only viable chance they

had and Michel Struthoff scored the most memorable goal among his eight international strikes to hand the Germans their fourth world title.

"Before the tournament, everyone was saying: Germany this year? No. Everybody was talking about the other teams but we showed what we are capable of," quipped Christopher Rühr, who is a two-time world champion now.

With their fourth title, Germany are tied with Pakistan for most hockey World Cups (WCs). Interestingly, Pakistan's last WC title came in 1994, eight years before Germany won their first title in 2002.

After losing to India in the



Germany now have four World Cup titles in hockey. **FIH**

bronze medal match at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021, the German team has gone on to win

two world titles, an Olympic silver, and a European title. This is Andre Hanning's fourth major

title as a coach since he took over the head coach role in 2022.

Playing against Spain, who had stunned Olympic champions Netherlands in the semis, Germany sat deep in their half and absorbed everything Spain threw at them. Pol Cabre and Jose Basterra were brilliant on the flanks, regularly finding pockets to create chances, but the German defence stood strong.

At the half-time break, both teams were goalless.

In the third quarter, Spain amped up the attack and played beautiful and fluid hockey. But ironically, despite ten circle entries and three shots on target, it was Germany's one circle entry

in the quarter that decided the World Cup final.

The German right and left flanks co-ordinated into almost poetic motion in the 44th minute. Michel popped on the baseline to receive a pass from the midfield, moved from left to right, dodging one Spanish defender and rounding up goalkeeper Luis Calza before simply lifting the ball into the net.

With the lead in hand, the German team put their bodies on the line to protect it. As captain Miralles flicked from the penalty corner, it hit Germany's first rusher, Prinz Thies, who had to leave the field.

In the final quarter, Spain

threw everything they had but the German defence held firm. Coach Max Caldas replaced goalkeeper Calza with four minutes remaining to put an outfielder but the Germans were resolute.

Miralles said that the German team understood the tempo better. "We had so many chances. But they understood the tempo of the game better," he said.

"They were unbelievably tough to beat," Rühr said before adding that the celebrations will go on till next week.

Fairly so; they deserve it after equalizing one of the most dominant records in the world of hockey.

Federer's love for the sport comes out during induction to Tennis Hall of Fame

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 30

MIRKA FEDERER summed it up even before husband Roger took the stage. The titles, the records, the elegance, yet extraordinary, are only part of the Swiss legend's rich legacy. "What makes me proudest," he smiled on Sunday, is that Roger accomplished when he the world was watching. "It's who he is when nobody's watching." And thus when Roger was inducted into the International Tennis Hall of Fame in Newport, Rhode Island, it was a celebration of the remarkable career of the player who wielded his racquet like a wand. While the grace and effortless ease on court "never stopped amazing" Mirka, she was more impressed by the devoted father, kind husband, loving son and ever-present friend. Her moving introduction brought Roger to tears, and the

emotions resurfaced throughout his subsequent speech. He kept using humour to lighten the moment, joking in between that his speech might go on till sunrise given the lengthy tear breaks. Though he has now joined the Hall of Fame, Federer said fame was never his objective; he was motivated by his love for the sport.

"We play tennis, we're tennis players. That for me is what it's about: the sense of play," Federer added. "Yes, this sport takes work and practice. But the sense of play always carried me through. And when the work and play blend together, that's the best feeling in the world."

In his 28-minute address, Federer took his audience on a nostalgic, vicarious ride, right from his days as a 13-year-old ballboy to the 103 ATP titles, acknowledging the roles played by friends, adversaries and mentors along the way. Thanking every body who

stood through his matches, Federer shared his own thrill at witnessing stars go up on stage.

"I'll never forget how the game looked from there and how it felt. The thrill of standing so close to the players, feeling them the ball, handing them the towel, seeing them sweat, watching them fight it out, figuring out the adversity, the intensity," the Swiss maestro said.

He then described his playing journey, on which he embarked as a three-year-old. Federer said he started with double-handed forehands and backhands as a kid, a far cry from his famous one-handed whiplash of a backhand in his professional days.

Not him alone

He reiterated the importance of the supporting acts that make up the tennis ecosystem. "Tennis is never about the players alone. It's the moms and dads like mine taking their kids



Roger Federer with his wife Mirka at the induction ceremony. **AP**

to matches, cheering them on. It's coaches who teach children how to win and how to bounce back when they lose. It's people who sweep the courts or pick up the balls. It's young players like me who get a chance to be a ball kid. And also, by the way, it's all linespeople," he added.

Emotions got overwhelming for Federer halfway through his speech, when he spoke about Stefan Edberg, who "provided huge personal inspiration for the everyday grind on the tour". He choked up again when speaking about his longtime coach Severin Luthi, before hewent on to thank Mirka, calling her "my coach, hitting partner, reality check and stylist". Federer said he was "in-

"I'm still writing my love letter to tennis. My time as a player is done, but tennis will always stand at the intersection of everything I care most about: my family, our friendships, the past 40 years, the future we're building."

ROGER FEDERER

AT HIS HALL OF FAME INDUCTION

credibly lucky" to have played with different generations of tennis players, from Andre Agassi and Lleyton Hewitt to Andre Roddick, and then Rafael Nadal and Novak Djokovic. He sprinkled some more humour

by way of the number of headbands and socks he expended.

"I'm talking about the numbers that really paint a picture. Between 1998 and when I first went on the ATP Tour, and when I retired in 2022, I wore more than 5,000 headbands," said Federer. "That's more than (Bjorn) Borg and (John) McEnroe combined. And if you think that's impressive, I wore probably over 7,000 pairs of socks. That's probably twice as many as most of my opponents, because I doubled them up," he said.

While jokingly asking for tissues and sunglasses "to protect" himself, Federer delivered the ultimate punchline: "I'm still writing my love letter to tennis. My time as a player is done, but tennis will always stand at the intersection of everything I care most about: my family, our friendships, the past 40 years, the future we're building. "Tennis for me is responsible for it all."

Pegula shakes off nerves to win opening match

New York: Jessica Pegula shook off nerves that contributed to a slow start against Elena Gabriela Ruse, winning her opening match at the U.S. Open on Sunday in straight sets. Leading off at Arthur Ashe Stadium, the American missed her first nine opportunities to break Ruse but found a rhythm and began dominating. Pegula won 92% of the first-serve points on the way to a 6-3, 6-2 victory in 83 minutes. 19th seeded Jasmine Paolini also advanced in women's singles, defeating Veronika Erjavec 6-3, 3-6, 6-4. Kamilla Rakhimova beat No. 27 seed Barbara Krejciakova 7-6 (4), 6-2. **ASSOCIATED PRESS**